



GOVERNMENT OF INDIA



BRICS
INDIA 2026

BUILDING FOR RESILIENCE, INNOVATION,
COOPERATION AND SUSTAINABILITY

BRICS SUMMIT

12 - 13 September 2026

New Delhi, India

People-Centric
Approach
Spirit of
Humanity First



CBC 14129/13/0016/2627

Play, create, stay active: PM to students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has urged teachers to remain vigilant against student drug addiction and help children tackle excessive screen time through sports, physical play, and creative activities.

Interacting with the national award-winning teachers on Friday, the eve of Teachers' Day, Prime Minister Modi also urged the teachers to preserve childhood and nurture children's natural curiosity.

He said teachers should share creative approaches to make classroom learning more engaging. A video of the interaction at the Prime Minister's Lok Kalyan Marg residence was released on Saturday. The Prime Minister emphasised that teachers need to look beyond the academic performance of children and be attentive to their behaviour and everyday lives.

He said teachers have an increasingly important role to play in the lives of children now that there are fewer

Prime Minister Narendra Modi interacts with children as he travels by Delhi Metro en route to Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC) for its centenary celebrations in New Delhi

PTI

joint family set-ups. On drugs, Modi said that in some big cities and universities, it is difficult to identify if anyone is affected by the problem, as no one knows who gives whom what.

"In these circumstances, teachers should take the initiative for awareness and also observe minutely if any change (in behaviour) is

witnessed in any child," he said. The PM said the teachers should enter the lives of the students, going beyond books and syllabuses.

"You should not allow the childhood of a student to die. The biggest contribution can be given by the teachers by keeping childhood alive in students' lives," PM said.

Modi also talked about how teachers can keep the students away from long hours of screen time and encourage them towards outdoor sports activities. The Prime Minister said children have the same basic nature and curiosity, and if teachers nurture and channelise this curiosity, they can make a signifi-

INDIA TRANSFORMED IN 13 YEARS: PM MODI

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday launched a full-scale offensive against the Opposition for misguiding the youth after he assumed the mantle at the Centre and highlighted India's economic growth and contrasted the country's current position with the situation in 2013. These strong remarks came against the backdrop of recent protests by Gen Z and his determined effort to reach out to them, dispelling doubts about his leadership.

Addressing the centenary celebrations of the prestigious Sri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC), he referred to the economic

and political situation at the time. Modi said, "There is a gang that will take what I am saying, break it into small pieces and put it in my account. So, let me warn you about this. Let me tell you what used to dominate the media during that period in 2013. For example, Indian soldiers were being killed along the LoC. The current generation may find it surprising; perhaps they may wonder, "Did this really happen?" Yes, it did.

The Prime Minister began by referring to his earlier speech, which he said had been discussed and watched again in recent days.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Subhash Chandra booked in ₹1,322 cr LICHL loan case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has filed an FIR against Essel Group chairman Subhash Chandra and others. They are accused of inflating Chandra's personal net worth to secure two loans worth ₹980 crore from LIC Housing Finance Ltd. These loans later defaulted, leading to a reported loss of over ₹1,322 crore for the public-sector lender. LICHL filed the complaint on August 31.

The agency registered the case on the same day, alleging criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust, and related offences. Officials said the loans were approved in 2018 based on Chandra's ongoing personal guarantees and two net worth certificates that listed him as extremely wealthy.

The first loan of ₹500 crore was given to Vasant Sagar Properties Pvt Ltd, with Pan India Infraprojects Pvt Ltd as co-borrower. It was described as a home-entity loan for takeover, top-up, and business expansion. Chandra provided a continuing guarantee

letter on March 28, 2018. That same day, DIM & Co issued a certificate stating his net worth was about \$6,197.62 million, or ₹59,113.21 crore, as of March 31, 2017.

The second loan of ₹480 crore went to Digital Subscriber Management and Consultancy Services Pvt Ltd, with Spirit Infrapower and Multiventures Pvt Ltd as co-borrowers. This was a rental-discounting loan under a securitisation scheme. Chandra gave a continuing guarantee on August 10, 2018. MPJ & Co issued a second certificate on July 6, 2018, stating his net worth was ₹40,562 crore. Both accounts later became irregular.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Jantar Mantar case: Bhardwaj remanded to police custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Patiala House Court on Saturday remanded self-styled influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj to one-day police custody in connection with the alleged assault on Sanjay, the father of a teenage Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) activist, during a protest at Jantar Mantar in July.

Bhardwaj was produced at the residence of Additional Sessions Judge Saurabh Pratap Singh Laler at around 2 pm. His legal aid counsel appeared before the judge through video-conferencing. Bhardwaj was originally expected to be produced physically in the Patiala House courts.

Supporters of Swatantra Bhardwaj stage a protest outside Parliament Street police station in New Delhi

The development came as security was tightened outside the Parliament Street police station after supporters of Bhardwaj gathered there to stage a protest. Barricades were put up at strategic points around the police station and paramilitary personnel were deployed as a precautionary measure, a police officer said.

Advocate Rishav Ranjan, the counsel representing Nishu Azad (victim's daughter), termed the development "strange", as he questioned the manner in which Bhardwaj was produced before the Court.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Yasir, left, a terrorist of banned Lashkar-e-Taiba who was killed in an encounter with the army in the higher reaches of Yusmarg in Budgam district

PTI

Terrorist killed in J&K's Budgam linked to LeT

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Police on Saturday identified the terrorist killed in a joint operation in central Kashmir's Budgam district as Yasir, a Pakistani national affiliated with the banned Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terrorist outfit.

The slain terrorist is believed to have been involved in the ambush of an IAF convoy in Poonch and an attack on army and civilian workers in 2024.

Meanwhile, massive searches were going on at an altitude of 12,000 to 15,000 feet to track down the footprints of the second terrorist in the Pir Panjal range. According to the officials, the encounter site is nearly six hours from the

Doodhpathri area of Budgam and is extremely isolated.

Security agencies described the elimination as a significant blow to the group's remaining network in the Pir Panjal belt. So far, three out of four LeT terrorists hiding in the upper reaches of Kashmir have been eliminated, and a massive hunt is going on in the forested area of Budgam to neutralise the lone surviving terrorist of the same group.

In a post on X, J&K Police on Saturday said, "You can run, but you can't hide! The terrorist neutralised during Op Ashdar has been identified as Yasir, a Pakistani national of Lashkar-e-Taiba."

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Delhi waterlogged after heavy rain, NH-48 inundated

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Several parts of Delhi were submerged on Saturday after heavy rain, with roads disappearing beneath knee-deep water and traffic slowing to a crawl, following heavy showers a day earlier. The downpour left the National Highway-48 between Indira Gandhi International Airport and Dhaula Kuan inundated. Several airlines have issued advisories to passengers on their way to the Indira Gandhi International Airport

(IGIA). Delhi Airport authorities said flight operations were normal as of Saturday morning.

Heavy waterlogging was also reported around the Palam airport tunnel and Neem Chowk Road in Sangam Vihar. Shakarpur, Laxmi Nagar, and Mehrauli-Badarpur Road witnessed waterlogging, while several stretches in Sangam Vihar were inundated. Mahipalpur saw particularly severe waterlogging, with vehicles struggling to wade through water and children splashing

A cyclist wades through a waterlogged Baba Kharak Singh Road following heavy rainfall in New Delhi on Saturday

PTI

on flooded stretches. Heavy waterlogging was reported at Terminal 3 of the Indira Gandhi International Airport.

As heavy rains hit the city, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta conducted a surprise inspection of waterlogged areas

near Sadbhavna Park in East Delhi. During the inspection, she assessed areas prone to waterlogging, reviewed the cleanliness of major roads, and received updates on the water drainage system and the challenges posed by the ongoing rains.

"She directed officials to immediately deploy pumps and other necessary resources in waterlogged areas and ensure swift clearance of accumulated water," the Chief Minister's Office said in a statement.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

13 years on, 10 convicted in Jhiram Valley Maoist attack

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

On Saturday, a Special National Investigation Agency (NIA) court in Jagdalpur, Chhattisgarh, convicted all ten people accused in the 2013 Jhiram Valley Maoist attack. This attack is considered one of the most serious incidents of left-wing extremism in the state. It happened on 25 May 2013 and led to the deaths of twenty-nine people, including senior Congress leaders Vidya Charan Shukla and Mahendra Karma. The loss of these

leaders came at a crucial time, ahead of the assembly elections, and severely impacted the party's leadership in Chhattisgarh.

Judge Ajay Singh Rajput has set the sentencing for 16

September. Defence lawyer Arvind Choudhary confirmed the convictions and said the accused will appeal in the High Court once they receive the judgment.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

India backs UN push to redraw world map more accurately

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
AGENCIES
■ New Delhi/New York

School classrooms across the world may soon do away with the distortions in the old map shrinking the size of Africa, Latin America and South Asia after the United Nations (UN) has overwhelmingly adopted a resolution backed by India. It aimed at correcting the world map to promote a "more accurate representation" of continental landmasses. The United States was the lone country to vote against it.

On the world map, at present, Greenland and Africa look about the same

size. In reality, Greenland covers 2.16 million sq km. Africa covers 30.3 million, nearly 14 times as much. Even India, at 3.29 million sq km, is bigger than Greenland, but the maps as

of now suggest otherwise. The UN resolution adopted late on Friday noted that the Mercator projection, designed in the 16th century for navigational purposes, remains widely used

in educational, media, digital and official materials, despite the considerable distortion of landmasses to the North and South, far from the equator.

The resolution also noted with "concern" that "this distortion contributes to minimising the perceived sizes of Africa, Latin America and South Asia, and perpetuating an unbalanced view of the world." The resolution is not binding. It does not redraw borders and leaves Mercator's map in place for shipping and aviation.

The 193-member UN General Assembly adopted the resolution "Correct the map": rebalancing global cartographic representa-

tion and promoting equitable representation of the world's regions, particularly Africa.

The resolution was sponsored by Togo, receiving 164 votes in favour, with abstentions from Estonia, Georgia, Lithuania, Moldova, Serbia and Ukraine, and a lone vote against from the United States.

In an explanation of the vote in the General Assembly, First Secretary at the Permanent Mission of India to the UN, Raghuo Puri, said India "welcomes" the intention behind the resolution to promote more accurate and representative cartographic practices.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Population Census to begin in four States from December 1

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

Population enumeration for Census 2027 will take place in Goa, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and parts of Uttarakhand from December 1, 2026, to January 4, 2027, the Registrar General of India said on Saturday, keeping in mind the election schedule of these States.

These four States are all set to go to Assembly elections in February, which is usually the month when population enumeration is held. Manipur is the fifth one which is scheduled to go to polls during the same time, but the Census operations in the State have been halted due to demands for preparing a National Registry of Citizens. The terms of the State Assemblies of Goa, Manipur, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand will end by May 2027.

In a gazette notification, the Registrar General of India (RGI) and Census Commissioner of India, Mrityunjay Kumar Narayan, said the citizens in these areas can avail the option for

self-enumeration from November 16 to November 30, 2026.

"The conduct of the Census of the population shall be undertaken in the States of Goa, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and areas other than snow-bound areas of the State of Uttarakhand, from 1st December, 2026 to 4th January, 2027 with a revisional round from 5th January, 2027 to 9th January, 2027," the notification said.

The reference date for Census 2027 for Goa, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and Uttarakhand, other than snow-bound areas of the State, shall be 00:00 hours of January 5, 2027.

"For the Union territory of Ladakh and snow-bound non-synchronous areas of the Union territory of Jammu and Kashmir and the snow-bound non-synchronous areas of the states of Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand, the reference date shall be 00:00 hours of the 1st day of October, 2026," it added.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

NIA files chargesheet against 13 in Ghaziabad espionage case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency has filed charges against 13 people in the Ghaziabad Espionage Case.

They are accused of entering restricted sites, planting spy cameras, and sending geo-tagged photos and videos of sensitive locations to contacts in Pakistan. Investigators also say the group helped these contacts based in Pakistan to get and use Indian SIM cards.

The chargesheet was filed before the Special Court NIA, Lucknow, under Sections 61(2) and 152 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023; Sections 3 and 5 of the Official Secrets Act; and Sections 13, 17, and 18 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). The accused named are Praveen, Raj Valmiki, Shiva Valmiki, Ritik Gangwar, Sameer alias Shooter, Durgesh Nishad, Naushad, Gagan Kumar, Vivek, Shivraj, Meera Thakur and Shane Iram alias Mahak. A Detailed Investigation



Report against five juveniles was submitted to the Juvenile Justice Board in Ghaziabad on 18 May 2026. The case began as FIR No. 76/2026, registered on 14 March 2026 at Kaushambi Police Station in Ghaziabad. It was filed under the BNS and the Official Secrets Act, with Section 18 of the UAPA added later. So far, 21 people have been arrested. The investigation is still ongoing for others involved.

According to the NIA, the accused conspired to harm India's sovereignty, unity, and integrity. They are said to have entered important restricted areas, set up cameras, and sent location-tagged images and videos abroad. The group also helped supply Indian SIM cards and collect exact GPS coordinates of sensitive sites. The agency called the combination of illegal entry, secret recording, and the

sending of information abroad a threat to national security. The press release does not mention the enemy country, name the sites, list what was recovered, or explain how the network was discovered. For now, the official record shows charges under the Official Secrets Act (OSA), conspiracy, and UAPA against a group accused of combining local access with direction from the handlers based in the

enemy country.

By filing both an adult chargesheet and a juvenile report, investigators showed they saw this as a coordinated operation, not just separate incidents. Adding the UAPA after the first FIR suggests the investigation expanded from just unauthorised photography to possible involvement in a bigger conspiracy.

The method described by the NIA is not new. Local helpers gather visual information that foreign agents cannot easily get on their own. Using spy cameras means they do not need to stay in one place for long. Geo-tags make regular photos useful for targeting.

Indian SIM cards allow handlers to communicate within the country, making it harder to trace them immediately. The focus on "precise GPS coordinates" shows this was more than just casual photography. One arrest against 13 names in this chargesheet, and five juveniles, implies that other

adults remain in custody or are being questioned.

The agency says the investigation is ongoing, so more arrests or another chargesheet could follow. The NIA's statement is brief as usual, listing names, laws, the alleged conspiracy, and the ongoing investigation. The public core of the allegation is nevertheless clear.

A group of Indian nationals is accused of crossing into restricted zones, planting cameras, filming sensitive sites, attaching coordinates and sending the product to an enemy-linked recipient while also supplying SIM cards.

The state has responded with a combined chargesheet under the new criminal code, the Official Secrets Act, and the UAPA. For now, 13 adults are facing a special court, and five juveniles are before the Juvenile Justice Board because their actions are said to have threatened the nation's sovereignty, unity, integrity, and security.

HC slaps ₹1 lakh fine for 32-year wage battle

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has imposed ₹1 lakh as costs on the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) for pursuing litigation against a bus conductor for 32 years over the payment of back wages for 17 months, terming it an abuse of the process of law.

Dismissing the DTC's appeal against a 2004 industrial tribunal's order in the conductor's favour, Justice Amit Mahajan said the department's "continued litigation" for such an "inordinately long period" was an avoidable expenditure of public money. In the order passed on September 2, the judge said DTC was at liberty to recover the cost from the officer responsible for pursuing such an "insignificant dispute".

The case arose from an alleged failure of the bus conductor to issue tickets to three passengers despite taking the due fare of ₹67 from them in November 1994. "The manner in which the

present proceedings have been pursued, despite the limited nature of the claim, warrants imposition of costs upon the concerned officers," Justice Mahajan said in the order.

"Accordingly, costs of ₹1,00,000/- shall be paid by the petitioner Department, out of which ₹25,000/- shall be paid to the DHLSC; ₹50,000/- to the PM Relief Fund; and ₹25,000/- to the Respondent (conductor)," the order said. After the alleged incident, the conductor was placed under suspension, but despite the enquiry officer ruling in his favour, the disciplinary authority disagreed and issued a show-cause notice for his removal from service.

The disciplinary authority subsequently removed him from service with effect from August 1996, which was set aside in appeal by the DTC Chairman-cum-Managing Director. In 1998, the DTC Chairman directed that the conductor be reinstated in service without back wages and reduced pay scale.

118 teachers felicitated; CM vows to fix school infrastructure gaps

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Saturday felicitated around 118 teachers and principals with state awards on Teachers' Day, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta saying the Government is working to improve education in the city by addressing gaps in school infrastructure as well as curriculum. Addressing the Shikshak Mahakumbh Award event 2026 at Thyagraj Stadium, she said the Government aimed to take education to "great heights", but it had to begin by addressing basic facilities in schools. "We want to take education to great heights and make a lot of progress, but the previous Governments did not do anything in 12 years.

So, after coming to power, we have had to start working from a very low level," she said. The chief minister said the Government was working on repairing toilets, ensuring water facilities, maintenance, whitewashing and other repair works in schools.

"Many schools had very poor toilet facilities. Once, I went for an inspection to a very good and reputed school, which the previous Government used to boast about. When I saw it, there was no gate in the toilet. How would our girl students have been using it?" she said.

A total of 118 teachers were honoured in different categories. These included 20 HoSSs, 69 teachers from DoE and MCD schools, and teachers from three CM Shri



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta during the Teachers' Maha Kumbh – State Teachers Award 2026 in New Delhi

Schools. Librarians, special educators and sports teachers, among others who have made notable contributions in different areas of education, were also honoured.

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood, Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra, MP Bansuri Swaraj, MLAs Abhay Verma, Neeraj Basoya and Chandan Kumar Chaudhary,

among several other public representatives, Education Department Director Ankita Anand, senior officials, and teachers, principals, vice-principals, students and other dignitaries from various schools were present at the event.

The Chief Minister said teachers are the strong foundation of society. They do not merely impart text-

book knowledge to students, but also instill values, skills, confidence, a sense of duty and the right direction in life. A teacher's influence does not remain limited to an individual student, but contributes to shaping an entire generation.

"As long as our Government is in power, all good work concerning the education and future of children will be undertaken, and even more good work will be done. Whatever deficiencies remain will be fulfilled," she said.

The chief minister said 170 modern language labs are being established in Delhi's schools to strengthen students' language and communication skills. These include 70 CM Shri Schools and 100 other Government schools.

Civic body honours 13 teachers for excellence in education on Teachers' Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), chairperson Manoj Kumar Dwivedi conferred the prestigious NDMC Teachers' Award 2026 upon 13 outstanding teachers, comprising 08 awardees from Atal Adarsh Vidyalayas and 05 awardees from Navyug Schools, in recognition of their valuable contribution towards nurturing students and strengthening the quality of education in NDMC schools.

On the occasion of Teachers' Day, NDMC organised the "NDMC Teachers' Award 2026" Ceremony at Navyug School, Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi to honour



and recognise teachers who have demonstrated exceptional dedication, commitment and exemplary service in the field of education.

After felicitating the teachers on the occasion of teachers' day, Dwivedi extended his warmest congratulations to all 13 awardees and acknowledges their invaluable contribution to the educational

ecosystem of New Delhi. Addressing the teachers, Dwivedi said that "Honouring teachers is not merely a recognition of their dedication and contribution in the education; it also boosts the confidence and morale of the students they nurture. After parents- teachers hold one of the most important places in our lives.

MODI RUBBER LIMITED
CIN: L25199UP1971PLC003392

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NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that the 53rd Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the members of Modi Rubber Limited ("Company") will be held on Wednesday, the 30th September, 2026 at 11:30 a.m. (IST) through Video Conferencing ("VC")/ Other Audiovisual Means ("OAVM") facility provided by Mas Services Limited to transact the business set out in the Notice convening the AGM.

Notice of AGM and Annual Report: We are pleased to inform you that, The 53rd Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of **MODI RUBBER LIMITED** is scheduled to be convened on **Wednesday, 30th September, 2026 at 11:30**. Indian Standard Time ("IST") through Video Conferencing ("VC")/ Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM") mode, in compliance with the General circular nos. 14/2020 dated April 8, 2020, 17/2020 dated April 13, 2020, 20/2020 dated May 5, 2020, 09/2024 dated September 19, 2024 and subsequent circulars including the latest General Circular No. 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025, (collectively referred to as "MCA Circulars") Circular Nos. SEBI/ HO/CFD/CFD-PDD-2/P/CIR/2024/133 dated October 3, 2024 and the circulars issued earlier in this regard by Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") and SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("Listing Regulations") to transact the businesses as set out in the AGM Notice.

The Notice setting out the business to be transacted at the AGM together with the Integrated Annual Report of the Company for the year 2025-26 has been sent on 05.09.2026 through electronic mode only to the members whose email address is registered with the Company / Depository Participant(s). The Notice and the Integrated Annual Report are also available on the Company's website at www.modirubberlimited.com & on website of Stock Exchanges, at www.bseindia.com & www.nseindia.com.

E-voting: The Company is providing to the members, the facility to cast their vote(s) on the business as set out in the Notice of the AGM through remote e-voting facility ("remote e-voting") as well as during the AGM to those members who could not cast their vote(s) by remote voting. **Members are requested to note the following:**

- the company has fixed 23rd September 2026 as the 'Cut Off date' to ascertain the eligibility of members to vote by remote e-voting or by e-voting at the AGM.
- A person, whose name is recorded in the register of members or in the register of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on the cut-off date i.e. 23rd September 2026 only, shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting or for participation and voting at the AGM.
- the remote e-voting period shall be available as under:
Commencement of remote e-voting : from 09:00 a.m.(IST) on Sunday 27th September 2026
End of remote e-voting : till 05:00 pm (IST) on Tuesday, 29th September 2026
- any person, who acquires shares of the Company and becomes a member of the Company after dispatch of the Notice and holds shares as on the cut-off date, may obtain the login ID and password. by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.co.in However, if the person is already registered with NSDL for remote e-voting then he/she can use their existing User ID and password for casting the vote.
- the members who have cast their vote by remote e-voting prior to the AGM can also attend/ participate in the AGM through VC / OAVM but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again at the AGM.
- the remote e-voting module shall be disabled by NSDL after 5.00 p.m. (IST) on 29th September 2026. The votes once cast by the member, cannot be changed subsequently.
- those members, who intend to participate in the AGM through VC / OAVM facility and could not cast their vote on the resolutions through remote e-voting and are otherwise not barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through e-voting during the AGM.
- the manner of voting for members holding shares in dematerialized mode, physical mode and for members who have not registered their email address has been provided in the Notice of the AGM. The notice will also be available on the website of the Company at www.modirubberlimited.com Members are requested to carefully read all the Notes set out in the Notice of the AGM with respect to instructions for joining the AGM, manner of casting vote etc. Contact details: In case of any queries relating to e-voting, the members may refer to the FAQs for members and e-voting user manual for members available at the download section of www.evoting.nsdl.com or call on toll free no.: 1800-222-990 or send a request at evoting@nsdl.co.in.

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By order of the Board of Directors
Sd/-
(S K Bajpai)
Head – Legal & Company Secretary

SOUTH EASTERN COALFIELDS LIMITED
"A MINI RATNA COMPANY"

NOTICE

All the tenders issued by SECL for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on website of SECL <http://www.secl-cil.in>, CIL e-procurement portal <http://coallindiatenders.nic.in> and Central Public Procurement Portal <http://eprocure.gov.in> In addition, procurement is also done through GeM portal <http://gem.gov.in>. SECL's mining services tenders are also now available on GeM portal <http://gem.gov.in>

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Ziya Ur Rahman S/o Hifzur Rahman Khan R/o-58, Mohalla Baroon Saray, Jama Masjid, Sardhana, Meerut have changed my name to Ziyaur Rahman Khan.
I, Sonali, W/o No.10437939Y Hav Shewale Rajendra Shamrao, R/o- Vill- Sakora, Tal- Nandgaon, Dist- Nashik, Maharashtra, my name & D.O.B is wrongly recorded as Sonali (15.05.1986) in my husband's record whereas my correct name & D.O.B is Sonali Rajendra Shewale (30.12.1989) which may be amended accordingly.
I, No.4577414N Hav Clik (SD) Arvind Singh Yadav, R/o- Vill & PO- Kori, Teh- Sakaldhi, Dist- Chandauli, U.P, have changed my Daughter's name from Arshi Shrirudra to Arshi Sri Rudra, vide affidavit dated 05/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, No.14857633K SEP Patel Ankikumar Amrutbhai, R/o- At Navaghara Balisana, Ta Prantij, Dist. Sabarkantha, Gujarat- 383205, have changed my son's name in my service record from Vivan to Vivan Ankikumar Patel, vide affidavit dated 17.08.2026 before Notary Public Gujarat.
I, No.4577414N Hav Clik (SD) Arvind Singh Yadav, R/o- Vill & PO- Kori, Teh- Sakaldhi, Dist- Chandauli, U.P, have changed my Daughter's name from Arshi Shrirudra to Aranya Sri Rudra, vide affidavit dated 05/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, No.14857633K SEP Patel Ankikumar Amrutbhai, R/o- At Navaghara Balisana, Ta Prantij, Dist. Sabarkantha, Gujarat- 383205, have changed my son's name in my service record from Vivan to Vivan Ankikumar Patel, vide affidavit dated 17.08.2026 before Notary Public Gujarat.

I, Anil Kumar Singh S/o Shatrudhan Singh, R/o- RZ I-116, I Block, Som Bazar Wali Gali, Mahavir Enclave-I, Palam Village, South West Delhi, Delhi - 110045, declare that in my children's some documents my name is mentioned as Anil Singh whereas my correct name is Anil Kumar Singh, both are one & same person.
I, Heenakausr, W/o No.17012047N Hav Areepahmad Nadaf, R/o- Vill & PO- Teerth, Teh- Athani, Dist- Belagavi, Karnataka- 591304 have changed my name from Heenakausr to Heenakausr Areepahmad Nadaf, vide affidavit dated 04/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, Radhakisan Narsing Kavhale, Mother of No.17014094M Hav Kavhale Amol Radhakisan, R/o- At Mahartakli, PO- Ardhapimpri, Teh- Gevrai, Dist- Beed, Maharashtra- 431130, declare that in my son's service record my D.O.B. is wrongly recorded as 05/06/1972 whereas my correct D.O.B is 01/01/1967 which may be amended accordingly.
I, Hirabai Radhakisan Kavhale, Mother of No.17014094M Hav Kavhale Amol Radhakisan, R/o- At Mahartakli, PO- Ardhapimpri, Teh- Gevrai, Dist- Beed, Maharashtra- 431130, declare that in my son's service record my D.O.B. is wrongly recorded as 10/03/1975 whereas my correct D.O.B is 01/01/1971 which may be amended accordingly.

I, Sukunthala, Mother of No.2620718P Nk Chinnaraju K, R/o- 145, Muthanuru PO- Gullahalli, Dist- Kolar, Karnataka- 563129, declare that in my son's service record my D.O.B. is wrongly recorded as 06/03/1958 whereas my correct D.O.B is 01/01/1953 which may be amended accordingly.
I, Jagdale Mohan Sukhdekh, Father of No.15798106Y Hav Jagdale Krishna Mohan, R/o- Vill & PO- Vita, Dist- Sangli, Maharashtra- 415311, have changed my name from Jagdale Mohan Sukhdekh to Mohan Sukhdev Jagdale, vide affidavit dated 04/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, No.17012047N Hav Areepahmad Nadaf, R/o- Vill & PO- Teerth, Teh- Athani, Dist- Belagavi, Karnataka- 591304, have changed my daughter's name from Izna Nadaf to Izna Areepahmad Nadaf, vide affidavit dated 04/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, No.17012047N Hav Areepahmad Nadaf, R/o- Vill & PO- Teerth, Teh- Athani, Dist- Belagavi, Karnataka- 591304, have changed my son's name from Ahil to Ahil Areepahmad Nadaf, vide affidavit dated 04/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, Surekha Mohan, Mother of No.15798106Y Hav Jagdale Krishna Mohan, R/o- Vill & PO- Vita, Dist- Sangli, Maharashtra- 415311, have changed my name from Surekha Mohan to Surekha Mohan Jagdale, vide affidavit dated 04/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client i.e. Sarawat Co-op Bank Ltd. that Smt. Neelu Khatter is the owner of First Floor without Roof Rights Built on Property Bearing No.24 area measuring 330 Sq. Mtrs. in Pocket-15A, Situated at Sector-24 Rohini Delhi, by virtue of a Relinquishment Deed Dt-15.08.2025 (duly regd. as document no.2025/14/4441) executed by Dr. Ashish Khatter & Smt. Rinkia Khatter in favour of Smt. Neelu Khatter in respect of entire property, all legal heirs of late Mr. Girish Khatter who acquired the said property from registered Will dated 08.12.2003 (doc. No. 47494) executed by Smt. Sita Devi. All persons are here by informed that above mentioned owner wants to sell the said property/floor to a person who intends to obtain loan from our client i.e. Sarawat Co-op Bank Ltd against the said property. If anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above owner over the said property/ floor, its sale/ mortgage/ litigation/ Charge etc., & any other objections, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 7 days of the present. **Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)** 200, IInd Flr. 21, Shivaji Marg, Mori Nagar, N Delhi-15 legal@knslegal.com Ph: 011-41112527-28

PUBLIC NOTICE
My clients Dhani Devi W/o Mohan Lal & Mohan Lal S/o Lt. Ratan Lal R/o H. No. 181/182, Gali No. 12, Rana Vihar Delhi 86, hereby severe all relations & debar their daughters, Aarti wife of the Late Gila Ram and Krian wife of Shyam Lal, from all movable -immovable property(s) due to their misconduct & illegal activities. My clients shall not be responsible or legally liable for any of their acts.
Salman Khan (Advocate)

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
E-Tendering Tender Notice
No. 53/2026

Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.) N.E. Railways Izatnagar for and behalf of President of India invites "OPEN" e-tender through Online (E-Tendering) for the following work:-
S.No. 1. Description of works: Bhojipura-Lalkuan TRR(P)-64 TkM (Km 0 to 64); **Approx. Value(₹):** ₹12,03,35,426.26/-; **EMD Money (₹):** ₹24,06,700/-; **Cost of Tender Forms :** ₹Nil; **Completion time/period from the date of issue of acceptance letter:** 12 Months. **S.No. 2. Description of works:** Protection of Major Bridge no. 46 (SPAN 4x30.50M) between BHL-KHH Block Section at CH 43/887-44/17.61; **Approx. Value(₹):** ₹1,38,25,893.10; **EMD Money (₹):** ₹2,76,500/-; **Cost of Tender Forms :** ₹Nil; **Completion time/period from the date of issue of acceptance letter:** 06 Months; 1. Online e-tender can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs. of dated 25.09.2026. 2. For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in

Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.) CPROW-316 Izatnagar

DO NOT SMOKE BIDI/CIGARETTE IN TRAINS

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Moleshree Khanna, previously known as Moleshree Juneja, D/o Late Sh. Suraj Juneja, resident of Mississauga, Ontario, Canada, am a legal heir and co-owner in Property No. VVZ-53, Virender Nagar, Delhi (formerly Plot No. VB-205, Kharsa No. 813), through succession from my late father Sh. Suraj Juneja and late grandfather Sh. Pyare Lal Juneja. I also hold a registered General Power of Attorney (GPA)/Special Power of Attorney (SPA) executed by Ms. Manvi Juneja, D/o Late Sh. Suraj Juneja, in my favour, duly authorising me to act on her behalf in respect of her share and interest in the said property. Neither I, in my own right, nor Ms. Manvi Juneja, nor any person purportedly acting on her behalf, have executed any Sale Deed, Agreement to Sell, Gift Deed, Mortgage Deed, Lease Deed, GPA, SPA, or any other document authorising any third party to sell, transfer, lease, mortgage or otherwise deal with either my share or Ms. Manvi Juneja's share in this property. Public is cautioned not to deal with the said property, or any part thereof, based on any document claiming my signature/authority or that of Ms. Manvi Juneja, without first verifying directly with me. Any such unauthorised transaction shall not be binding on me or on Ms. Manvi Juneja, and shall be liable to legal action. Moleshree Khanna (In her own right, and also holdin GPA/SPA on behalf of Ms. Manvi Juneja)
Contact:
Moleshree- +1-437-603-0933
Manvi - +1-647-705-1804
Email: khanna.moleshree01@gmail.com

Heavy rains trigger waterlogging, traffic snarls; CM Rekha inspects affected areas

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Traffic movement in Delhi was affected after a heavy downpour inundated key corridors on Saturday, including areas around the Indira Gandhi International Airport and Mahipalpur, raising concerns over preparedness ahead of the BRICS Summit next week.

As heavy rains hit the city, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta conducted a surprise inspection of waterlogged areas near Sadbhavna Park in East Delhi on Saturday.

During the inspection, she assessed areas prone to waterlogging, reviewed the cleanliness of major roads, and received updates on the water drainage system and the challenges posed by the ongoing rains. "She directed officials to immediately deploy pumps and other necessary resources in waterlogged areas and ensure swift clearance of accumulated water," the Chief Minister's Office said in a statement.

The chief minister also instructed officials to strengthen the drainage system further during the monsoon season and ensure that no area experiences waterlogging, the statement added.

The chief minister emphasised that all concerned departments must work with complete preparedness, promptness and coordination to ensure that Delhi residents do not face inconvenience due to rainfall. The inspection comes a day after several parts of the city were waterlogged, particularly



Commuters cover themselves amid heavy rain in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

areas around Indira Gandhi International Airport.

Several parts of Delhi were submerged on Saturday after heavy rain, with roads disappearing beneath knee-deep water and traffic slowing to a crawl. Safdarjung recorded 22 mm of rainfall between 8.30 am and 11.30 am, while Palam received 25.2 mm, Lodhi Road 24.4 mm, and Ridge 6.8 mm during the period.

The capital has been receiving incessant rain since Friday. The Dwarka underpass connecting Palam with the IGI domestic area, along with the parts near Terminal 3, was inundated after Friday's heavy rain.

A PWD official had earlier said temporary pumps were deployed to remove the accumulated water from the Dwarka underpass. The official had said that flooding in nearby Mehrampur added to the water accumulation in the tunnel, which was subsequently cleared.

The PWD's earlier instructions under the flood-control order require its ground teams to alert the control

room immediately once water stagnation in an underpass reaches 6 to 8 inches and to deploy mobile pumps.

If pumping fails to prevent the water level from rising, the control room informs the Traffic Police to halt movement through the affected underpass, the official had said.

PWD officials had said other roads and underpasses around the airport were under the jurisdiction of Delhi International Airport Limited and the National Highways Authority of India.

Rainfall on Saturday inundated the National Highway-48 stretch between IGI Airport and Dhaura Kuan, and waterlogged the Palam airport tunnel and Neem Chowk Road in Sangam Vihar. Shakarpur, Laxmi Nagar and Mehrauli-Badarpur Road were among the other affected areas.

Water also accumulated along the stretch between Rotary Chowk and DJB Chowk, the road towards Omaxe via Radha Swami Satsang Bhavan, DJB Red Light-Omaxe Road and Omaxe Road in Dwarka, covering several sectors. The

NH-8 underpass was also affected.

Amid waterlogging and preparations for the upcoming BRICS Summit, the Delhi Traffic Police warned commuters of slow movement at multiple locations. The city also reported trees falling at several locations, including Mathura Road and near Malviya Nagar Metro Station, amid heavy downpour, with the PWD and the MCD receiving around 10 and eight complaints of tree falling, respectively, an official said.

About 10 calls concerning waterlogging were also received, most of which were addressed within an hour, the PWD official said. The MCD also received three complaints related to waterlogging and 20 complaints of no electricity supply during the day.

As the capital prepares for the International BRICS Summit on September 12 and 13, senior Delhi Government officials inspected the route between Bharat Mandapam and IGI Airport to identify vulnerable spots. The latest waterlogging also comes against the backdrop of a review meeting held by Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on August 26 with agencies concerned.

He called for a "whole of Government" approach to the city's waterlogging problem, asking departments and agencies to work in close coordination rather than operate in silos. Sandhu had also directed the civic agencies, including the PWD, to submit a report on waterlogging-related issues by the end of August.

Gurugram drenched in hour-long downpour; waterlogging hits key routes, traffic crawls



Workers use a tractor-mounted water pump to drain accumulated rainwater from a waterlogged road following heavy rainfall in Gurugram, Haryana, on Saturday



PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

The heavy rain that drenched Gurugram on Saturday afternoon provided much-needed relief from the humid heat, but it also caused significant waterlogging in several areas, halting the city's usual pace. Traffic remained slow from Sarhaul Border to Rajiv Chowk, with 36 mm of rainfall recorded within just one hour.

The hour-long downpour resulted in light to moderate waterlogging in key areas and on connecting routes throughout the city. This accumulation of water disrupted traffic flow. A resident noted that since it is the weekend, those commuting home from work later may experience considerable delays due to traffic congestion.

Immediately after the rain, traffic volume surged on the Delhi-Jaipur highway.

Vehicles crawled along the stretch from Sarhaul Border to Rajiv Chowk and Subhash Chowk. Waterlogged areas along the roadside have made navigation extremely difficult for two-wheelers and three-wheelers.

The worst affected areas include Rajiv Chowk, Sohna Road, Golf Course Extension Road, Udyog Vihar, and the roads surrounding Sector 14, where traffic has slowed significantly.

According to commuters, waterlogging at various locations has posed challenges for both pedestrians and motorists. Water accumulating in existing potholes on Udyog Vihar Phase 3 and Old Delhi-Gurugram Road has heightened the risk of accidents, forcing drivers to exercise extreme caution and drive at reduced speeds to avoid accidents.

The traffic police swung into action in response to the traffic jams and water-

logging. Police personnel have been deployed at major intersections and vulnerable waterlogged spots to divert traffic and clear the congestion.

The Gurugram Traffic Police has issued an advisory for motorists due to heavy rain and waterlogging in Delhi. Vehicles travelling from Gurugram to Delhi have been advised to take a U-turn at IFFCO Chowk and enter via the Aya Nagar border, while those heading to the airport are advised to use the Dwarka Expressway.

Teams from the Municipal Corporation of Gurugram (MCG) and the district administration have been engaged in draining water from the affected areas using suction pumps.

According to the India Meteorological Department, intermittent rainfall is likely to continue in Gurugram and surrounding areas over the next 24 to 48 hours due

to an active monsoon trough and a low-pressure area. The department warned that if heavy rainfall continues in the coming hours, waterlogging in low-lying areas could worsen significantly.

The district administration also issued an advisory asking people not to leave their homes unless necessary.

"Avoid waterlogged roads, underpasses, and low-lying areas. Stay away from trees, electricity poles, and overhead power lines. Do not attempt to cross waterlogged roads", the advisory read.

Deputy Commissioner Uttam Singh, in his capacity as Chairperson of the District Disaster Management Authority, has directed all concerned departments and emergency response agencies to remain alert and take necessary precautionary measures.

Swatantra Bhardwaj with history of provocative posts held over assault at protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Self-styled influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj had built a sizeable social media following with provocative posts, displays of political proximity and incendiary statements long before a video showing him boasting about assaulting a Jantar Mantar protester's father went viral.

The 22-year-old, who describes himself as a "Sanatani Yodha", was detained from Bulandshahr in Uttar Pradesh on Friday, hours after Delhi Police assured CJP protesters that he would be arrested within 72 hours in connection with the alleged assault on Sanjay Kumar, the father of a teenage student activist, during the July 20 protest in the national Capital.

A look at Bhardwaj's social

media presence shows that such statements were hardly an aberration from the persona he has cultivated.

His Facebook page, which has around 3,27,000 followers, is replete with posts centred on Hindutva, cow protection, attacks on Muslims and critics of the Government, and photographs projecting his proximity to political figures and official events.

On Thursday, a day before he was detained, Bhardwaj posted a screenshot showing his name among the trends on X, captioning it, "Love you all Virodhi".

Bhardwaj also posted a photograph of himself on Instagram displaying a 'kada' on his wrist with the caption "Feel the power!", an apparent reference to Delhi Police's statement that Kumar was hurt by 'kada' and "not by any weapon".



His Facebook page also carries photographs of him at the Red Fort on August 15 with hashtags such as "#sanatanihero" and "#gaurakshak". In another post, he displayed an invitation issued in his name by the Ministry of Defence for the Independence Day ceremony this year.

He had similarly posted photographs of invitations issued to him for the swear-

ing-in ceremony of the Narendra Modi Government on June 9, 2024.

There are also photographs of Bhardwaj with political leaders, including Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary, Delhi minister Kapil Mishra and Union minister Chirag Paswan. Paswan said he has lodged a complaint against Bhardwaj and demanded action against him.

His Instagram account,

which had around 1,84,000 followers, was deactivated on Friday. Bhardwaj also has a verified account on X with more than 6,400 followers and the bio reads: "A Modern-Day Youngster Who Can't Tolerate Anything Against His DHARMA and RASHTRA."

As the clip about the alleged assault on Kumar circulated widely, several older videos featuring Bhardwaj also surfaced on social media. In some of them, he is purportedly heard making inflammatory statements against Muslims and Government critics. In others, he boasts about his political connections and claims that he does not fear arrest.

In the clip that drew attention to him, he boasted about cracking the skull of Nishu's father.

"Do you know which section this crime attracts? Section 307. He needed 60

stitches. The man was being taken away in an ambulance in serious condition. His daughter was standing outside the police station and saying that she would die by suicide if her father didn't get justice.

"But I was not even jailed. The world should know this. I was out and about through the night," Bhardwaj is heard saying in the video.

He then invoked the names of several political leaders while explaining why, according to him, he had little reason to worry.

"I have the blessings of Hanuman upon me. And secondly, Kapil Mishra is my elder brother. They say Kapil Mishra called and I was released. Chirag Paswan is my elder brother. How many leaders do you know? Do you know Modi ji? Modi ji is also my elder brother. I have everyone's support," he claimed.

3-year-old leopard found dead in Aravalli foothills; probe underway

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

A three-year-old leopard was found dead in Paldi village in the foothills of the Aravallis in Nuh district, with forest officials investigating all possible causes of its sudden death, an official said on Saturday.

The discovery of the leopard's body caused a stir among the villagers. Teams from the Forest Department and the Wildlife Department



arrived at the scene, took possession of the carcass, and launched an investigation, the official said.

According to the police, a woman from the village went near the graveyard on Friday morning. She spotted a leopard lying at the foothills of the Aravallis. Upon closer inspection, she found the leopard dead.

She immediately informed the villagers, who then notified the Police, Forest Department and the Wildlife

Department. A team arrived at the scene and secured the leopard's carcass. Preliminary examination revealed no external injuries on the body.

The leopard was reportedly around three years old. An investigation into all possible causes of its sudden death has been initiated, said a wildlife officer.

Departmental officials are also investigating other possibilities, such as a bite from a venomous creature

or a snake. A post-mortem of the leopard has been conducted. Viscera samples are being also sent to Bareilly for analysis. The cause of the leopard's death will only become clear once the report is received.

"No external injuries were found on the leopard's body. Further action will be taken based on the report, and surveillance in the area will be stepped up," Wildlife Officer Ramkumar Jangra said.

1807 British map reveals Capital's old names and forgotten landscape

MANSI JAGANI
■ New Delhi

Mapping a territory is perhaps one of the foremost ways of establishing dominion over it. Thus, when the British East India Company occupied this city after defeating the Marathas in the Battle of Delhi in 1803, one of the first things they did was to map its localities.

More than a century before the popular landmarks and grand avenues of the imperial capital came into being, Mehrauli was 'Mouralee', Indraprastha 'Indiput', the Yamuna was 'Jumnah' and Okhla 'Okilluh' to the British surveyors who put Delhi on paper for the first time — some four years after establishing dominion over the city.

The 1807 map captures a Delhi that feels familiar, and yet almost

unrecognisable: the walled city of Shahjahanabad, the Yamuna flowing along the ramparts of the Red Fort, villages scattered across fields, streams descending from the Ridge, 'sarais' (residences) lining bustling trade routes and a landscape of monuments, orchards and open countryside stretching far beyond.

"Sketch of the Environs of Delhi", a hand-drawn map attributed to British surveyor F S White, is one of the earliest maps of the capital in Survey of India's archives. It captures familiar locales that survive to this day, separated by open landscape stretching far and wide.

Shahjahanabad sits at the heart of the city, its built-up expanse shaded pink, with its gates and major structures marked in detail.

The Red Fort is identified simply as 'The Palace', while Salimgarh

appears as 'Juleemgurh' and the Jama Masjid as 'Jumma Musjid'. Around the walls are Dillee Gate (Delhi Gate), Ajmeer Gate (Ajmeri Gate), Lahor Gate (Lahori Gate), Kabul Gate (Khooni Darwaza), and Toorkman Gate (Turkman Gate). Beyond the walled city, the dense cluster of buildings gives way to villages, roads, sarais, and scattered historic sites.

The quaint spellings of place names offer a glimpse into how British surveyors perceived regional languages and dialects as they navigated a city they had come to occupy recently.

Rithala became 'Rittaluh', Sarai Juliana appears as 'Injuleh Sarai', Moti Bagh as 'Mochee Bagh', and Tihar as 'Teehar' — spellings that can seem whimsical today but were often attempts to reproduce names as they sounded to the surveyors.



This image shows the oldest surviving British-era map of Delhi, dating to 1807, showing Shahjahanabad and the city's surrounding landscape of villages, roads, waterways and monuments

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While the map has changed, many of these names have stuck to this day. Rittaluh (Rithala), Badlee (Badli), Jusroulah (Jasola), Okilluh (Okhla) and Kulkajhee (Kalkaji) remain landmarks in the modern city.

What has changed is the landscape around them.

To the north and northwest of Shahjahanabad, the map places familiar settlements amid far more open landscapes than the one surrounding them today. Rithala and Badli appear as villages, while Wuzeerabad (Wazirabad) lies by the Yamuna.

Puhargunj, today's Paharganj, sits outside the walled city. The Western Yamuna Canal cuts across the landscape, while routes marked on the map connect these settlements to Shahjahanabad and to the larger network of roads leading out of Delhi.

South of Shahjahanabad, the map begins to connect the old city with monuments, villages, and roadside settlements that would eventually be swallowed up by the expanding capital. Feroz Shah's Palace, now Feroz Shah Kotla, is marked prominently, while Indiput appears near the Purana Qila.

The name 'Indiput' is particularly intriguing because Indraprastha has older linguistic parallels, including the Pali name 'Indapatta'.

Further south are Beegampor, or Begampur, and Sieud Lubab, now Said-ul-Ajaib. Mooralee is Mehrauli, then a small settlement in an expansive open landscape, leads towards Kanhpur further south, Khanpur of today.

The old roads south of Delhi are dotted with sarais along them — Shekh Seraee, Toot Saraee, Keem

Seraee, Jeer, and Beer Seraee. These were resting stops for travellers and traders moving along these routes in and out of the city.

Other names point to landscapes that have proved less durable. Khierpor, a village near Sufterjung's Tomb (Safdarjung Tomb) stood in the area that is now Lodhi Gardens.

The Yamuna itself is 'Jumnah', running close to Shahjahanabad and the Red Fort, while the eastern bank remained sparsely populated.

The map, therefore, is not simply a depiction of a city. It captures its various indices — the walled Mughal city and stray settlements, roadways and waterways, agrarian lands and bustling trade routes, and its languages and cultures — as the colonial surveyor tries to make sense of it all.

8 engineering students killed in Keralam’s Thrissur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thrissur

Eight engineering students from Tamil Nadu’s Dindigul were killed when their car rammmed into a lorry parked “illegally” on NH-66 in Thrissur district of central Keralam, police said on Saturday. The accident occurred around 11.40 pm on Friday at Panambikkunnu in Kaipamangalam, when the car, travelling from Guruvayur towards Kodungallur, collided with the rear of the Maharashtra-registered lorry, police said. According to the FIR, the lorry was parked illegally on the right side of the highway near a barricaded stretch where traffic had been diverted as part of ongoing construction work.

Police said the car was travelling at high speed and its driver apparently failed to notice the diversion barricade before the collision. Six students died on the spot, while two others were declared dead on arrival at a nearby hospital, police said. The deceased were students of an engineering college in Dindigul and were travelling towards Kodungallur along NH-66. Police said five of the deceased-Surya, Yuvasanjith, Joshua, Murali and Jeeva-were from Dindigul, while Santhosh and Prasanna were from Madurai and Vishva was from Salem. The students were pulled out of the mangled car during a rescue



People gathering near wreckage of a car after it collided with a lorry parked on the highway at Thrissur district Keralam

PTI

operation involving residents, fire and rescue personnel and police. Their bodies were taken to the mortuary at Thrissur Medical College, police said. Kaipamangalam police have registered a case against the lorry driver under Section 105 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for culpable homicide. The driver went into hiding soon after the accident, police said. Police contacted the families of the deceased using student identity cards recovered from the victims. Some of the families were unaware that their children had travelled to Keralam, police said. Relatives

told police that Santhosh had recently purchased a car and that the group had planned a trip to Kochi. As the registration of the car had not been completed, they hired a rented vehicle for the trip, they said. Postmortem examinations were conducted at Thrissur Medical College, where relatives arrived to receive the bodies. Hospital authorities arranged ambulances to transport the bodies to their respective native places. Thrissur Rural District Police Chief Mohammad Nadeemuddin said a preliminary investigation indicated that the accident occurred due to the

lorry driver’s fault. “It is definitely a mistake on the part of the lorry driver. An FIR has already been registered. Additionally, regarding the highway authorities and the contractor, we will inspect that as part of the investigation and take strict action,” he told reporters. Nadeemuddin said the lorry driver was absconding, but the vehicle owner had been identified, and the driver would be apprehended soon. He said that although a Highway Police patrol unit had been deployed in the area, lorry drivers often parked their vehicles and left the spot. “Definitely,

parking should not be done here. We will check whether the highway authorities and contractors have installed proper signboards. But as per the preliminary assessment, this is a mistake on the part of the lorry driver,” he said. Nadeemuddin said the Kodungallur deputy superintendent of police had been assigned to investigate the case. “Legal action has been initiated, and an FIR has already been registered. Given the gravity of the case, we have designated the deputy SP of Kodungallur as the investigating officer. There will be a thorough investigation, and immediate and strict action will be taken against whoever is at fault. Necessary preventive measures will be taken by the police,” he said.

Keralam Minister Janeesh raises safety concerns

Keralam Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Saturday expressed concern over recurring accidents and safety issues on National Highway stretches in the State following the death of eight engineering students in Thrissur district. He also said that he would urgently raise the matter with the National Highways Authority of India. The NHAI said comprehensive safety measures and warning signs had been installed well ahead of the accident site. Eight students from Tamil Nadu were killed late Friday night when the car in which they

were travelling rammmed into a lorry parked on NH-66 at Kaipamangalam in Thrissur district. In a post on ‘X’, Satheesan said he was “deeply concerned” over the increasing number of accidents and safety issues on National Highways in Keralam, particularly on stretches under construction. He said he would urgently raise the matter with the NHAI and urged Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari to order a comprehensive safety review of ongoing highway projects in the state. “Request Union Minister Nitin Gadkari to kindly accord high priority to a thorough safety review and immediate corrective action on NH projects in the State. Public safety must remain paramount,” he said. Earlier in the day, Keralam Sports Minister O J Janeesh, who represents Kodungalloor in Thrissur district, also criticised the NHAI following the deaths of the eight engineering students. Janeesh alleged that the NHAI had been uncooperative whenever public representatives convened meetings or raised concerns over construction work on NH-66. “From the visuals, it appears that the car crashed into the rear of a parked vehicle. The spot where the vehicle was parked on the highway was not a designated parking area. That is a major issue,” he said.

Sushant appointed as district president of BJP Yuva Morcha



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Sushant Mehlawat has been appointed as the district president of the Bharatiya Janata Party Yuva Morcha (BJYM), Mehrauli. Expressing his gratitude to the party’s senior leadership for entrusting him with the responsibility, Mehlawat said that he is committed to strengthening the organisation at the grassroots level and working towards the welfare, empowerment, and participation of the youth. Mehlawat believes that young people are not only the future of the nation but also an important force for positive change today. As district president, his key priorities will include raising the concerns and aspirations of young people, understanding their challenges, encouraging greater youth participation, and strengthening the organisation at the grassroots level.

Play, create, stay active: PM to students

The PM praised a teacher who spoke about making women in her vicinity aware of breast cancer, and said a breast cancer awareness campaign was launched by him in Varanasi, his Lok Sabha constituency.

“I am happy to share with you that more and more women are coming forward for screening (for breast cancer), even setting a Guinness World Record for it,” he said. This year, 82 teachers and educators have been selected for the National Teachers Awards from three departments. These include 48 teachers from the Department of School Education and Literacy, 21 teachers/faculty members from higher educational institutions and polytechnics, and 13 skill trainers from the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship.

India transformed in 13 years: PM Modi

“What I said in 2013 was my conviction,” he told the students. Modi’s visit to the SRCC comes amid the BJP’s ongoing outreach to the young generation. He last visited the SRCC in 2013, when he was the chief minister of Gujarat. The Prime Minister described the alumni of SRCC as the institution’s “OGs”, saying they had taken the college’s name across the world and made their mark in different fields.

Speaking in a lighter tone, PM Modi told the students, “You may not be a Dhurandhar, but make some noise,” urging them to make an impact even if they were not Dhurandhar. Modi took a sharp jibe at the Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi, describing the Congress party’s student outreach campaign “Chhatron Ki Goonj” as “Jhooth ki goonj”. “Chhatron Ki Goonj” is a student-dialogue campaign launched by the Congress to raise issues including examination paper leaks, rising education costs, irregularities in government recruitment and unemployment. Over the past three months, the campaign has been held in Kota in Rajasthan, Dehradun in Uttarakhand, Prayagraj in Uttar Pradesh and Pune in Maharashtra.

Modi highlighted India’s economic growth and contrasted the country’s current position with the situation in 2013. The World Bank had lowered its GDP growth forecast. The current account deficit was at an all-time high. Inflation was around 10 per cent. The industrial sector was in the grip of a slowdown. Corruption in the helicopter deal had been exposed. There were bomb blasts in Hyderabad. These were all headlines at that time. I firmly believe that our students today may not know about all these things.”” He said those responsible for pushing India into the ‘fragile 5’ are now unable to digest its 7.8 per cent growth. The PM noted that people have revisited his 2013 address and even today, the impact of that address remains intact.

“Today, those spreading terrorism are trounced. If Pakistan indulges in any nefarious act, the Indian army enters their home and strikes; the back of Naxalism has been broken...from policy paralysis to policy dynamism, India has come a long way. Modi recalled former Union minister Arun Jaitley, who studied at the college, and spoke about his frequent recollections of his student days. He also used the word “revisit” while asking the younger generation to look back at the situation in India when he last addressed SRCC in 2013. PM Modi arrived at the college by Delhi Metro and interacted with students and fellow passengers during the journey. He also released a commemorative ₹100 coin to mark the centenary. Notably, when PM Modi returns to Delhi University’s Shri Ram College of Commerce on Saturday evening for the institution’s centenary celebrations, it’ll mark 13 years since an address at the same college that was widely read as the launchpad for his projection as the BJP’s prime ministerial face.

The last time was in February 2013, when PM Modi came to SRCC as the chief minister of Gujarat, weeks into his fourth term in

Gandhinagar and yet to be named his party’s candidate for national office. He was in his 12th year as CM, having first taken office in October 2001. He would go on to mark another year as CM before taking the chair in Delhi.

13 years on, 10 convicted in Jhiram...

Originally, eleven people were on trial, but one died during the process. The ten convicted include two women, Pramila Modiyam (40) and Chaitu Lekam, as well as Sumitra Punem Modiyam, Mukka Mandavi, Kosa Kavasi, Aayata Markam, Madkami Deva, Joga Madkami, Banjami Sanna, and Mahadev Nag. The trial lasted more than ten years and included testimony from 101 witnesses. The attack happened in the afternoon as a Congress convoy was returning from a Parivartan Rally in Sukma. The convoy was travelling on the national highway through Jhiram Valley, under the Darbha police station in Bastar district. Maoist fighters first set off a landmine that destroyed the road and blocked the vehicles. Then, they fired at the convoy, threw grenades, and targeted specific people. Witnesses said the attackers surrounded the convoy from several directions and aimed at certain leaders.

Among those killed were then-State Congress President Nand Kumar Patel and his son Dinesh, former Leader of the Opposition Mahendra Karma, former Union Minister Vidya Charan Shukla-who succumbed to injuries weeks later-and former MLA Uday Mudliyar. Security personnel, party workers, and civilians also lost their lives, with over thirty others injured. Karma, known as the Bastar Tiger and associated with the Salwa Judum movement, was identified as a primary target. Reports from the period depict cadres recognising him, assaulting him, and shooting him at close range after exchanging fire with his guards.

The massacre shocked the political establishment and occurred during a Congress campaign against the then-BJP-led government in Chhattisgarh. The operation involved approximately 200 to 250 armed cadres, some in civilian clothing, demonstrating the Maoists’ capacity for a large, coordinated ambush in Bastar’s forested terrain. This incident remains one of the most serious instances of violence against political leaders during the Naxalite-Maoist insurgency.

At first, Bastar police registered the case. Because of the seriousness of the charges and security concerns, the investigation was later handed over to the NIA.

The agency filed charge sheets against many cadres. Several senior figures involved in the plot have since died in encounters, surrendered, or are still at large. The ten people convicted are lower-ranking commanders and armed fighters who helped plan or carry out the attack.

The verdict follows a lengthy legal process. Final arguments concluded. This verdict comes after a long legal process. Final arguments ended in August 2026, and the court was first set to announce the judgment on 31 August, but it was postponed to 5 September.

The families of the victims have waited thirteen years for this outcome. Sentencing will take place on 16 September, when the prison terms will be decided. The defence plans to appeal and says it will decide on the exact reasons after reading the full written order.

The conviction does not end the larger story of the case. Questions about intelligence failures, the slow police response, and the Maoist leadership remain unanswered. Still, the court’s decision is an important legal step in this long-running case of an entire generation of leaders.

For the security forces, it serves as a reminder of the human cost associated with the Naxal insurgency in Bastar region. The next hearing will determine the prison sentences, with an appeal to follow in the High Court. The events of 25 May 2013, however, continue to occupy a prominent place in the region’s political memory.

Population Census to begin in four states...

The population enumeration of snow-bound areas of Uttarakhand, Jammu and Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh has already started on

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September 1 and will end on September 30. At present, the house listing and housing Census in other States are underway. The early announcement of population enumeration in four states has been made keeping in mind the logistics of holding two massive exercises without any glitches, as most of the officials needed for conducting the Census and elections are the same.

A Government statement issued on June 25 said that the reference date for the remaining country, except Ladakh and snow-bound non-synchronous areas of the Union territory of Jammu and Kashmir and the snow-bound non-synchronous areas of the States of Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand, would be March 1, 2027. Last month, the Centre notified 40 questions, including a query on caste for the first time in independent India, to be asked of respondents. This is the first time that caste will be enumerated in independent India, other than that of Scheduled Tribes (STs) and Scheduled Castes (SCs). Until the 2011 Census, the exercise included the systematic enumeration of only SCs and STs, while caste enumeration for other communities was not part of the post-Independence Census. The decision to include caste enumeration in Census 2027 was taken by the Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs (CCPA) on April 30, 2025.

The Government has added new questions — such as father’s & mother’s particulars, total number of bank accounts, place of COVID vaccination, Aadhaar no, mobile no, voter ID, and passport no — for posing before every person through the schedule of Census 2027.

As per the notification issued by the Registrar General, India, the information to be collected also includes the name of the person, relationship with the head of household, sex, date of birth and age, marital status, age at marriage and spouse’s name, nationality, mother tongue, religion, literacy, education, migration, and other demographic parameters.

Subhash Chandra booked in ₹1,322 cr LICHL loan...

The main issue in the FIR is what happened next. During personal insolvency proceedings under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), Chandra denied the figures in those certificates. He said his net worth in 2024 was ₹31.79 crore and that even in 2017-18, it had not exceeded ₹40,000 crore. LICHL sees the difference between the 2018 documents and Chandra’s later statements as proof that the certificates were inflated to get the loans. The complaint claims Chandra worked with the four borrower and co-borrower companies and their officers to cheat the lender.

The FIR names Chandra, Vasant Sagar Properties and its director Pankaj Suroliya, Pan India Infraprojects, Digital Subscriber Management and Consultancy Services and its director Amish Pandya, Spirit Infrapower and Multiventures and its director Rajeev Dholakia, and others not yet identified. Creating false documents to inflate net worth, inducing LICHL to advance funds, and then misappropriating those funds.

The claimed loss of over ₹1,322 crore is not the original principal. LICHL’s admitted claim in Chandra’s personal insolvency is about ₹1,322.39 crore, reflecting outstanding dues with interest and charges after default. That insolvency itself has been contentious. Creditors have opposed a repayment plan that would recover only a few crore against admitted claims running into tens of thousands of crore.

The CBI case now adds a criminal investigation to the ongoing civil dispute over the loans. Investigators will look into the roles of the two chartered accountancy firms, how LICHL assessed the loans, how the funds were used, and whether public money was put at risk due to misleading information.

Chandra and the other accused did not comment right away. This case adds a criminal angle to the ongoing financial troubles of the Essel group’s founder. His personal guarantees once backed large loans, and his later statements during insolvency hearings are now central to the CBI investigation.

Delhi waterlogged after heavy rain, NH-48...

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD) data, Safdarjung recorded 22 mm of rainfall between 8.30 am and 11.30 am, while Palam received 25.2 mm, Lodhi Road 24.4 mm, and Ridge 6.8 mm during the period. Among other stations, Aya Nagar recorded 13.4 mm of rain, Pusa 13.5 mm, Mayur Vihar 7 mm, Jafarpur 2.5 mm, Chhatarpur 22 mm, Janakpuri 8.5 mm, Naraina 20.5 mm, Jharoda Kalan 4.5 mm and Pritampur 2.2 mm between 8.30 am and 11.30 am.

Several airlines, including IndiGo and Air India, issued passenger advisories as rain lashed Delhi and adjoining areas on Saturday morning, causing flight disruptions at Delhi’s Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport. Bad weather is currently affecting Delhi, leading to possible delays in flight operations, India’s largest airline IndiGo said in a post on X, urging passengers to check their flight status before leaving for the airport.

Tata Group-owned carrier Air India also said that flight operations to and from Delhi may be affected due to adverse weather conditions today. However, Delhi Airport authorities said the flight operations are currently normal.

Delhi Traffic Police on X cautioned the public about slow traffic at various locations due to waterlogging and preparations for the BRICS Summit. A tree was reported to have fallen on Mathura Road between Apollo Hospital and Ashram Chowk.

Jantar Mantar case: Bhardwaj remanded...

Ranjan also questioned why police sought only one day’s custody in what he described as a serious offence and said the legal team had not been given details of the provisions added to the FIR.

“Today at Patiala House Court around 1:45, he was presented before the Judge at his residence, and a special VC arrangement was done for him. The judge was not sitting in Court. No idea about which charges are being freshly pressed. No idea about how many days of remand were asked by the Police,” he tweeted.

On the other hand, Advocate Umesh Sharma for Bhardwaj said that initially, the regular area magistrate, whose court normally handles the matter, was on leave and thus, they were informed that the accused would be produced before the Link Magistrate.

“However, since sections of the SC/ST Act and POCSO Act were also added, the investigating officer produced him before another judge, either virtually or otherwise. We were informed by the court that he had been remanded to one day of police custody,” he said.

On Friday, Delhi Police added provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act and criminal intimidation to the FIR against Bhardwaj for allegedly assaulting the father of a teenage activist during a CJP-led protest at Jantar Mantar in June. He has also been booked in a POCSO case. A Delhi court on Saturday remanded influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj to one-day police custody in connection with the alleged assault on Sanjay, the father of a teenage CJP activist, during a protest at Jantar Mantar in July.

Bhardwaj was detained in Bulandshahr on Friday, hours after the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) staged a protest outside the Parliament Street Police Station for his arrest.

The action followed outrage over an interview in which Bhardwaj claimed him “cracked the skull” of the minor activist’s father, Sanjay, on June 23 during the CJP protest and escaped arrest because of his political connections. “I cracked the skull... Do you know which section this crime attracts? Section 307. He needed 60 stitches,” he said on a video podcast.

India backs UN push to redraw world map...

“We believe that maps play an important role in how societies understand geography and the

relative scale of the world around us,” he said.

However, India clarified its understanding of the scope of this resolution, saying, “We believe that the resolution should be understood as supporting the broader use and consideration of Equal Area map projections, and not as endorsing the Equal Earth projection or any other specific map projection.” Equal Area projections are particularly relevant because they preserve the relative sizes or areas of continental and territorial landmasses, Puri said.

“Therefore, we believe it is important for this resolution to remain technological and methodological-neutral. Our delegation supports the language that encourages accurate cartographic representation while allowing countries, institutions and cartographers to determine which projection is most appropriate for their specific needs,” Puri said.

He said India’s position is limited to the principle of encouraging Equal Area approaches where the objective is to preserve the relative sizes of continental landmasses.

The resolution affirmed that cartographic distortions of continental sizes inherited from history have cognitive, educational, cultural, geopolitical and socioeconomic impacts and constitute historical biases, the correction of which will promote recognition, justice and development, particularly about the African continent.

The Mercator projection is a world map devised in 1569 by Flemish cartographer Gerardus Mercator that does not accurately reflect the actual continental landmasses, making Africa look smaller than it actually is and enhancing the sizes of Northern Europe and North America. Rejecting the text, Deputy US Representative to the UN Economic and Social Council Yaryna Ferencevych said that instead of focusing on genuine problems of international peace, prosperity, or good relations, the UNGA is debating map projects from the 16th century, and their role in promoting reparations and “cognitive justice.”

Pakistan also voted in favour of the resolution, saying it supports the basic premise of the initiative for an accurate description of the continental landmasses only and not countries’ political maps and boundaries.

Terrorist killed in J&K’s Budgam linked to LeT

The operation, named Operation Ashdar by the Army’s Srinagar-based Chinar Corps, was launched on Thursday after specific intelligence that a suspected group of terrorists was moving from Pakherpora in Pulwama towards Yousmarg in Budgam through the forested Ashdar Gali area. The joint search involved the Indian Army, J&K Police and the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF). Officials said troops had tracked movement across mountain passes in the Pir Panjal range and trekked for hours from the Doodhpathri side to close in. The area is a known transit corridor linking the Kashmir Valley with Poonch in the Jammu region.

On Friday, troops deployed at one of the Temporary Operating Bases (TOBs) observed suspicious movement in the rugged, high-altitude terrain above the Yousmarg tourist belt. When challenged, the suspects opened fire. In the ensuing exchange, one terrorist was killed. An AK-series rifle and other war-like stores were recovered from the site.

Kashmir Zone Inspector General of Police Sujit Kumar visited the operation area on Friday to review the search.

According to the police, Yasir’s presence was first detected in 2024. Inputs suggest his involvement in at least three major terror incidents in 2024: an ambush of an Indian Air Force (IAF) convoy in Poonch district in May, an attack on construction workers near Sonamarg in October, and an attack on the army in Bota Pathri.

Yasir was part of the terror group led by Junai Ahmed Bhat, a Lashkar-e-Taiba commander, who was shot dead by security forces on December 3, 2024, in Dachigam forest on the outskirts of Srinagar.

On October 24, 2024, Yasir and other terrorists ambushed an Indian Army vehicle in the Bota Pathri area near Gulmarg, Jammu and Kashmir, killing five people — three soldiers and two porters.

Jhiram attack case: BJP hails verdict, Congress hits out

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

The conviction of 10 accused in the 2013 Jhiram Valley Maoist attack case has triggered a political slugfest in Chhattisgarh, with the Congress terming the verdict “incomplete justice” and the ruling BJP welcoming the court’s decision.

An NIA court in Jagdalpur on Saturday convicted all 10 persons arrested for the attack, in which 29 people, including senior Congress leaders Vidya Charan Shukla and Mahendra Karma, were killed.

Reacting to the verdict, former chief minister Bhupesh Baghel, in a long post on X, said the judgment appeared to be “incomplete justice” as the alleged larger political conspiracy behind the attack had not been investigated.

“In such a case, sentencing only 10 lower-level Naxals cannot be called justice,” Baghel said.

“The NIA, the agency investigating the incident, had itself stated

that 200 people carried out the Jhiram attack. The NIA had named 39 individuals as accused. However, due to persistent negligence during the investigation, the agency failed to apprehend more than ten people. The NIA had already dropped the names of top Naxalite leaders from the FIR; one wonders at whose behest,” he said.

Secondly, the inquiry commission investigated the matter solely regarding ‘lapses in security arrangements,’ rather than focusing on securing convictions in a criminal case, Baghel claimed.

The truth is that the horrific political conspiracy behind the Jhiram incident has never been investigated, the senior Congress leader asserted.

“The Congress party and the affected families have consistently maintained that a massive political conspiracy was behind this incident and that an investigation into it was essential. However, the NIA never investigated this aspect,” he said.



BJP MP Santosh Pandey, State Congress president Deepak Baij



Baghel also referred to a second FIR registered by Chhattisgarh police in 2020 on a complaint by Jitendra Mudliyar, son of slain Congress leader Uday Mudliyar, alleging a larger conspiracy.

The Supreme Court had rejected the NIA’s objection to the second FIR in November 2023, he said, adding that no investigation was conducted into it after the

BJP returned to power in the state (in 2023).

“In the last two-and-a-half years, no investigation has been conducted into the second FIR. In fact, the BJP does not want an investigation into the criminal conspiracy to take place at all. As I stated, BJP leaders simply do not want an investigation into the criminal conspiracy behind the

Jhiram incident. Until this investigation takes place, justice for Jhiram will remain incomplete,” he added.

Talking to reporters in Durg, State Congress president Deepak Baij said the conviction of 10 accused was not justice for Bastar, the victims’ families or the Congress.

The attack was the result of a political conspiracy and a “supari (contract) killing” aimed at eliminating Congress leaders to capture power, he said, adding the NIA investigation was incomplete and that only those who were arrested had been convicted.

“The people of Bastar do not even know the names of the 10 persons who have been convicted. Only small-level Naxals were arrested, and tribal and lower-level cadres were made accused,” he said.

“The names of some senior Naxal leaders were mentioned in the initial FIR and were later removed. Today, several senior Naxal leaders have surrendered.

Were they interrogated by the NIA or the Government after their surrender?” Baij asked.

Some senior Maoist leaders had admitted in media interviews to being involved in the Jhiram attack, he said and questioned whether they had been granted immunity from punishment.

“Overall, this verdict appears to have held these small-level Naxals responsible for protecting the then chief minister and his cabinet colleagues at the Centre’s direction,” Baij alleged while stating that the Congress does not agree with the verdict.

The SIT constituted during the previous Congress Government should be asked to investigate the case again, he added.

The BJP, however, welcomed the court verdict and defended the NIA investigation.

BJP chief spokesperson and MP Santosh Pandey said the verdict was a matter of satisfaction after a long wait and would help bring the truth before the public.

He also said Baghel was in

power for five years (from 2018 to 2023) and could have produced the evidence he claimed to possess regarding the Jhiram attack.

“If you (Baghel) had evidence, why did you not present it before the court during your five-year Government?” Pandey asked.

Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Sharma also slammed the Congress and asked why the party did not take action while it was in power. He was responding to queries on Congress’ allegations against those responsible at the time for providing security for the party’s rally.

He said the NIA probe had been found to be correct by the court, pointing out that the investigation was handed over to the agency when the Congress-led UPA was in power at the Centre and the BJP was ruling Chhattisgarh.

The May 25, 2013 attack in Bastar’s Jhiram Valley had wiped out almost the entire top leadership of the Congress in Chhattisgarh.

President Murmu honours 82 teachers with national awards

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Every child who ever felt small in a large classroom, every first-generation learner who walked into a city school still carrying the dust of a village one, has at some point been rescued by a teacher who noticed. President Droupadi Murmu built her Teachers’ Day address around that quiet act of noticing, as she conferred National Awards on teachers from across the country at a function in New Delhi on Friday.

Speaking at the event, Murmu said education remains the most effective means of realising the constitutional ideal of equality of opportunity. She said India’s achievement of a negligible primary school dropout rate had been made possible through the sustained efforts of teachers, and she commended them for this national success.

Murmu said school education forms the foundation of the entire education system. She said knowledge and skills can be acquired at any stage of life, but lessons in good conduct instilled during childhood prove far more lasting. She said teachers, by diligently attending to the intellectual, physical and moral development of children in early grades, help prepare future



generations of capable students and responsible citizens.

The President spoke at length about the diverse backgrounds students come from, noting that many belong to economically disadvantaged families, some are first-generation learners, others move from ordinary village schools into large city institutions, some are naturally shy, some possess considerable talent but lack self-confidence, and some are children with special needs. She said it falls specifically on teachers to instil confidence in such students and lift up anyone who, for whatever reason, feels inadequate in the classroom.

Murmu said academic excellence, skill development and entrepreneurship carry enormous weight in the country’s development trajectory. She said establishing India as the skill capital of the world and transforming it into a knowledge superpow-

er remain among the nation’s key priorities.

She said the country is moving toward the goal of building a Viksit Bharat, a developed India, and that this goal can only be realised through a world-class education system. She described teachers as the ones who breathe life into that system, and said the collective effort must ensure that not a single student in the country is deprived of access to quality education. She said teachers should work to instil knowledge, inspiration, morality and sensitivity in every student through their affection and dedication.

The National Awards to Teachers are conferred annually on Teachers’ Day, observed on September 5 to mark the birth anniversary of Dr Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan, the country’s first Vice President and second President, who was also a distinguished philosopher and educator.

Congress slams advance Census in poll-bound States, sees plot

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Saturday accused the Modi Government of “shoddy planning” in advancing the population enumeration exercise in states likely to go to polls early next year, and alleged that “some nefarious political calculations” were behind the move.

Population enumeration for Census 2027 will take place in Goa, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and parts of Uttarakhand from December 1, 2026, to January 4, 2027, the Registrar General of India said on Saturday, advancing the exercise in the states likely to go to polls early next year.



Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh

In a gazette notification, the Registrar General of India (RGI) and Census Commissioner of India, Mrityunjay Kumar Narayan, said the citizens in these areas can avail the option for self-enumeration from November 16 to November 30, 2026.

Reacting to the development, Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said, “The population enumeration that was to take place in February 2027 as part of the Census 2027 exercise (that was due in 2021) has been advanced in UP, Punjab, Uttarakhand and

Goa where elections are due early next year.”

“This shows shoddy planning since it was known that these elections were due. Why the sudden dawn of wisdom? Undoubtedly there are some nefarious political calculations afoot,” he said in a post on X.

He also alleged that question number 10 on caste was “deliberately very poorly designed” and would render the caste census exercise meaningless.

“The LoP-IS (Rahul Gandhi) and LoP-RS (Mallikarjun Kharge) had written to the PM on Aug 20, 2026 on this issue. Clearly, their pleas for mid-course correction and their constructive sugges-

tions to follow the Bihar and Telangana questionnaire model have been totally ignored,” he said.

The notification said the conduct of the Census of the population shall be undertaken in the States of Goa, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and areas other than snow-bound areas of the State of Uttarakhand, from 1st December, 2026 to 4th January, 2027 with a revisional round from 5th January, 2027 to 9th January, 2027.

It said the reference date for Census 2027 for Goa, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and Uttarakhand, other than snow-bound areas of the state, shall be 00:00 hours of January 5, 2027.

NHRC action on custodial-torture complaint indicts Punjab Govt: BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

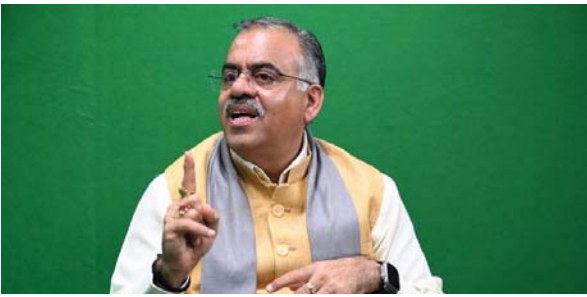
BJP leader Tarun Chugh on Saturday said the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) has taken cognisance of his complaint over the alleged custodial torture of a Sikh man who waved a black flag at a programme of Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann.

A day earlier, Chugh had urged the NHRC to take suo-motu (on its own) cognisance of the alleged custodial torture of Mohanjeet Singh, who waved a black

flag at Mann’s programme in Sheron village on September 2 to protest against the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) Government’s handling of the drug menace in Punjab.

Chugh had requested the NHRC to send an independent fact-finding team to the village where the incident took place and the police station concerned, and direct the registration of an FIR against the officers involved, including the deputy superintendent of police (DSP).

The Rajya Sabha MP had also sought security and



BJP leader Tarun Chugh

medical assistance for the victim and his family, alleging that they face serious threats from the state machinery.

The commission has taken cognisance of Chugh’s letter and written to the Punjab Government over the matter.

Sharing the NHRC letter on X, Chugh said the commission’s action is a “serious” development and a “strong indictment” of the AAP Government’s handling of human rights in Punjab.

“The Commission has ordered an immediate inquiry, medico-legal examination, preservation of CCTV footage and police records, and a point-wise Action Taken Report within two weeks,” he said, adding that the action came even as Mann has “merely” transferred the DSP involved in the matter.

Build parallel reservoir if silt removal fails: Vijayendra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Koppal (Karnataka)

Karnataka BJP chief BY Vijayendra on Saturday demanded that the state Government take an immediate decision on constructing a parallel reservoir if scientific desilting of the Tungabhadra reservoir is found to be technically or economically unviable.

He was speaking after the fifth day of the BJP’s ‘Ballari Chalo’ *padayatra* (foot march), which covered around 20 km and concluded

near Marali village on the outskirts of Gangavathi amid a large turnout and enthusiastic reception from villagers.

The day’s *padayatra* began with the felicitation of teachers on the occasion of Teachers’ Day.

Addressing the gathering, the BJP chief said experts should immediately examine whether the large quantity of silt accumulated in the Tungabhadra reservoir could be removed scientifically.

“If experts conclude that desilting is not possible or is not economically viable, the



Karnataka BJP chief BY Vijayendra

Government should not delay the matter. Funds should be earmarked in the budget and work on a parallel reservoir should be taken up immediately. Farmers should not be made to wait for another

four or five years,” he said.

Claiming that the reservoir is estimated to have around 34 TMC of silt, Vijayendra said the Government should give a clear account of the technology required for its removal, the time it would take and the estimated cost.

He also sought a detailed discussion in the Legislative Assembly on the proposed parallel reservoir, including its initial and final cost estimates, completion timeline and the financial burden on the State.

“Earlier, ₹14 crore was earmarked for preparing the DPR for a parallel reservoir, but the project did not move forward. The project is now estimated to cost around Rs 22,000 crore. We need clarity on the cost and the financial implications,” he said.

The BJP State president cautioned against cost escalation during execution.

“A project should not be announced at ₹15,000 crore or ₹22,000 crore and eventually end up costing ₹35,000 crore. This is taxpayers’ money,” he said.

Pakistan will remain major security concern: Ex-CDS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nearly a month after Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye signed a key joint defence agreement, former CDS Gen Anil Chauhan on Saturday said such accords may induce “overconfidence” in Pakistan, which may lead Islamabad to make another “miscalculation.”

Delivering a lecture on ‘Threats and Challenges to India’s Security’ at an event hosted at the Teen Murti Bhawan complex here, he also said, “Pakistan will remain, I think, a major security concern and a threat for times to come.”

He further said that Operation Sindoor, holding of Indus Water Treaty in abeyance and some practical measures may “hopefully change or induce behavioural change in our neighbour.”



Former CDS Gen Anil Chauhan

kind of agreements and accords that they have recently signed. This sometimes, I feel, may induce some kind of overconfidence into Pakistan, and they may make some kind of a miscalculation again. We’ve got to be careful about that,” the former CDS said.

Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye on August 7 signed the ‘Makkah Joint Defence Agreement’ under which an attack against one of them

will be treated as an attack against all of them. The move had come amid increasing security concerns in the wake of escalating tensions in West Asia. Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman and Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan had signed the pact after the Makkah Al-Mukarramah Summit for Joint Defence at the Al-Safa Palace in Islam’s holiest city of Mecca, according to a joint

statement issued by the three countries earlier.

Gen Chauhan (ret’d) was delivering the 22nd Bharat Ratna Pt Govind Ballabh Pant Memorial Lecture to a packed audience, becoming the first speaker from an armed forces background to do so.

“India’s external threat environment is shared by a large number of factors: unresolved borders... cross-border terrorism, non-state actors, contested spaces which are known as global commons, then expanding cooperation and competition in space, cyber and the maritime domain. These factors interact. They cannot be examined in separate compartments; they have to be looked at in one perspective,” he said.

“Let me talk about our western neighbour. So Pakistan will remain, I think, a major security concern and a threat for times to come,” the former CDS cautioned.

Human element remains decisive in modern war: Navy chief Swaminathan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Chief of Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swaminathan on Saturday called upon newly commissioned officers of the OTA, heading to their first postings, to build courage like a muscle, as the human element remains the decisive factor in the modern battlefield.

He reminded them that the outcomes of modern combat will always be determined by leaders who inspire, persist, and persevere. “That the character of warfare may have changed in many ways, but fundamentally, war still remains a profoundly human endeavour. Combat operations may see new weapons being used across new domains, but their outcomes shall



continue to be determined by the men and women who fight, lead, inspire, persist and persevere,” the naval chief said.

This was the conviction that grew stronger in him after nearly four decades in uniform, he said at the event of reviewing an impressive Passing Out Parade of the SCC-122 and SSC (W)-36

courses at the historic Parameswaran Drill Square of the Officers Training Academy in Chennai.

Admiral Swaminathan congratulated the 365 graduating cadets — including 17 officers from friendly foreign nations — as they completed their rigorous training to receive the President’s Commission.

On the changing dynamics of modern wars, Admiral Swaminathan highlighted the dramatic transformation of warfare, drawing from nearly four decades of service since his commissioning in 1987.

While acknowledging that modern combat involves long-range precision strikes, advanced sensors, and multi-domain operations, he asserted that outcomes still rested on the men and women who lead.

He suggested five core principles to help the young officers navigate future challenges, and they include treating the mind as the primary weapon, remaining a lifelong student, building courage as a muscle, instinctively place service before self, and make trust their currency.



States Focus



VP RADHAKRISHNAN TO VISIT FOUR NORTHEASTERN STATES

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan will visit four northeastern States from Sunday, where he will be participating in a series of cultural and academic engagements, according to an official statement.

Radhakrishnan will visit Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur and Arunachal Pradesh from September 6 to 9, his office said on Saturday. During his visit, the vice president will participate in a series of academic, cultural and public engagements, besides visiting institutions of historical, social and national significance, it said. On September 6, Radhakrishnan will arrive in Guwahati to attend the golden jubilee celebrations of Geetanagar College, formerly known as Kanya Mahavidyalaya. He will later attend the convocation ceremony of Srimanta Sankaradeva University of Health Sciences. On September 7, the vice president will attend a foundation stone laying programme at Gauhati University, followed by an interaction with students, faculty members and leading citizens at the university's convention centre. (PTI)



CURRENT FORMAT OF CASTE CENSUS FLAWED, SAYS GEHLOT

Senior Congress leader Ashok Gehlot said here on Saturday that the current format of the caste census is "fundamentally flawed", and alleged it indicated the Narendra Modi Government lacks honest intent regarding the exercise. He said the "flawed" caste census will hurt the OBCs (Other Backward Classes), EBCs (Extremely Backward Classes), and marginalized sections the most.

The existing questionnaire of the caste census must be scrapped and a new questionnaire should be prepared based on a verified list of castes (a dropdown list), following the methodology adopted in Telangana and Bihar, the former Rajasthan chief minister demanded. (PTI)

Kashmiri Pandits hold strike, demand separate homeland

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jammu

A large number of displaced Kashmiri Pandits, under the banner of Panun Kashmir, on Saturday observed a one-day hunger strike demanding the creation of a separate homeland for their rehabilitation in the Kashmir Valley and formal recognition of what it describes as the "genocide" of the community, enactment of a genocide law.

Staging a sit-in dharna outside Press Club, Jammu, displaced Kashmiri Pandits, with placards in their hands, raised slogans in support of their demands and warned the Government against ignoring their long-pending demands.

Panun Kashmir convener Agnishekhar said the hunger strike by Panun Kashmir activists, including women members, was part of a struggle that had continued since the displacement of the community from the Valley.



"We demand that our return to the Kashmir Valley should be facilitated through a separate homeland with Union Territory status," he said.

He alleged that the community had experienced "continuous genocide" over centuries and believed that a separate Union Territory was the only lasting solution.

"The proposed homeland would enable Kashmiri Pandits living across the world to return to the Valley

and ensure that no force can ever drive us out again," he said.

Panun Kashmir Chairman Tito Ganju said the community had been seeking formal recognition of the alleged genocide for the past 37 years. "We suffered a genocide, and we want that genocide to be formally recognised," he said, claiming that while references to the term had been made in Parliament, there was still no formal recogni-

tion by the Government. He also demanded enactment of a specific genocide law, arguing that India, being a signatory to the Genocide Convention, was obligated to bring such legislation.

Ganju said Panun Kashmir had itself proposed a Bill in 2020 and wanted the Government to constitute a commission to examine the issue and deliberate on legislation.

"After 37 years, the community that is the victim community still has to protest for justice and livelihood," he said, listing the organisation's three principal demands as "recognition of the genocide, enactment of a genocide law and a separate homeland".

He also demanded 15,000 jobs through the Central Government for unemployed Kashmiri Pandit youth and an increase in the monthly ex-gratia relief to displaced families to at least ₹25,000.

Crisis of credibility biggest problem in media sector, says Nitin Gadkari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Nagpur

Union minister Nitin Gadkari on Saturday stressed the importance of an independent judiciary and media for the progress of a democracy, and said that among all institutions, the media suffered the biggest problem of a crisis of credibility.

The Road Transport and Highways Minister was addressing a gathering at IIM Nagpur Media Conclave 2026 on the theme of 'Media, Leadership and the New World Order'.

Chief Executive Officer and Editor-in-Chief of the Press Trust of India (PTI) Vijay Joshi, Editorial Director at Business Standard A K Bhattacharya, and Chairman and Editor-in-Chief of Blitz India Media Group Deepak Dwivedi were



among those present at the event. "India is the mother of democracy, and it is the largest democracy in the world," Gadkari said.

Seeking a qualitative transformation in democracy, he said, "The Constitution has very clearly specified the responsibilities of the four pillars of democracy, that is, legislature, executive, judiciary and media. Independent, impartial and fair judiciary and

media are very important for the progress and development of a democracy."

Politics and political parties are the biggest strength of a democracy, he said. "There can be differences of opinion or ideological differences, but there should be commitment towards one's ideology," the veteran politician said. He also made a pitch for raising public awareness on social, economic, educational issues in order to strengthen democracy.

"Awareness among people about democracy and democratic values, and commitment of people with democratic values and ideology are very important," he said. Credibility, goodwill and honesty are the biggest capitals of the 21st century for all sectors, Gadkari noted.

BJP alleges paper loot in JPSC forest services exams

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The BJP on Saturday alleged a "paper loot" in the exams conducted for filling the posts of assistant conservators of forest and forest range officers in Jharkhand, and demanded answers from Congress leader Rahul Gandhi.

Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters, party spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi claimed that a probe into the alleged irregularities in the recruitment exams in Jharkhand has brought to light that changes were made in the answer scripts after breaking into the strong room.

The investigation conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) has revealed "startling facts" that expose the "true reality" of the Congress-led INDIA bloc's stance on student interests, he said.

"During the investiga-



Sudhanshu Trivedi

tion into the exams conducted for filling the posts of assistant conservators of forest and forest range officers, facts have emerged that changes were made in the question papers (answer scripts) after breaking into the strong room where they were kept," Trivedi said.

"It was not a case of paper leak. It was a case of paper loot," the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader said, asking Gandhi, "Who gave this 'loot ki choot' (licence to loot)?"

Ganga breaches record level; 10 lakh hit in Bihar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Patna

Around 10.26 lakh people across 11 districts of Bihar have been affected by floods, while the Ganga water level breached the 'highest flood mark' at Gandhi Ghat and Pandarak here on Saturday morning, amid heavy rain in the State, official bulletins said.

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Saturday conducted an aerial survey of flood-hit areas in Bhagalpur and Naugachia and reviewed relief and rescue operations.

In a post on X, the CM said, "Officials have been directed to ensure timely arrangements, adequate relief supplies and prompt rescue



An aerial view of the flood-affected Punpun area following a rise in the water level of the Punpun river in Patna on Saturday

PTI

measures, with priority given to public safety and preventing any hardship to affected people".

Choudhary directed ministers and officials to visit flood-affected areas and closely monitor relief and rescue operations.

The Ganga was flowing

above the 'highest flood mark' at two places at 10 am, posing a risk of inundation in low-lying areas in the State's Capital, a Water Resources Department bulletin said. People have been asked to exercise caution in view of the rising water level of the river.

BJP hits out at Congress over Telangana minister's sacking

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The BJP criticised the Congress on Saturday over the sacking of Forest Minister Konda Surekha from the Council of Ministers in Telangana, alleging that the action shows the grand old party is against giving representation to women in politics.

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy sacked Surekha with immediate effect on Thursday, amid a row over remarks made against him and others by the woman leader's daughter. Surekha, on her part, claimed she did nothing wrong and accused Reddy of "blackmail politics." Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters here, party spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi termed the sacking as "unfortunate" and said the



Forest minister Konda Surekha

action reflects the difference between the Congress's words and its deeds.

He also questioned the silence of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and party leaders Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on the development.

"Besides Rahul Gandhi, Kharge, who recently wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi demanding immediate implementation of 33 per cent reservation for women

(in the Lok Sabha and state legislative assemblies), is also silent on the issue," Trivedi said. "This has exposed their real face. The Congress is completely opposed to giving women representation in politics in its thoughts, words and deeds. The difference between the Congress's words and deeds is clearly visible now," the BJP Rajya Sabha MP added.

With the removal of Surekha in Telangana, just three women ministers are left in the Congress-ruled states, Trivedi said.

"In Congress-ruled Telangana, one of the two women ministers has been removed. In Kerala, there are only two women in the Cabinet. In Himachal Pradesh and Karnataka ruled by the Congress, there is not a single woman in the Cabinet," he said.

BJP seeking to win next Telangana Assembly polls through vote removal during SIR: Revanth Reddy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Hyderabad

Accusing the NDA Government at the Centre of resorting to a vote theft conspiracy in non-BJP ruled States, Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Saturday alleged that the BJP is making attempts to win the next Assembly elections in Telangana by deleting votes of Congress supporters during SIR of electoral roll.

Reddy, who attended a meeting of Congress leaders and workers in his Kodangal assembly constituency, alleged that the BJP won Maharashtra, Bihar, and West Bengal elections through vote removal during Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral roll. The BJP is now adopting the same "deceitful tactic" in Telangana and the party



Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy

targeted SC, ST and Minority voters in the SIR for removal, he claimed.

"We will not sit idle and are ready to counter the BJP's move to delete the names of the Congress supporters. The party workers will not tolerate any such attempt," a release quoted Revanth Reddy as saying.

The chief minister also

alleged that the BJP exploited ED and CBI to defeat political rivals in the previous elections and the party is now resorting to deletion of votes.

The CM strongly objected to the alleged deletion of votes citing minor errors as a pretext, the release said.

Reddy further said the BRS was also supporting the

BJP in the deletion of votes to defeat the Congress.

He stressed that the responsibility of "safeguarding the right to vote" lies with all Congress workers and leaders, the release said. The Congress Booth Level Agents (BLAs) should coordinate at the village level to ensure that the votes of the poor are not deleted, he said. The CM instructed that each mandal-level leader should take responsibility of four villages and ensure that not a single vote is deleted from any booth.

"Everyone must remain vigilant and thwart the conspiracies of the BJP and BRS," he said. Reddy also said Kodangal constituency gained national recognition and respect because the local people extended all kinds of support to him.

Boy among two dead in dahi handi celebrations in Maharashtra; 42 govindas injured in Mumbai, Thane

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Dahi Handi celebrations claimed the lives of two persons in Maharashtra as a seven-year-old boy died after a brick column collapsed on him in Mumbai, while a woman was crushed to death under an iron frame in Pune, officials said on Saturday.

Besides, at least 32 'Govindas' were injured in Mumbai and 10 others in neighbouring Thane during the formation of human pyramids as part of the celebrations. Dahi Handi, which is part of the Janmashtami festival that marks the birth of Lord Krishna, is seeing enthusiastic participation by the revellers across the state. As part of the celebrations, 'Govindas' form multi-tier human pyramids to break



Representative image

Dahi Handis (clay pots filled with curd) suspended mid-air. In Mumbai, the death of the boy occurred at Ekta Welfare Society at Chikuwadi in Malvani around 3 pm, they said.

It happened when a group of children was celebrating Dahi Handi on their own. They had tied the one end of the rope holding the handi to a tree and the other end to a

brick column of a ground-floor structure.

As the children tried to break the handi, the brick column suddenly collapsed, hitting seven-year-old Rudra Kadam on the head. He was immediately rushed to Malvani General Hospital, where doctors declared him dead, the officials said.

Ward staff and police personnel were mobilised fol-

lowing the incident.

In Pune, Salma Salauddin Pathan, a resident of the Old Sangavi area in Pimpri Chinchwad, died after a temporary iron structure erected to support a stack of loudspeakers for a Dahi Handi event collapsed on her on Friday night, police said.

Workers were dismantling the iron frame after the event organised by the Vighnaharta Mandal concluded, and a heavy portion fell on Pathan. She sustained a serious head injury and was rushed to a hospital, where doctors declared her dead, they said.

Pathan's son was an office-bearer of the organising mandal, and her family declined to lodge a complaint against the organisers and urged the police not to register a case on their own, police said.

MP youth's mission to clean Ajnar River gets civic support

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bhopal

Wading into a polluted river with little more than determination, 21-year-old BSc student Surendra Singh Chaudhary has been trying to reclaim the Ajnar River in Biaoara from years of accumulated garbage and debris. His initiative, started on January 26, has now received support from the local municipality, which has deployed heavy machinery for the clean-up.

Known on social media as 'Bittu Tabahi', Chaudhary initially undertook the work largely on his own, removing plastic, polythene and other waste from the river. He regularly shared photographs documenting the condition of the river and the progress of his campaign, drawing attention to the pollution of the water body.

The clean-up has involved



considerable health and safety risks. Chaudhary suffered infections in his limbs while working in the polluted water, particularly near a local temple, and also encountered snakes during the operation. Despite the difficulties, he continued the campaign. His efforts eventually prompted local residents and civic officials to participate. Biaoara municipal sub-engineer Rupesh Kumar Netam said the municipality provided a Poclain excavator to remove old waste, debris and polythene that

had accumulated in the river. Residents also joined the clean-up drive.

Netam said the municipality undertakes cleaning of the river and drains every year before the monsoon. The increased water flow during the rainy season subsequently helps wash away some of the remaining debris. He also confirmed that the before-and-after photographs shared by Chaudhary on social media were authentic and reflected the actual condition of the river at different stages

of the clean-up. Officials, however, said the visible garbage is only one part of the problem. Five major drains discharge wastewater into the river, making untreated sewage a major source of pollution.

To address the problem at its source, the municipality has prepared a proposal to construct a sewage treatment plant (STP) at an estimated cost of ₹14.77 crore. The proposed facility would treat wastewater before it is discharged into the river.

Chaudhary's campaign has consequently turned the Ajnar River into a subject of wider civic discussion. What started as an individual effort has brought residents and the municipality together, while the proposed sewage treatment plant is expected to provide a more sustainable response to the river's long-standing pollution problem.



Tata Trusts: Vijay Singh's complaint backfires

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

A complaint by Tata Trusts vice-chairman Vijay Singh seeking an inquiry into a decades-old transfer of Tata Sons shares has ended with an outcome he may not have anticipated: the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner has closed the complaint while making adverse observations about Singh's own conduct as a trustee.

In an order dated September 2, 2026, the Charity Commissioner rejected Singh's plea for an independent investigation into the 1989 transfer of 833 shares of Tata Sons Private Limited from the Navajbai Ratan Tata Trust (NRTT) to Naval H Tata, father of Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata.

Singh had approached the Charity Commissioner on June 10, 2026, questioning the transaction. But rather than ordering the investigation he sought, the regulator closed the matter and recorded observations that could have wider implications for Singh's position as a trustee.

According to a Tata Trusts statement quoting the order, the Charity Commissioner noted that Singh had not made his complaint email available to the Trust. The authority said this indicated an intention to "suppress



Tata Trusts vice-chairman Vijay Singh

this from the other Trustees and the Trust as a whole."

The Commissioner further observed that Singh's actions had damaged the reputation and goodwill of the Trust and described his conduct as "unbecoming of a Trustee of NRTT." The observations shift the focus of the dispute from the historical share transfer to the manner in which a sitting trustee pursued the complaint. The Charity Commissioner also examined the sequence of events surrounding Singh's complaint.

On June 8, 2026, Singh participated in a meeting of the NRTT board at which he was party to a resolution authorising representation of the Trust's case before the Charity Commissioner. Just two days later, on June 10, Singh independently approached the

same authority seeking an inquiry into the 1989 share transfer. That sequence appears to have been significant in the regulator's assessment of Singh's conduct.

On the substantive issue raised by Singh, the complaint was closed and the basis for seeking an independent investigation was rejected. The result represents a significant setback for Singh's challenge to the transaction, which dates back more than three decades.

It also provides a degree of regulatory vindication to Tata Trusts and its chairman Noel Tata, who had been drawn into the dispute because of the historical transfer involving Naval H Tata. Under Section 41D of the Act, the Charity Commissioner has powers, after following the prescribed procedure, to

suspend, remove or dismiss a trustee in specified circumstances, including continuous neglect of duty, malfeasance, misfeasance and breach of trust. Such proceedings may be initiated on an application, following a statutory report, or suo motu by the Charity Commissioner.

The latest observations do not by themselves mean that Singh faces removal proceedings. However, the regulator's findings that his actions damaged the Trust's reputation and that his conduct was "unbecoming of a trustee" could become relevant if his conduct is questioned in future governance or regulatory proceedings.

For Tata Trusts and Noel Tata, the order amounts to a significant reprieve. For Singh, the episode leaves a more complicated outcome: the transaction he sought to challenge has not been subjected to the independent inquiry he demanded, while his own conduct has come under formal regulatory scrutiny.

The Pioneer also reached out to Vijay Singh over message seeking his response to the Charity Commissioner's observations and the closure of his complaint. However, Singh neither issued a statement nor responded to the message seeking his comments.

Adani Defence & Aerospace signs five-year ammunition supply pact for AK-203 rifles



Gautam Adani, AK-47 (L-R)



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Adani Defence & Aerospace has signed a five-year agreement with Indo-Russian Rifles Pvt Ltd to supply indigenously produced 7.62x39 mm ammunition for AK-203 assault rifles being manufactured in India, creating an integrated domestic supply chain for the India-Russia rifle programme.

Under the agreement, Adani Defence will supply the small-calibre ammunition required for the AK-203 programme for five years, providing an Indian source of supply and supporting continuity of ammunition availability over the contract period, according to the company.

The pact brings together rifle production by Indo-Russian Rifles, or IRRPL, and ammunition manufacturing by Adani Defence, linking two parts of the AK-203 pro-

gramme within India's defence manufacturing ecosystem.

IRRPL was established in 2019 under an India-Russia intergovernmental agreement to manufacture AK-203 rifles for the Indian Armed Forces. Its manufacturing facility is located at Korwa in Uttar Pradesh's Amethi district.

The joint venture has Indian shareholders Advanced Weapons and Equipment India Ltd and Munitions India Ltd, along with Russian shareholders Concern Kalashnikov and Rosoboronexport.

The Ministry of Defence has identified IRRPL as the joint venture responsible for indigenous production of the AK-203. The Government signed a contract with the company in December 2021 for 6,01,427 AK-203 rifles, which are to be manufactured at the Korwa facility.

The latest agreement expands the domestic manufacturing footprint around the programme by pairing locally produced rifles with locally manufactured ammunition, according to the firm.

Adani Defence has established small-calibre ammunition manufacturing capabilities in India, including a production facility in Kanpur. The agreement would further strengthen domestic capabilities across the small-arms supply chain and support the Government's Aatmanirbhar Bharat push for greater self-reliance in defence manufacturing.

The agreement also deepens the localisation of an India-Russia defence programme that was originally established to manufacture AK-203 rifles domestically, reducing reliance on external sources for a key consumable required for the weapon system.

NIMAS scales 20 unclimbed Ladakh peaks in 23 days

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

In a landmark achievement for Indian mountaineering, the National Institute of Mountaineering and Adventure Sports (NIMAS), based in Dirang, Arunachal Pradesh, has scripted history by successfully summiting 20 unclimbed peaks above 6,000 metres in Ladakh. The elite expedition team accomplished the extraordinary feat of recording 20 first-ever summits in just 23 days.

Under the leadership of Colonel Ranveer Singh Jamwal, Director, NIMAS, the institute has secured its third consecutive world record in three years. The expedition underscores the institution's capability to execute technically demanding assignments across some of the most remote and hazardous Himalayan terrains.

Operating under the Ministry of Defence, NIMAS remains India's premier institution offering comprehensive training across land, air, and water-based adventure disciplines. From white-



water rafting, scuba diving, and mountain biking to paragliding and mountaineering, the institution has emerged as a crucial hub for youth development and adventure sports in the North-East.

Officials noted that the success aligns with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call for the nation's youth to engage in fitness, adventure, and exploration as drivers of personal growth and national progress. Embracing the ethos of the Fit India move-

ment, the expedition aimed to inspire young citizens to step beyond virtual environments and build resilience, teamwork, and physical endurance.

The historic campaign also highlights the growing potential of North-Eastern institutions to deliver world-class feats. By fostering discipline and adventure sports leadership, NIMAS continues to cement Arunachal Pradesh and the wider region as a major force in national excellence and exploration.

Over 500 global investors to join iBRICS summit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 500 institutional investors, pension funds, and family offices managing a total wealth of over \$1 trillion will participate in the inaugural iBRICS Summit 2026 here next week, organisers said on Saturday.

The two-day summit, convened alongside the 18th BRICS Summit in the National Capital on September 12-13, is designed to connect sovereign capital with bankable infrastructure, energy, and digital capacity projects across the 21 BRICS member states and partner nations, the Sovereign Wealth Fund Institute

(SWFI) said in a statement.

The summit comes at a critical juncture as BRICS economies adapt to shifting trade dynamics, US tariff pressures, and high dollar-clearing costs, SWFI Chairman and Lead Co-Chair of iBRICS, Lakshmi Narayanan, said.

"With tariffs and sanctions stressing traditional corridors, funds and ministries need direct access to allocate capital differently. We are providing that dedicated venue alongside the Leaders' Summit," Narayanan said.

The participants will also link national fast-payment networks (like India's UPI and Brazil's Pix) and CBDC interoperability.



Noida hikes farmers' land compensation to ₹6,459/sqm

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

In a major push towards farmer-centric development, civic infrastructure, and long-pending real estate resolutions, the New Okhla Industrial Development Authority (NOIDA) approved a range of key decisions during its 223rd board meeting chaired by Infrastructure and Industrial Development Commissioner Deepak Kumar.

Under a key decision, the Board approved a 53 per cent hike in land compensation for farmers, increasing the rate to ₹6,459 per square metre alongside a 5 per cent developed residential (abadi) plot for land acquired via mutual agreement. Compensation rates in DNGIR (New Noida) have also been aligned with Greater Noida and Yamuna Expressway authority norms to ensure farmers become active partners in the region's economic growth.

Addressing legacy stalled real estate projects, officials revealed that ₹561.35 crore



has been collected across 36 projects following Government relief policies, with instructions issued to expedite pending property registrations for homebuyers. To streamline civic operations, the Board approved a Standard Operating Procedure for a 'One-Time Lease Rent - Corpus Fund' to secure non-recurring revenue for long-term maintenance of sanitation, public health, and water supply.

Key decisions also included allocating 13,347.18 square metres of land in

Sector-153 for the Gautam Buddha Nagar Police Commissionerate Office, setting up a 100 TPD waste-to-energy plant in Sector-145, and modernising the Sector-8 nursery on a Build, Operate, and Maintain model. Additionally, the Board approved a tripartite sub-lease deed framework to grant property rights to present occupants in cooperative housing societies and agreed to form a joint committee with Greater Noida to draft a uniform industrial policy.

NCLT stays disposal of BYJU's K3-linked assets auctioned for ₹16 crore, flags valuation concern

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The insolvency tribunal NCLT has ordered a status quo on the assets sold by the resolution professional of Think and Learn Private Limited, the parent entity of debt-ridden edutech firm BYJU's, in one of its subsidiaries.

The Bengaluru-based bench of the NCLT has put a hold on any further disposal of BYJU's K3 Education's assets till the next hearing on September 21 amid allegations that assets worth around ₹150 crore were sold for just about ₹16 crore.

"The RP of TLPL (Think and Learn Private Limited) and the said newly impleaded Respondent are directed to maintain status quo in respect of the articles/equipment/assets auctioned under notice dated August 2, 2026, issued by the former, till next date," said a two-member bench.

The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order came earlier this week over a plea moved by the resolution professional (RP) of BYJU's K3 Education, which is also facing insolvency proceedings, and Kritikal



Solutions, seeking protection of the assets pending verification of ownership and auction proceeds.

They had contended that even the RP of TLPL has not produced any documentary evidence of the articles auctioned, to claim ownership.

Moreover, the bidder, Comprint Tech Solutions, to whom the assets were sold has its registered address in an under-construction building which was found locked on repeat visits. At least 15 vehicles loaded with the assets had already left the warehouse for Mumbai in the preceding days, they said.

"Since the articles worth about ₹150 crore have been auctioned for about ₹16

crore, the bidder is likely to get rid of same to save itself from being entangled in litigation," the NCLT noted in its order.

Moreover, the suspended directors of BYJU's supported the plea and said that there was no need to hurry to auction the articles in the way it has all been processed.

They submitted that CIRP (Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process) is being conducted for revival of TLPL and does not call for auction of its assets and that too for meagre value.

The tribunal noted that the current status of the auctioned assets was "not known", and held that a stay on any further alienation was

warranted at this stage.

"It is not going to irretrievably prejudice anybody, including the successful bidder," it said, adding that the status quo would hold "at least until some concrete evidence comes up".

The NCLT allowed an application to implead Comprint Tech Solutions as a party to the proceedings and directed it to file, within a week, a sworn inventory of the assets it had purchased, along with their storage location and supporting photographs.

The RP of TLPL was also directed to comply within a week with an earlier order of August 20 requiring it to furnish transaction-related details.

Bank unions to go ahead with September 11 strike as talks fail

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a major setback to banking services across the country, the United Forum of Bank Unions (UFBU) has decided to proceed with its proposed nationwide strike on September 11, after conciliation talks with the Indian Banks' Association (IBA) failed to yield any positive outcome.

The decision was announced following a meeting between the IBA management and representatives of all seven constituent unions of the UFBU. The IBA delegation was led by Chief Executive AK Goel, Dy Chief Executive Gopal Murli Bhagat, and Sr Advisor (HR&IR) Arvind Misra.

During the meeting, IBA Chief Executive AK Goel appealed to the unions to defer the agitation, pointing out that a strike would severely disrupt economic activities and public banking services. He urged union leaders to resolve all pending issues bilaterally through continued discussions.

However, the UFBU reject-



Bank strike

FILE PHOTO

ed the appeal, stating that key demands — including the implementation of five-day banking and modifications to the Performance Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme — have been brushed aside for too long. Union leaders noted that despite prior assurances from Department of Financial Services (DFS) officials that five-day banking was being prioritised at the highest level in Government, no progress has been made since the deferment of their

March 2025 strike call.

The unions also expressed strong resentment against the Government and DFS for unilaterally directing banks to implement what they termed a "discriminatory" PLI scheme for Scale IV officers and above, even while the matter remains pending before the Chief Labour Commissioner (CLC).

With residual issues remaining unresolved and no concrete assurances provided during the talks, the

UFBU leadership issued a call to all member unions and workers to intensify preparation efforts and ensure full participation in the September 11 strike action.

The circular issued by the UFBU was jointly signed by key union representatives, including CH Venkatachalam (AIBE), Rupam Roy (AIBOC), L Chandrasekhar (NCBE), Sanjay Khan (AIBOA), Debashish Basu Choudhary (BEFI), Prem Makker (INBOC), and OP Sharma (INBEF).

FROM THE
WORLD

SRI LANKA

Navy saves
8 people

The Sri Lanka Navy on Saturday rescued eight people, who were found stranded on a remote sandbank off Thalaimannar after travelling from India. “Preliminary inquiries revealed that the group had travelled from Rameshwaram, India and had reportedly been abandoned in the area in connection with an alleged human smuggling operation”, the Navy said in a statement. The group, which included children aged two, 11 and 14, was detected by naval personnel during an early morning patrol, it said. The Navy provided the stranded people with drinking water, food and temporary shelter after finding them in distress. The individuals are believed to be returnees from the Anaiyur and Okkur refugee camps in southern India, the statement said. They are currently under the Navy's care and will be handed over to the relevant civilian authorities for further action, it said. (PTI)

Two more survivors rescued from flood-ravaged Nepal

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Two more people have been found alive in Nepal following days of intensive rescue operations in areas devastated by deadly floods, bringing the number of recent survivors pulled from collapsed structures and underground tunnels to four.

Among the latest survivors were a Chinese national trapped inside a hydropower tunnel and a 64-year-old woman who was buried inside a flood-damaged house in Nuwakot.

The Chinese worker was rescued from a 225-metre tunnel associated with the Trishuli hydropower project. The operation was conducted by Nepali security personnel with assistance from South Korean disaster-response specialists, according to the Nepali Army.

The rescue came a day after two Nepali workers were brought out alive from a tunnel at the Trishuli 3A hydropower plant. The Chinese worker, identified as Luhaitao, was later taken for medical assessment.

Images released by the Nepali Army showed the rescued man being escorted by personnel and later transported by helicopter. He appeared conscious and responsive despite having



Nepalese army personnel rescue a Chinese national from a hydropower tunnel during a search and rescue operation, 11 days after the project was hit by devastating floods in Rasuwa district, Nepal. The man, identified as Luhaitao, was trapped inside Audit Tunnel 4 of the flood-affected Upper Trishuli 1 Hydropower Project

spent days underground, with mud visible on his hands and clothing.

In a separate operation in Nuwakot, emergency teams rescued Chandika Shrestha, 64, from the remains of a house damaged by the floods. Officials said she was subsequently being airlifted to Kathmandu for treatment. Photographs released by Nepal's Armed Police Force showed rescuers carrying Shrestha out of the damaged building while she was wrapped in a grey

blanket. The rescue operations come as authorities continue a massive search for people still unaccounted for after the disaster. Officials said nearly 900 workers are missing from 12 hydropower projects, while about 500 people are believed to remain trapped inside tunnels. The floods struck Nepal on August 26 and are believed to have been linked to a glacier collapse. At least 1,344 people have died, while more than 5,000 remain missing, according to the

country's disaster management authorities.

Rescue and search teams from India, China, Australia and South Korea have joined Nepali personnel in efforts to locate survivors, particularly those believed to be trapped in blocked tunnels.

The scale of the disaster has also created major challenges in identifying victims. Nepal Police said 1,030 bodies had been buried in mass graves after DNA samples were collected to facilitate identification at a later stage.

DNA testing offers last hope to families searching for missing loved ones

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kathmandu

When Amrit Diyali saw a human hand washed downstream by floodwaters, he was struck by how closely it resembled his younger brother Raj Kumar's, who has been missing along with his wife and four-year-old son since the devastating floods hit Nepal.

"I found a hand that looks exactly like uncle's," Diyali's nephew Avinash told him after sending him a photograph of the severed hand, according to *The Kathmandu Post* newspaper.

For Diyali, the discovery brought both hope and dread. A DNA test is now his family's only chance of knowing whether the remains belong to his brother.

The case reflects a much larger challenge facing Nepal, where authorities are relying on DNA testing to identify hundreds of bodies recovered after the August 26 floods and help families find relatives who remain missing. Flash floods, triggered by an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal.



The Bhotekoshi River, which flows south from the Himalayan border region, carried the floodwaters downstream, sweeping away homes, vehicles, roads and bridges and damaging hydropower projects.

Raj Kumar, 33, his 30-year-old wife Shriti and their four-year-old son Siraj were living in Syaphrubesi in Rasuwa district when the Bhotekoshi flood struck. His relatives searched along the river as far as Chitwan and Nawalpur, turning over mud and stones in the hope of finding the family. When they could not find them alive, they began looking for their bodies.

Thousands rally in Croatia demanding urgent cleanup of toxic waste from town

DARKO BANDIC ■ Zagreb

Tens of thousands of people rallied on Saturday in Croatia, furious that authorities for months haven't cleared a huge amount of illegally dumped hazardous waste that has triggered fears of major environmental damage in the European Union country.

The illegal waste scandal in the central town of Gospić has fuelled criticism of conservative Prime Minister Andrej Plenković and his government, which has faced



mounting public anger in recent weeks.

The issue first surfaced last February when Croatian police and Europol, the EU's law enforcement agency, arrested 13 people suspected of illegally importing and disposing of hazardous waste. (AP)

RLF LIMITED

[Corporate Identification Number -L74999HR1979PLC032747]

Registered Office: 14 Kms, Pataudi Road, Village Jhund Sarai Veeran, Gurugram, Haryana, 122016

Corporate Office: D-41, South Extension, Part-II, New Delhi-110049.

Website: www.rlftd.com; **Email:** compliance@rlftd.com; **Telephone:** 011-26258237

NOTICE OF THE 46TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, REMOTE E-VOTING & BOOK CLOSURE

Notice is hereby given that the **46th Annual General Meeting (AGM)** of the Members of **RLF Limited** will be held on Wednesday, **30th September, 2026** at 10:00 A.M. IST at 14 Kms, Pataudi Road, Village Jhund Sarai Veeran, Gurugram, Haryana, 122016 to transact the business (es) as mentioned in the notice of AGM which is being circulated for convening the AGM. The Company has sent the notice of AGM for Financial Year 2025-26 on September 05, 2026 through electronic mode to the members whose email addresses are registered with the Company/Depositories. The Annual Report for Financial Year 2025-26 is available and can be downloaded from the Company's website www.rlftd.com and on the website of stock exchange i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com.

In compliance with section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with rule 20 of The Companies (Management & Administration) Rules, 2014 ("the Rules") including any statutory modification or re-enactment thereof for the time being in force, guidelines prescribed by the MCA, the members are provided with the facility to cast their votes on all resolutions set forth in the notice of AGM using electronic voting system (insta-vote) provided by MUGF Intime India Pvt. Ltd. The voting of members shall be in proportion to the equity shares held by them in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on Wednesday, 23rd September, 2026 ("Cut-off date").

The remote e-voting period commences on Sunday, 27th September, 2026 at 9.00 A.M. and ends on Tuesday, 29th September, 2026 at 5.00 P.M. During this period, members may cast their votes electronically. The remote e-voting module shall be disabled by MUGF Intime India Private Limited (InstaVote) thereafter. The eligible shareholders may also cast their vote at the Annual General Meeting through Venue Voting, and Members who have not already cast their vote by remote e-voting shall be able to exercise their right at the AGM. The Members who have cast their vote by remote e-voting prior to the AGM may also attend the AGM but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again.

The documents pertaining to the items of business to be transacted in the AGM are open for inspection at the Registered Office of the Company during business hours on any working day. Pursuant to regulation 42 of SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 and section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013, The Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company will remain closed from Thursday, 24th September, 2026 to Wednesday, 30th September, 2026 (both days inclusive) for the purpose of 46th AGM of the Company.

Any person who acquires shares and become member of the Company after the dispatch of notice of the AGM by the Company and whose name appear in the register of members of the Company or in the statement of beneficial ownership maintained by the Depositories as on cut-off date i.e. 23rd September, 2026 can view the notice convening the AGM on the website of the Company viz www.rlftd.com website of stock exchange viz BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com. Such members can exercise their voting rights through e-voting by following the procedure as mentioned in the said notice of AGM. Members are also informed that in case shareholders/ investor have any queries regarding E-voting, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions ("FAQs") and insta-Vote e-Voting module available at <https://instavote.linkintime.co.in> under download section or you can email us to enotices@in.mpmns.mugf.com or contact on: - Tel: 022 - **4918 6000**.

For RLF LIMITED

Sd/-

Aditya Khanna

Managing Director

DIN:01860038

Date: 05.09.2026

Place: Haryana

UNITED LEASING AND INDUSTRIES LIMITED

[Corporate Identification Number -L17100HR1983PLC033460]

Registered Office: Plot No 66, Sector-34, EHTP, Gurugram, Haryana, 122001

Corporate Office: D-41, South Extension, Part-II, New Delhi-110049.

Website: www.ulilttd.com; **Email:** teamunited83@gmail.com

NOTICE OF THE 42ND ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, REMOTE E-VOTING & BOOK CLOSURE

Notice is hereby given that the 42nd Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the Members of **United Leasing and Industries Limited** will be held on Wednesday, 30th September, 2026 at 10:30 A.M. IST at 14 Kms, Pataudi Road, Village Jhund Sarai Veeran, Gurugram, Haryana, 122016 to transact the business (es) as mentioned in the notice of AGM which is being circulated for convening the AGM. The Company has sent the notice of AGM for Financial Year 2025-26 on September 05, 2026 through electronic mode to the members whose email addresses are registered with the Company/Depositories. The Annual Report for Financial Year 2025-26 is available and can be downloaded from the Company's website www.ulilttd.com and on the website of stock exchange i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com.

In compliance with section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with rule 20 of The Companies (Management & Administration) Rules, 2014 ("the Rules") including any statutory modification or re-enactment thereof for the time being in force, guidelines prescribed by the MCA, the members are provided with the facility to cast their votes on all resolutions set forth in the notice of AGM using electronic voting system (insta-vote) provided by MUGF Intime India Pvt. Ltd. The voting of members shall be in proportion to the equity shares held by them in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on Wednesday, 23rd September, 2026 ("Cut-off date").

The remote e-voting period commences on **Sunday, 27th September, 2026 at 9.00 A.M. and ends on Tuesday, 29th September, 2026 at 5.00 P.M.** During these period members may cast their votes electronically. The remote e-voting module shall be disabled by MUGF Intime insta-vote thereafter. The eligible shareholders may also cast their vote at the Annual General Meeting through Venue Voting, and Members who have not already cast their vote by remote e-voting shall be able to exercise their right at the AGM. The Members who have cast their vote by remote e-voting prior to the AGM may also attend the AGM but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again.

The documents pertaining to the items of business to be transacted in the AGM are open for inspection at the Registered Office of the Company during business hours on any working day. Pursuant to regulation 42 of SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 and section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013, The Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company will remain closed from Thursday, 24th September, 2026 to Wednesday, 30th September, 2026 (both days inclusive) for the purpose of 42nd AGM of the Company.

Any person who acquires shares and become member of the Company after the dispatch of notice of the AGM by the Company and whose name appear in the register of members of the Company or in the statement of beneficial ownership maintained by the Depositories as on cut-off date i.e. 23rd September, 2026 can view the notice convening the AGM on the website of the Company viz www.ulilttd.com website of stock exchange viz BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com. Such members can exercise their voting rights through e-voting by following the procedure as mentioned in the said notice of AGM. Members are also informed that in case shareholders/ investor have any queries regarding E-voting, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions ("FAQs") and insta-Vote e-Voting module available at <https://instavote.linkintime.co.in> under download section or you can email us to enotices@in.mpmns.mugf.com or contact on: - Tel: 022 - 4918 6000.

For United Leasing & Industries Limited

Sd/-

Ashish Khanna

Managing Director

DIN: 01251582

Date: 05.09.2026

Place: Haryana

PM Shah to address UN to voice Nepal's concern over climate change

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah will visit the US later this month to address the 81st session of the UN General Assembly, where he is likely to raise the issue of climate change and seek compensation from the international community over the devastating flash floods.

The flash floods, triggered by an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal, killing more than 1,300, while around 4,900 remain missing. Shah is scheduled to address the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) session in New



York on September 24, according to the UN's official speaking schedule. This would be his first foreign trip since taking office on March 27.

ITL FINLEASE & SECURITIES LIMITED

CIN: L65910DL1991PLC045090,

Regd. Off: B -08, GD -ITL Tower, Netaji Subhash Place, Pitampura, Delhi - 110034, Tel-011-41572981, E-mail: csitlfinlease@gmail.com,

Web site: www.itlfinlease.in

NOTICE OF THE 35th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, E-VOTING

Notice is hereby given that the 35th Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the Members of ITL Finlease and Securities Limited ("the Company") is scheduled to be held on Monday , September 28, 2026, at 10.00 A.M. (IST) at the Registered Office of the Company at B-08, GD-ITL Tower, Netaji Subhash Place, Pitampura, Delhi-110034 to transact the business contained in the Notice of the said AGM dated 03/09/2026.

In terms of MCA Circulars, electronic copies of the Notice of the AGM and Annual Report for FY 2025-2026 have been sent to all the Members whose email ID's are registered with the Company/Depository Participant (DP) as on the cut-off date. Further, in accordance with Regulation 36(1)(b) of the Listing Regulations, the Company will be sending a letter to the Members whose email addresses are not registered with Company/DPs/Registrar and Share Transfer Agents, providing the weblink from where the Annual Report FY 2025-2026 can be accessed on the Company's website. The dispatch of these documents has been completed on 05/09/2026.

The said Notice and Annual Report 2025-2026 is also available on the Company's website at www.itlfinlease.in; website of stock exchange - Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India Limited at <http://www.mseil.in/> and on the website of CDSL at <https://www.evotingindia.com>

The Register of Members and the Share Transfer Books of the Company will remain closed during the book closure period from Tuesday , the 22nd day of September 2026 to Monday , the 28th day of September 2026 (both days inclusive).

In compliance with provisions of Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 as amended by the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2015 and Regulation 44 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, and Secretarial Standards on General Meetings (SS-2) issued by Institute of Company Secretaries of India, the Company is pleased to provide Remote e-voting or e-voting facility at the AGM, to the Members of the Company to cast their vote on all resolutions set-forth in the notice of AGM, through e-voting services provided by the Central Depository Services Limited (CDSL). The voting rights of the Members shall be reckoned on the basis of equity shares of the Company held by them as on the cut-off date. Thus, the Members holding shares either in physical or dematerialized form as on the cut-off date i.e., Monday , September 21st, 2026, may cast their vote electronically.

All the Members are hereby informed that:

(a) The remote e-voting shall commence from Friday , September 25, 2026 at 10.00 A.M and ends on Sunday , September 27, 2026, at 5.00 P.M. for all members, whether holding shares in physical form or demat form. The e-voting module shall be disabled by CDSL for voting thereafter. Remote e-voting shall not be allowed beyond the said date and time.

(b) A person whose name is recorded in the register of members or in the register of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on the cut-off date only shall be entitled to avail of the facility of remote e-voting as well as voting in the general meeting.

(c) The members may participate in the meeting even after exercising their right to vote through remote e-voting, but shall not be allowed to vote again in the meeting.

(d) In case any person, who acquires shares of the Company and becomes a member of the Company after the dispatch of the AGM Notice and holds shares as on the Cut-Off Date, may obtain the login ID and sequence number by sending a request to RTA of the Company, Alankit Assignments Limited, or CDSL. However, if the said shareholder is already registered with CDSL for e-voting, then his existing user ID and password can be used for casting the vote. If he has forgotten the password, he can reset his password by using the "Forgot User Details/Password" option available on www.evotingindia.com.

(e) The members may view the notice of the aforesaid meeting by accessing the following links: www.itlfinlease.in and www.evotingindia.com.

The Board of Directors of the Company has appointed M/s. Nakul Kumar & Associates, Practicing Company Secretaries (M. No. 35689) , Practicing Company Secretaries to act as the Scrutinizer to conduct the e-voting process in a fair and transparent manner, in accordance with the Act, and the Rules made thereunder.

In case of any queries or grievances pertaining to the e-voting procedure, Shareholders may refer to the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for Shareholders and the e-voting user manual, available at www.evotingindia.com under the Help section or write an e-mail to helpdesk.evoting@cdsindia.com or may contact Alankit Assignments Limited, E-mail: rla@alankit.com.

Members who have not registered/updated their e-mail address are requested to register the same in respect of the shares held by them in electronic form with the Depository through their depository participant.

JINDAL LEASEFIN LIMITED

CIN : L74899DL1994PLC059252

Regd. Office: 110, BABAR ROAD, NEW DELHI - 110 001

Ph. :011-46201000 FAX : 011-46201002

E-mail : jindal@jindal.bz, Website : www.jindalleasefin.com

NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that the 32nd Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the members of Jindal Leasefin Limited will be held on **Tuesday, September 29, 2026 at 5:00 p.m. at Kejriwal Farm House, Holambi Kalan Narela, Delhi - 110 082** to transact the business as set out in the Notice convening the AGM, in compliance with applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 (Act) and rules made thereunder and Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 read with all the applicable circulars issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA Circulars) and Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI Circulars) (MCA Circulars and SEBI Circulars collectively referred as "Circulars").

In compliance with the Circulars, AGM Notice and the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 including the financial statements for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, has been sent only by email to all those members, whose email IDs are registered with the Depository Participants or the Company or Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, Beetal Financial & Computer Services Pvt. Ltd. The emailing of AGM Notice to all members has been completed. The soft copy of the AGM Notice and the Annual Report are also available on the Company's website at www.jindalleasefin.com, website of BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and on the website of CDSL, e-voting agency at www.evotingindia.com.

The cut-off date for determining the eligibility to vote by remote e-voting or voting at the AGM shall be **Tuesday, September 22, 2026 ("Cut-off date")**. Shareholders of the Company, whose names appear in the register of members / list of beneficial owners as on Cut-off date, shall only be entitled to vote either through remote e-voting or voting at the AGM, on the resolutions set forth in the AGM Notice. A person who is not a shareholder as on the Cut-off date should treat this communication for information purposes only. The voting rights of shareholders shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the Cut-off date.

Any person who acquires shares and becomes a member of the Company after dispatch of Notice and holds shares as on the Cut-off date, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request at helpdesk.evoting@cdsindia.com. However, if they are already registered with CDSL for e-voting, then they can use their existing user ID and password to cast their vote(s).

All the members are informed that the business(es) set out in the Notice may be transacted through remote e-voting or voting at the AGM. The remote e-voting facility will be available from **September 26, 2026 (09:00 a.m.) to September 28, 2026 (05:00 p.m.)**. The remote e-voting will not be allowed beyond the aforementioned date and time and the remote e-voting module will be forthwith disabled upon expiry of the aforesaid period. Once the vote is casted by the member on a resolution, the member will not be allowed to modify or change his/her vote subsequently. Shareholders who have casted their vote(s) by remote e-voting prior to the AGM may also attend and participate in the AGM but shall not be entitled to cast their vote(s) again. Members present in the AGM, who have not casted their vote on the resolution through remote e-voting and are not otherwise barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through the polling papers at the AGM.

The detailed procedure for e-voting, including the manner in which members holding shares in physical / demat form and who have not registered their email address can cast their vote(s) through remote e-voting, is provided in the AGM Notice.

In case the shareholders have any queries or issues regarding e-voting, they may refer Frequently Asked Questions ("FAQs") and e-voting manual available at www.evotingindia.com under help section or send an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdsindia.com or call at toll free no. 1800 21 09911.

The Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company will remain closed from Wednesday, September 23, 2026 to Tuesday, September 29, 2026 (both days inclusive).

By Order of the Board of Directors

For JINDAL LEASEFIN LIMITED

Sd/-

Rajendra Prasad Rustagi

Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

DATE : New Delhi

PLACE : August 28, 2026

JINDAL LEASEFIN LIMITED

CIN : L74899DL1994PLC059252

Regd. Office: 110, BABAR ROAD, NEW DELHI - 110 001

Ph. :011-46201000 FAX : 011-46201002

E-mail : jindal@jindal.bz, Website : www.jindalleasefin.com

NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that the 32nd Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the members of Jindal Leasefin Limited will be held on **Tuesday, September 29, 2026 at 5:00 p.m. at Kejriwal Farm House, Holambi Kalan Narela, Delhi - 110 082** to transact the business as set out in the Notice convening the AGM, in compliance with applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 (Act) and rules made thereunder and Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 read with all the applicable circulars issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA Circulars) and Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI Circulars) (MCA Circulars and SEBI Circulars collectively referred as "Circulars").

In compliance with the Circulars, AGM Notice and the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 including the financial statements for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, has been sent only by email to all those members, whose email IDs are registered with the Depository Participants or the Company or Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, Beetal Financial & Computer Services Pvt. Ltd. The emailing of AGM Notice to all members has been completed. The soft copy of the AGM Notice and the Annual Report are also available on the Company's website at www.jindalleasefin.com, website of BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and on the website of CDSL, e-voting agency at www.evotingindia.com.

The cut-off date for determining the eligibility to vote by remote e-voting or voting at the AGM shall be **Tuesday, September 22, 2026 ("Cut-off date")**. Shareholders of the Company, whose names appear in the register of members / list of beneficial owners as on Cut-off date, shall only be entitled to vote either through remote e-voting or voting at the AGM, on the resolutions set forth in the AGM Notice. A person who is not a shareholder as on the Cut-off date should treat this communication for information purposes only. The voting rights of shareholders shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the Cut-off date.

Any person who acquires shares and becomes a member of the Company after dispatch of Notice and holds shares as on the Cut-off date, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request at helpdesk.evoting@cdsindia.com. However, if they are already registered with CDSL for e-voting, then they can use their existing user ID and password to cast their vote(s).

All the members are informed that the business(es) set out in the Notice may be transacted through remote e-voting or voting at the AGM. The remote e-voting facility will be available from **September 26, 2026 (09:00 a.m.) to September 28, 2026 (05:00 p.m.)**. The remote e-voting will not be allowed beyond the aforementioned date and time and the remote e-voting module will be forthwith disabled upon expiry of the aforesaid period. Once the vote is casted by the member on a resolution, the member will not be allowed to modify or change his/her vote subsequently. Shareholders who have casted their vote(s) by remote e-voting prior to the AGM may also attend and participate in the AGM but shall not be entitled to cast their vote(s) again. Members present in the AGM, who have not casted their vote on the resolution through remote e-voting and are not otherwise barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through the polling papers at the AGM.

The detailed procedure for e-voting, including the manner in which members holding shares in physical / demat form and who have not registered their email address can cast their vote(s) through remote e-voting, is provided in the AGM Notice.

In case the shareholders have any queries or issues regarding e-voting, they may refer Frequently Asked Questions ("FAQs") and e-voting manual available at www.evotingindia.com under help section or send an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdsindia.com or call at toll free no. 1800 21 09911.

The Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company will remain closed from Wednesday, September 23, 2026 to Tuesday, September 29, 2026 (both days inclusive).

By Order of the Board of Directors

For JINDAL LEASEFIN LIMITED

Sd/-

Rajendra Prasad Rustagi

Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

DATE : New Delhi

PLACE : August 28, 2026

Serbia's ruling populists propose President Vucic switch to PM after election

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Belgrade

Serbia's governing party on Saturday formally proposed that President Aleksandar Vucic become prime minister if they win an upcoming early parliamentary election that is seen as a major test for the populists after more than a year of street protests. Vucic is yet to formally dissolve Parliament and call the ballot that is expected to be held on October 25.

Voting will be held nearly two years after a train station canopy collapse in northern Serbia killed 16 people, triggering youth-led demonstrations that blamed Government corruption and incompetence for the tragedy. The election will take place in an atmosphere of heightened political tensions as the populists seek to retain power despite widespread popular discontent. Scores of anti-Government protesters on Saturday marched in the city of Nis while Vucic's party held their meeting there.



Putin orders 72-hour pause in strikes on Kyiv

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Moscow

Russian President Vladimir Putin ordered a 72-hour pause in strikes on Kyiv, the Kremlin said on Saturday, as US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner arrived in Moscow to try to revive a stalled push to end Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

"Putin has ordered that no strikes be carried out against Kyiv for three days, starting at midnight today," presidential spokesperson Dmitry Peskov told Russia's Tass news agency. He said the decision was tied to preparations for Witkoff and Kushner's planned visit to the Ukrainian capital, which Kyiv has said



US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner

will take place on Sunday. The envoys' trip comes as both sides escalate aerial attacks, some 4.5-years after the Kremlin's invasion of its neighbour. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Friday that Ukraine would halt airstrikes during the envoys' visit and urged Moscow to do the same.

Washington's push to end the fighting, now in its fifth year, has lost momentum as US attention has been focused for the last six months on its war with Iran.

The last known visit to Moscow by Witkoff and Kushner, US President Donald Trump's son-in-law, was in January, when they met Russian President Vladimir

Putin in the Kremlin. They have never previously visited Kyiv. The envoys were met at the airport by Russian envoy Kirill Dmitriev, Tass reported. Dmitriev shared photos of him meeting the US delegation as they disembarked, alongside the caption, "Welcome to Moscow Peacemakers."

With peace efforts stalled, Russia has intensified its attacks on Kyiv and other cities with relentless bombardments recently stretching into daylight hours, taking advantage of Ukraine's shortage of air defensive systems.

On Friday, a Russian drone hit one of the most important government buildings in Kyiv -- the headquarters of Ukraine's Security Service,

known as the SBU, which is one of the agencies involved in carrying out deep-strike operations inside Russia.

The long-range strikes by Ukraine have hit Russian military facilities, oil refineries and e-commerce hubs, seeking to undermine the Kremlin's war effort and economy, as well as make ordinary citizens feel the consequences of the war.

The air war between Russia and Ukraine has intensified as troops have struggled to make progress along the 1,250-kilometre front line.

Russia has recently been using fast-flying, jet-powered drones, and the recurring wail of air-raid sirens has become part of daily life in Kyiv.

US midterm mail ballots start to go to voters



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

Statewide mail voting for this year's midterm elections kicked off amid a churning legal battle over President Donald Trump's attempts to limit the practice and mounting concern over Postal Service changes that some state officials blame for a rise in rejected ballots.

The developments have created a sense of uncertainty about a popular voting method used by one-third of the nation's voters.

North Carolina on Friday became the first state to widely distribute mail ballots for this year's elections, which will determine the balance of power in Congress for the remainder of Trump's term.

Election officials said that while they are closely monitoring the litigation, ballots will be mailed out as expected and the state is prepared to administer a secure election even if the new limits go forward.

headlines about the executive order and court fights have already confused some voters. "The biggest part of this is that it has sparked questions about what it is. What does this mean? What are you guys doing? Can I not vote by mail anymore?" said Michael Dickerson, director of the Mecklenburg County Board of Elections.

"I just want people to be assured that, yes, you can still vote by mail," he said, adding "it's a safe and secure process." While the issue has ping-ponged around the courts, election workers in North Carolina had been working hard to get ready for the Friday deadline, officials there said in interviews.

Wake County elections employees have been processing absentee request forms, which come in daily online and in paper form, said Olivia McCall, the county's director of elections. They've also been coding ballots, running pre-election accuracy testing and packaging absentee packets that include a ballot, instructions and photo ID fliers, she said.

About 5,000 ballots will go out during Wake County's first wave, she said.

The turnaround time for ballots being returned could be quick, too, noted Dickerson, especially for military and overseas voters who can vote through an online portal.

"I guarantee you" votes will begin rolling in that way by Saturday, he said. North Carolina Attorney General Jeff Jackson is among Democratic state officials who have aligned in one of the lawsuits challenging Trump's executive order and the changes proposed by the Postal Service. In a recent court filing, a representative of the office argued it was "far too late in the election cycle to introduce such dramatic changes" and warned that implementing them would "imminently cause significant harm, confusion and disruption in North Carolina election administration."

In March, Trump signed an executive order seeking to limit mail balloting. States would have to submit lists of eligible voters to the Postal Service through an online portal that apparently is still inactive. Ballot envelopes also would have to comply with new Postal Service rules and include barcodes.

Trump's directive has been held up by multiple lawsuits, one of which led to a preliminary injunction Friday against its implementation, a decision the administration quickly appealed.

Election officials warn that

Masked men block Dover port traffic in anti-immigrant protest

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

A group of masked men blocked roads leading to Britain's busiest ferry port on Saturday in what officials said appeared to be an anti-immigration protest.

The Port of Dover said all traffic in and out was "stopped due to an ongoing public order incident," and police said they were "engaging with the protesters."

Video posted on social media showed several dozen men in black, their faces covered, standing across a major road near the port. One clip showed demonstrators linking arms across a main road and shouting "stop the boats."

Chris Vinson, a Conservative Party local councillor, said the protest appeared to be "illegal migration-related." "I'm not aware that there's been any violence, although clearly, having the path of your vehicle



blocked by men wearing black paramilitary gear and balaclavas is extremely intimidating," he said.

The National Highways agency said the protest blocked routes to the port and caused a 6.4-kilometre traffic jam on Saturday morning.

The Port of Dover said one road to the port had reopened by late morning. P&O Ferries, which runs ser-

vices between Dover and Calais in France, said passengers who missed their ferry would be offered the next available crossing.

Dover, about 110 kilometres southeast of London, dealt with more than 9 million passengers and 2 million freight vehicles in 2025, according to the port's website. The town has been the site of pre-

vious anti-immigrant protests focused on migrants who cross the Channel from France in small boats. Some politicians, including Nigel Farage of hard-right party Reform UK, have seized on the issue. He branded the asylum seekers "an invasion" in a Friday speech.

The Labour Party government says stepped-up law enforcement cooperation between Britain and France has helped reduce the number of people making the crossing this year by more than 40 per cent compared to 2025.

Mike Tapp, a Labour lawmaker who represents Dover in Parliament, criticised "idiots coming to Dover to cause disruption." "I bet if you asked any one of those protesters' they wouldn't know small boat crossing are down by 40 per cent and we are working hard to fix the mess," he wrote on Facebook on Saturday. "Go home, enjoy your weekend/get a job."

Jaishankar to address UNGA session on September 26

YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar will address the annual high-level UN General Assembly session on September 26. The 81st session of the UN General Assembly (UNGA) will kick-off on September 8, and world leaders will address the 193-member organisation at the General Debate, which will run from September 22 to 28.

Jaishankar is scheduled to address the General Debate in the afternoon session on September 26, according to a revised provisional list of speakers for the high-level session released here. He addressed world leaders from the UN lectern last year.

Brazil will be the traditional first speaker at the General Debate that opens on September 22, followed by the US. The year-long 81st session of the UN General Assembly will be presided over by Bangladesh Foreign



Minister Khalilur Rahman, who was elected in June to head the 193-member UN organisation.

US President Donald Trump will address world leaders from the iconic UNGA podium on September 22, his second address to the UN session in his second term in the White House.

Considered the "busiest diplomatic season" of the year at the United Nations Headquarters, the high-level session opens annually in September. The session this year comes amid

continuing geopolitical conflicts across the world, including the months-long US-Israel war against Iran that has had a devastating cascading impact on countries of the Global South as well as the least developed nations, affected by rising food and fuel costs in the wake of the continued disruption in the Strait of Hormuz. Meetings scheduled to take place during the UNGA session include high-level session to commemorate the 40th anniversary of the Declaration on the Right to Development; meeting on climate action and the just transition.

High-level meeting to address the existential threats posed by sea level rise; pandemic prevention, preparedness and response and plenary meeting to commemorate and promote the International Day for the Total Elimination of Nuclear Weapons. (PTI)

Philippines Vice President Sara posts bail after arrest for alleged threats against Marcos

TERESA CEROJANO ■ Manila

Philippines Vice President Sara Duterte posted bail on Saturday after an order was issued for her arrest the previous day on charges that she publicly threatened to arrange the assassination of President Ferdinand Marcos Jr and two other people.

Emerging in a black outfit from Quezon City Regional Trial Court in Metro Manila, Duterte consoled her supporters, hugging a woman who was sobbing as supporters chanted "*Duterte! Duterte!*"

The vice president, who has denied the allegations, showed a court order lifting the arrest warrant issued by the court Friday and said her lawyers instructed her to keep a copy on hand. She urged journalists to surround her on the



way to her car because she did not feel safe. "If possible please go with me, because I do not feel safe with all these police personnel who are harassing those at my home, harassing me since 2023," Duterte said. "What does this administration really want to do

with me?" Paul Lawrence Lim, one of her attorneys, said court staff took Duterte's fingerprints and she posted 360,000 pesos bail (\$5,740) for three counts of grave threats.

After the arrest order was issued Friday, he said Duterte would fight the charges. "She has no intention of evading the law and will continue to exercise all her legal remedies," he said in a statement.

The case is seen as part of a high-stakes political showdown pitting Duterte against Marcos.

The charges stem from an alleged threat Duterte, 48, made during a 2024 online news conference. She said she would have Marcos, his wife and then-House of Representatives Speaker Martin Romualdez killed by an assassin if she herself was killed as their political disputes escalated. (AP)

Indian charged with drug trafficking, possessing illegal arms in US

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

An Indian National has been charged with distributing drugs from a pizza outlet in a California city, the US Department of Justice said.

According to court documents, 50-year-old Kawal Preet Singh, an unlawful resident of the US, sold wholesale quantities of methamphetamine from a Round Table Pizza restaurant he operated in Dinuba, while armed with illegal firearms.

Federal agents searched Singh's home and business on August 18 and seized more than 40 pounds of methamphetamine, three firearms and over USD 10,000 in cash, the Department of Justice said in a statement on Thursday.

If convicted, Singh faces a mandatory minimum of 10 years and a maximum of life in prison, plus a fine of up to USD 10 million, for drug trafficking. He also faces a mandatory minimum sentence of five years, consecutive to any other sentence, and up to life in prison for possessing a firearm in furtherance of drug trafficking. Any sentence,



however, would be determined at the discretion of the court after consideration of applicable statutory factors and the federal sentencing guidelines, which take into account a number of variables.

The charges are only allegations; the defendant is presumed innocent until and unless proven guilty beyond a reasonable doubt. (PTI)

Months after ceasefire, Israel and Hezbollah battle over strategic hill in Lebanon

BASSEM MROUE ■ Beirut

Since a ceasefire went into effect between Israel and Hezbollah more than two months ago, fighting has stopped in much of Lebanon, but not on a strategic hill overlooking parts of a main southern city.

In recent weeks, Ali Taher hill has been the scene of daily shelling and airstrikes by Israel's military. Hezbollah, a militant group backed by Iran, has repeatedly attacked Israeli forces in the area with drones.

The United States, which is mediating talks between Lebanon and Israel, had wanted Hezbollah to hand over the hill to the Lebanese army as part of larger plan to disarm the militant group and dismantle its infrastructure. But Hezbollah has refused.



Lebanon and Israel reached a framework agreement in June stating Israel will withdraw from Lebanon as Hezbollah is disarmed.

The militant group was not a party to the negotiations and has rejected calls to disarm in areas north of the Litani river, which is where Ali Taher is located.

A full-on battle over this hill near the city of Nabatiyeh could escalate fighting across the country, and unrest in Lebanon complicates efforts to resolve the war in Iran. On Thursday night, Israel's military announced it had taken "operational control" of Ali Taher and a network of tunnels beneath it that Hezbollah uses to shelter its fighters and weapons. It is unclear how far Israel's control extends. Just before Israel's announcement, its air force was still targeting the

hill, according to Lebanese state media. There has been no official statement from Hezbollah since Israel's announcement.

US pushes Lebanon to pressure Hezbollah

Hezbollah firmly rejected a proposal from the Lebanese government to hand over Ali Taher to the country's army. It fears Israel would then seize control of the hill from the Lebanese army and then demand the handover of more territory. Israel had occupied Ali Taher for 18 years before it withdrew from Lebanon in 2000.

The hill has a strategic location overlooking several villages as well as main roads leading to Nabatiyeh. Losing full control of it would disrupt Hezbollah's presence and supply lines in the area.

The Israeli military says the site is also important to Hezbollah because of tunnels it built there, with funding from Iran.

Israel said in its statement Thursday that the hill housed underground command centres, weapons storage rooms, generators, living quarters, showers and a kitchen. Israel said it cleared Ali Taher of Hezbollah fighters and was working to "neutralise underground infrastructure sites."

Hezbollah legislator Ihab Hamadeh questioned why the Israeli military was still attacking the hill if it was really in control of the area, according to Sputnik.

An Associated Press photographer who visited the nearby village of Kfar Rumman saw no sign of Israeli military presence on the hill. (AP)



Senior Minister K Shanmugam



BRIEFLY

Anahat Singh’s London Squash Classic run ends in quarters



India’s Anahat Singh bowed out of the London Squash Classic after going down to Malaysian world No 5 Sivasangari Subramaniam 4-11, 4-11 in the women’s quarterfinals of the PSA Gold event here.

The reigning world junior champion Anahat suffered a 4-11, 4-11 defeat on Friday. Anahat had beaten world no 11 Nelli Gilis to make the quarterfinals. The World No 20 will next compete in the Qatar Classic from September 12 in the build up to the Asian Games in Japan, which starts on September 19.

(PTI)

India hammers Indonesia in AHF Junior Asia Cup opener



India made a commanding start to their title defence at the AHF Junior Men’s Asia Cup with a ruthless 14-0 victory over Indonesia in their opening Pool A match here on Saturday.

Captain Anmol Ekka, Prabhdeep Singh and Ajeet Yadav spearheaded the emphatic performance, scoring 12 goals between them as the five-time champions immediately stamped its authority on the tournament. Prabhdeep was the most prolific scorer of the day, finding the net five times to earn the ‘Player of the Match’ award, while skipper Anmol contributed four goals and Yadav scored thrice for his hat-trick. Harpal and Ashu Maurya accounted for the other two goals. India’s attacking intent was evident from the opening whistle as they repeatedly entered the Indonesian circle and created scoring opportunities. Prabhdeep opened the scoring in the fifth minute, giving India an early advantage before Harpal doubled the lead in the eighth minute.

Indonesia struggled to cope with the pace and movement of the Indian attack. The Indian forward line continued to find openings in the second quarter. Anmol got his first goal of the match in the 16th minute when the Indonesian defence was penalised with a penalty stroke. Yadav added another four minutes later to make it 4-0. Prabhdeep then took centre stage, scoring in the 26th and 30th minutes to complete his hat-trick and take India into half-time with a commanding 6-0 lead. There was little respite for Indonesia after the break, with India continuing to dominate possession and territory.

(PTI)

Shubhankar Sharma stays in top-10 despite late bogeys



Indian golfer Shubhankar Sharma dropped three bogeys in the last six holes but managed to stay on in the top-10 at the halfway stage of the Omega European Masters.

The 30-year-old Sharma, a two-time winner on the DP World Tour, had three birdies on either side of the Crans-sur-Sierre Golf Club and four bogeys, three of which came on the back nine. He carded 2-under 68. Along with his first round 6-under 64, he is now 8-under and Tied-eighth with two more rounds to go. India’s other player in the event, Yuvraj Sandhu, had a superb 5-under 65, which was a 12-shot improvement on his first round 77. But he still missed the cut. For Sharma, every week will be crucial as he tries to get up from 179th to inside Top-100 to earn a card for 2027.

South Africa’s Thriston Lawrence produced a stellar second round of 63 to move two strokes clear of the field. The defending champion, who began the day one shot off the pace, delivered a flawless display, carding seven birdies to reach 13 under par after 36 holes.

(PTI)

‘Defence, attacking can make difference in Asian Games’

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Bengaluru

India women’s hockey team coach Sjoerd Marijne believes that an improved defence and the continuing work on sharpening goal-scoring skills can do wonders for his side in the upcoming Asian Games.

The women’s side had bagged a bronze in the 2022 Asian Games, and it’s eager to clinch a medal of a brighter hue in this edition in Japan. “I think one of the most important things we have shown is to be a unit and we defended really well. I think that is one of the basics of game,” Marijne said.

“Defending well is always possible. And the next step is to create more opportunities. But, yes, that is something that we are working on,” he added.

Marijne then dwelled upon some details of the route

map that he had set for the team.

“Yes, this (improving defence) is something that has to happen daily. Working on defence but also on attack. Defence is something you do as a unit. Everybody needs to be involved.

“And you need to have a lot of discipline in this. And that is something that we have worked really hard on. What are the key points we have to do really well? For instance, the left hand on the ground and those small things can make a big difference,” he said. India finished fifth in the recent Hockey World Cup held across Belgium and the Netherlands. But it has not left team dispirited and, for Marijne World Cup offered an important learning point.

“I can tell them many times we are really good and we can do it. But you have to experience it yourself (playing well) and that is



India women’s hockey team coach Sjoerd Marijne

FILE PHOTO

what happened now. They played against the best teams in the world.

“They have seen, okay, this is necessary on the highest level to do well. But they also can see that they can compete with all.”

But has the team picked up its intensity after a draining World Cup?

“Yes, after the World Cup, the first week is about recovery. It has been a very heavy period for the girls. We will leave for Japan on Monday

and we have a camp there outside the location.

“So, we will work there more on the intensity and the last week will be the high intensity training to be ready for the Asian Games,” he noted. Skipper Salima Tete agreed with Marijne that the team’s attitude has changed.

“Everyone has a mindset that we have to win every match. So, it is a benefit for us. After Marijne has come, our team culture has changed a lot. How we have to show our

Fenerbahce’s Guendouzi banned for two Champions League games after heated clashes in playoff at Lyon

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Nyon (Switzerland)

Matteo Guendouzi was banned by UEFA from Fenerbahce’s first two Champions League games for provocations and insults in a heated playoff win at Lyon in his native France.

Guendouzi, a former player at Lyon’s great rival Marseille, was at the heart of incidents before and after Fenerbahce’s 2-1 win on Aug. 26 including a mass brawl. The result sent the Turkish club into the Champions League for the first time in 18 years.

The 27-year-old Guendouzi will miss Fenerbahce hosting Roma next Thursday and a visit to Aston Villa on Oct. 14.

Fenerbahce forward Mason Greenwood had a one-game ban deferred for



one year of probation for his involvement, UEFA said in disciplinary verdicts announced late Friday.

Lyon goalkeeper coach Antonio Ferreira was banned from three Europa League games, with two more games deferred, for “serious assault.” He aimed a leaping kick at Guendouzi in a post-game clash near the players’ tunnel.

The charges against

after the game, and shouted “Allez l’OM” (“Go Marseille”), while also grabbing his crotch in wild post-match scenes. He later said Lyon fans insulted his family before and during the game.

Guendouzi and Greenwood both joined Fenerbahce in the offseason as part of a big investment by the Istanbul club which has fallen behind city rival Galatasaray in recent years. Galatasaray also will play in the Champions League.

UEFA also fined Fenerbahce 50,000 euros (\$58,000) for violating rules of decent conduct and 45,000 euros (\$52,000) for fan misconduct.

Lyon was fined 108,500 euros (\$126,000) on a series of charges. The team starts in the second-tier Europa League at Anderlecht next Thursday.

Valverde headlines Uruguay squad for India friendly, Forlan to begin coaching stint

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Real Madrid star Federico Valverde will headline a star-studded Uruguay squad named for next month’s international friendly against India, with the two-time world champions, led by head coach Diego Forlan, bringing a formidable mix of established internationals and emerging talents.

India will take on Uruguay at the Vivekananda Yuba Bharati Krirangan here on October 6, as part of a high-profile series of international friendlies. The Blue Tigers will also face Panama on September 25 at the Sree Kanteerava Stadium in Bengaluru and five-time world champions Brazil on October 3 here.

Valverde is among several marquee names in the Uruguay squad, which also includes Rodrigo Bentancur, Lucas Torreira, Giorgian de Arrascaeta, Facundo Pellistri, Maximiliano Araujo and Brian Rodriguez.

The defence boasts plenty of international experience, with Ronald Araujo, Jose Maria Gimenez, Nahitan Nandez, Guillermo Varela,

Mathias Olivera and Sebastian Caceres named in the squad.

Santiago Mele, Cristopher Fiermarin and Ignacio de Arruabarrena are the three goalkeeping options, while the attack features Liverpool star Darwin Nunez, along with Miguel Merentiel, Rodrigo Aguirre, Federico Vinas, Martin Satriano and Alvaro Rodriguez.

The match in Kolkata will also mark Forlan’s first assignment at the helm of Uruguay, with the former World Cup star taking charge of the national side as coach. “The announcement comes at the beginning of a new chapter for Uruguay following Marcelo Bielsa’s departure, with legendary former striker Diego Forlan taking charge of the senior national team and the Under-20 side,” said All India Football Federation in a statement. A 2010 FIFA World Cup Golden Ball winner and 2011 Copa America champion, Forlan scored 36 goals in 112 appearances for Uruguay. He enjoyed a distinguished club career with Manchester United, Villarreal, Atletico Madrid and Inter Milan, and also had a stint in the Indian



Super League with Mumbai City FC.

“Now, as Uruguay’s head coach, Forlan faces a new challenge as he prepares his side for the upcoming clash against India. With established stars such as Valverde, Nunez, Araujo and Gimenez featuring alongside a new generation of talent, Uruguay’s September-October window promises to offer an early glimpse into Forlan’s vision for the next chapter of La Celeste,” the statement added.

India, under coach Khalid Jamil, will be determined to put up a strong fight and deliver a memorable contest.

Uruguay squad: Goalkeepers: Santiago Mele, Cristopher Fiermarin, Ignacio de Arruabarrena, Sebastian Jaume, Thiago

Cardozo.

Defenders: Kevin Amaro, Jose Luis Rodriguez, Guillermo Varela, Nahitan Nandez, Santiago Mourino, Nicolas Marichal, Ronald Araujo, Alexander Barboza, Jose Maria Gimenez, Juan Rodriguez, Sebastian Boselli, Santiago Bueno, Sebastian Caceres, Mathias Olivera, Joaquin Piquerez, Lucas Olaza, Marcelo Saracchi, Juan Manuel Sanabria.

Midfielders: Emiliano Martinez, Lucas Torreira, Rodrigo Bentancur, Facundo Bernal, Santiago Homenchenko, Federico Valverde, Agustin Canobbio, Matias Abaldo, Facundo Pellistri, Luciano Rodriguez, Maximiliano Araujo, Lucas Villalba, Brian Rodriguez, Rodrigo Zalazar, Diego Rossi, Giorgian de Arrascaeta.

Shot putter Toor targets 22m throw, wants to raise bar like Neeraj



Neeraj Chopra (left) and Tajinderpal Singh Toor (right)

FILE PHOTO

APARAJITA UPADHYAY
■ Patiala

India’s most accomplished shot putter Tajinderpal Singh Toor wants to breach the long-awaited 22m barrier and set a benchmark for the next generation much like Neeraj Chopra has raised the bar for the country’s javelin throwers. The 31-year-old national record holder, who has a personal best of 21.77m, wants Indian shot putters to reach a stage where 20m and 21m are no longer considered exceptional distances.

“It’s my aim and dream to throw 22m and create a national record, so that the younger generation of Indian shot putters think 21m is nothing,” Toor told PTI in an interaction facilitated by SAI.

Chopra’s rise has had a similar impact on Indian javelin, with his Olympic gold and 90.23m national record pushing the benchmark higher. The likes of Rohit Yadav (87.68m), Kishore Jena (87.54m), Sachin Yadav (86.54m) and Yashvir Singh (85.41m) have all breached the 85m mark.

“Like Neeraj has thrown 90m, so 80m-82m is considered nothing. Rohit has thrown 87.68m, Sachin has thrown 86m-plus and Yashvir did a personal best at CWG. If we see, India has some of the most javelin throwers in the world who have thrown above 85m,” Toor said.

However, Toor feels injuries have repeatedly prevented him from performing to his full potential.

“Injuries have always been there with me. A lot of people say he doesn’t perform outside (India). But when the person is not fit, how will he perform? From the very first

Australia was drawn our team was disappointed. I think this is a good sign that today our team is upset even after playing a draw with Australia. It worked as a motivation in the last match we played with Germany.

“We played a very good attacking game. If we are winning a match against a tightly defending team like Germany then it is a good boost for the whole team for the Asian Games,” she said.

So, as a senior player with over 300 caps, what is her tip to young team members to tackle the pressure during a prestigious event like the Asian Games?

“We always have to keep a match by match focus. For gold, the journey is still very far. We have league matches and after that, the semis and then the final. Definitely, it’s our dream. So, it’s very important to stay focused,” Punia added.

Serena and Venus Williams lose in match tiebreaker in their return to US Open

BRIAN MAHONEY
■ New York

Serena and Venus Williams were once again the main attraction at the U.S. Open. Carlos Alcaraz sure wasn’t going to miss it.

“I think there is no better plan (than) to watch the doubles, the Williamses once again, while getting a treatment,” the defending men’s champion said after winning his match. “I’m going to be ready for that.” The match was a thriller, with the sisters battling back to force a 10-point match tiebreaker, but then blowing a 5-0 lead and losing 6-3, 6-7 (6), 7-6 (10-7) on Friday night to Hao-Ching Chan and Maya King.

It was the first U.S. Open match since 2022 at the Grand Slam tournament the sisters won twice.

They battled back from 4-1 down in the third set to tie it, but then faltered late in front of disappointed fans desperately rooting them on. “I think the crowd is pretty much what we expected. We expected a full stadium, everyone cheering for them, which, pretty much was that,” Joint said. “But the atmosphere is something that, yeah, it’s super special. Not really going to get again with many other players.”

Serena came back to tennis this year at 44. Venus has continued to play on tour at 46.

Perhaps it was their ages, could have been Serena’s long layoff, or maybe it was nerves. But both double-faulted during the tiebreaker after they had played so brilliantly late in the third set and then in the first few points.



Serena lost to Joint for the second time this summer. She fell to the Australian in three sets at Wimbledon in her return to singles play, and she and Venus

then had to pull out of their doubles match after Serena hurt her knee.

That delayed their return to the Grand Slam stage until New York,

where they won in 1999 and 2009 and are now 27-8 in their 10 appearances. The match got a spot in the night session in Arthur Ashe Stadium — practically unheard of for first-round doubles.

The sisters were once dominant in women’s doubles, teaming to win 14 Grand Slam titles along with Olympic gold medals in 2000, 2008 and 2012. They shared the No. 1 ranking in women’s doubles for eight weeks.

It appeared a first-round loss in 2022 was their last time together, with Serena stepping away from tennis that year after winning 23 Grand Slam singles titles. She came back this summer and now has two heartbreaking defeats with her older sister. They also lost in a match tiebreaker at the Cincinnati Open.

Venus also lost in the first round of singles. The champions lead the field into the fourth round. Alcaraz won easily but two-time defending champion Aryna Sabalenka was finally challenged — by her opponent and by the smell of marijuana — in her victory.

Sabalenka beat Kamilla Rakhimova 6-3, 6-4. The No. 1 seed was pushed in a second set that lasted 54 minutes - a minute longer than her entire previous match. Alcaraz returned to the round of 16 by beating Wu Yibing 6-3, 6-4, 6-1. Sabalenka smelled marijuana, Jessica Pegula struggled for tennis reasons Sabalenka was serving in the third game of her match in Louis Armstrong Stadium when she tossed the ball but then let it fall to the court. She did the same thing on the next

point, with something clearly bothering her.

She then approached the chair umpire to ask for help because she smelled marijuana.

“I was like, guys, you can do whatever, you can smoke whatever, you can relax as much as you can, but please, do not do it around the tennis courts,” Sabalenka said, when asked what she was thinking at the time. “It’s a bit tricky to handle that smell while you’re trying to compete at your best.” Pegula, the No. 3 seed, fought back to beat 2021 runner-up Leylah Fernandez 1-6, 6-4, 6-3. Pegula, who lost to Sabalenka in the 2024 final and again last year in the semifinals, had a dismal start in which she put only 5 of 16 first serves in during the first set.

(AP)

Women’s Asia Cup: India inflict seven-wicket defeat on Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

Young spin twins Shree Charani and Prema Rawat strangled Pakistan with deadly spells as India trampled all over their arch-rivals, winning a lopsided Women's Asia Cup T20 contest by seven wickets here on Saturday.

Harmanpreet Kaur, who become the first international captain (men or women) to lead the country in 150 T20Is, couldn't have been more pleased to find her spinners skittling out Pakistan for 55 in just 18.1 overs — their lowest-ever total in the shortest format. Fittingly, she finished

the game with a regal six down the ground.

India's spinners — 22-year-old left-arm orthodox Charani (3/7 in 4 overs), 24-year-old leg-break bowler Prema (3/9 in 4 overs) and part-time wrist spinner Shafali Verma (1/10 in 3 overs) completely dismantled the Pakistan batting. Deepti Sharma (2/5 in 3.1 overs) completed the formalities.

India completed the chase in 8.4 overs despite losing Shafali Verma (12), Smriti Mandhana (9) and Pratika Rawal (4) cheaply to Pakistan skipper Fatima Sana.

Harmanpreet (18 n.o.) and Deepti (12 n.o.) used all their experience to calm the

nerves after some initial jitters. With no scoreboard pressure, Pakistan bowlers never had any chance as such to create an upset.

Indian women would have expected a bit of practice before their semi-finals but such was the plight of Pakistani batters that once again it became a 'No Contest'. In the history of T20 Asia Cup, India have won seven games to Pakistan's one. Earlier, opting to bat, Pakistan did start confidently reaching 27 for no loss in little over four overs with openers Muneeba Ali (13) and Shawaal Zulfiqar (14) facing the seamers with ease but none of the other batters



were able to reach double figures in an embarrassing display of ineptitude.

The two wrist spinners, Shafali and Prema, didn't try to turn and kept attacking the stumps with relentless accuracy. By the time, Deepti came in to bowl, Pakistan women had already thrown in the towel.

In 18.1 overs, Indian bowlers delivered an astounding 78 dot balls.

Once, Harmanpreet Kaur, captaining the country for the 150th time in T20Is, gauged that the pitch was offering turn, she introduced the spinners right away and got due dividends. Suddenly Pakistan lost six wickets for

the addition of nine runs to totter at 36 for 6 after the end of 10 overs. Strangled for runs, Muneeba tried to shuffle towards leg stump to make room and was beaten all ends up.

Charani then got into the act as she extracted appreciable turn and bounce at the same time. Gull Feroza (0) tried to hit her against the turn to get caught at short third while Zulfiqar missed a sweep shot to be adjudged plumb in-front. Ayesha Zafar (2) was strangled as she tried to break the shackles, only to lob an easy catch to Harmanpreet at mid-on.

Sadaf Shamas (3) tried to hit her way out on a difficult

track against Prema, who bowled straight and hit the stumps.

Pakistan's biggest hope, skipper Fatima Sana (0) got a classical off-break from Deepti Sharma that hit her flush on the pads and could have hit the leg-middle line.

Eyman Fatima (5) and Umm-e Hani (6) were involved in a horrible mix-up leading to the former being run-out at the non-striker's end. Hani also perished like many of her teammates trying a sweep without even having an iota of idea about the length of the delivery. By then the contest was over even before India came out to bat.

Suthar picks up match haul of seven in big Warwickshire win

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

India's newest spin-bowling star Manav Suthar picked up a match haul of seven wickets as Warwickshire defeated Hampshire by an innings and 129 runs in a Division One away game of the English County Championship.

Having picked 11 wickets in his first two games for the Birmingham-based County club before leaving for national duty in Sri Lanka, the left-arm orthodox spinner started from where he had left off with a match haul of 7 for 94 in a total 38.3 overs bowled across both Hampshire innings.

Batting first, Warwickshire scored 398 and then bowled out Hampshire for 115 and 154 inside three days. The match ended late Friday evening as per India time.



target. Out of contention for national recall, Yuzvendra Chahal picked up nine wickets for Northamptonshire, including a five-for in the second innings, but Durham produced a clinical bowling performance to win the Division 2 game by 153 runs despite conceding a first-innings lead.

Durham scored 205 and 261 in their two innings while Northants after scoring 263 in their first innings were bowled out for 50 in the second essay in pursuit of 204. However, it was a good match for 36-year-old leg-spinner Chahal who took 4 for 36 in the first innings and 5 for 84 in the second innings. His leg-break that went through the gates of former England skipper Ben Stokes was a beauty.

Chahal has so far picked 14 wickets in three first-class games while another 15 in seven Royal London Cup games (List A).

In the same match, Mayank Agarwal, who turned up for Durham for the first time, scored 36 and 48. The second-innings 48 came in an 89-run stand with Stokes.

Challenging to join T20 after Duleep, it's our job to adapt: Tilak, Kishan

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Chennai

Tilak Varma and Ishan Kishan admitted that it is "tough" to join India's T20I squad for the three-match series against Afghanistan right after the Duleep Trophy final, but understood the need to adapt to the situation and as professional cricketers they can't offer "excuses."

The five-day domestic fixture, which starts here on Sunday, is scheduled for a September 10 finish, and India will face Afghanistan in the first of the three T20Is in New Delhi on September 13.

"It is just about knowing what format you are playing. I know it gets difficult when you are playing Test match and suddenly you have to go and start hitting from ball



one (in white ball format) and then suddenly you have to go back to your domestic team and you have to play a whole different role," Kishan, who is leading East Zone, said in the pre-match press conference.

Kishan, who is a part of India's T20I squad, found a supporting voice in Tilak Varma, South Zone captain and India's T20I vice-captain.

"Yes, it will be slightly challenging...playing five days

know how to change our mindsets and maintain our body with good fluids and everything. "We have played before in domestic as well as international back-to-back games, so we are quite used to it," he said. It may be recalled that Tilak had openly manifested his desire to play in the Duleep Trophy final after winning the semifinal in Bengaluru. Kishan too joined Tilak on the adaptability road.

"I feel as professionals it is our job to adapt. We cannot come up with excuses after knowing this is your routine for the next few days. So, it is better to not be in a situation where we have to make excuses. But at the same time be aware and be just mindful of what is going to happen and I will be playing T20I after this. So, my job will be different. But still I feel we are getting two days of practice before the first game against Afghanistan. So, it will be more than enough I feel," he added. However, Tilak will not be alone in his task of manning South's batting after the addition of in-form Devdutt Padikkal.

"Yeah, it will be a big boost for us. The kind of form he (Padikkal) is in, it will be really helpful for us and he can share his experience with the players. We have got quite a few young guys on our side and it will be really helpful."

Tilak said the Karnataka left-hander will bat at Number 3, a position where batted in India ranks. "Padikkal will be batting at number 3 and his coming into the side will strengthen our batting line-up, especially with the kind of

form we have seen from Padikkal in the last 2 or 3 games. He has done really well. It will be a big boost for us." Similarly, East Zone will have Vaibhav Sooryavanshi to depend on to make an impact up the order. For the record, this will be Sooryavanshi's first five-day game in representative career. Whether it is U-19, Ranji Trophy or Duleep Trophy, he has so far played only 4-day games.

"I feel Vaibhav is very smart for 15-year-old boy. He knows what he is doing, he has been in this situation and I have heard him speaking to other players as well. So, there is no doubt if he has played 4 day or 3 day cricket earlier and this is a 5-day game, I think you just need to get runs out of him and that is what he is willing to do," said Kishan. (PTI)

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It'll be tough but I don't take pressure: Parul Chaudhary

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Bengaluru

Asian Games double gold medallist Parul Chaudhary said the addition of 1500m race to the competition list has not burdened her, and is trusting the intense pre-event training process to do an encore in the upcoming edition.

Chaudhary had won gold in 3000m steeple chase and 5000m in the previous edition of the continental showpiece held in Hangzhou, China.

Additionally, she will take part in the 1500m event in this Games to be held in Japan. "There will be good and tough competition. There are strong athletes from across Asia, particular-



ly from Japan and Bahrain. But I am confident of doing well. I had won gold medals last time and I want to bring those medals back to the country," Chaudhary told PTI in an interview facilitated by SAI.

Chaudhary admitted that competing in three different events in as many days can

be tough, but exuded confidence that adaptive training at SAI Centre of Excellence can stand her in good stead.

"It is difficult (competing in three events). But I am training accordingly. I have to compete for three days in a row. "So, I will have to train accordingly. But I don't

I have fitness level of 2022, can repeat performance in Asian Games: Avinash Sable



G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Bengaluru

Since July 2025, Avinash Sable and his dream to retain the Asian Games 3000m steeple-chase gold were living in different houses. Delicate fitness following a surgery to repair Sable's torn ACL and meniscus was the biggest impediment in their reunion, forcing him to even skip the recent Commonwealth Games.

Instead, he trained at a high-altitude facility in Ooty, then went to Inspire Institute of Sport (IIS) in Bellary, Karnataka, before turning up at Sports Authority of India (Southern Centre) here for sessions in the Smart Track. The sum total of that nearly eight months of intense training is the belief in Sable's mind: "I went to the Asian Games in 2022. I have the same level of fitness now. I can repeat my performance in this Asian Games (2026 in Japan)," he said.

"There are 24 days left for my event in the Asian Games. My preparation is very good. I had a lot of ups and downs in my preparation after that injury (during the Monaco Diamond League in 2025).

"After that, I have done continuous training and it's a good preparation. I am confident that I can do well in the upcoming Asian Games. I feel that my old fitness has come back," he added.

But since recovering from that debilitating injury, Sable has participated in only one competition - the IFAM outdoor World Athletics Continental Tour in Oordergem, Belgium. There is a caveat too. He did not compete in his pet 3000m steeplechase event but took part in the 5000m race, in which his participation in this edition of the continental event is still doubtful.

Sable did not view it as a deterrent.

"I had an injury when the competition season started. I had planned to participate in the competition in May but could not recover in time. Training and competition are two different things.

"I feel that it is very important to participate in the competition. I felt bad that I could not participate in CWG (2026) because of that injury. My fitness was not good at that time. But I wanted to participate in Asian Games." (PTI)

Age just number, I see hunger in Shami bhai to make India comeback: Ishan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

The fire burns inside Mohammad Shami even after tallying 903 wickets in 100 first-class games, leaving East Zone skipper Ishan Kishan convinced about the pacer's "hunger and motivation" to make an India comeback.

Shami played a big role in East Zone's march to the Duleep Trophy final after 13 years, taking five wickets against Central Zone in the semifinal at Bengaluru.

"I think he is just one of the best. He has been legend of this game. He has been doing so well since he started playing for Bengal. He has been picking wickets, giving all his energy and he has

done so well for Indian team also," Kishan said.

"It's hard to say when it comes to age, I feel age is just a number. If he is working hard it doesn't matter. I see that hunger in Shami bhai because who better than me to judge about hunger right now (hinting at Kishan's time away from Indian cricket team for various reasons).

"He has been doing so well, especially having him in our team...it gives us a bit of more confidence," Kishan added. At 36, Shami is closer to the end of his career but Kishan said it has not prevented the Bengal man from asking for a few extra overs.

"Looking at his efforts as a captain, I felt very nice, because Shami bhai came in,



asking me for those extra overs to get the wickets, this is something which always gives confidence to skippers. When you have bowlers who are willing to get you wickets. So, it's always good to have him in the team."

"He also finished with two boundaries, so he is an all-rounder I feel nowadays. So I

am very happy to have him in my team," he added.

So what sets apart Shami? "Looking at Shami bhai this season, I feel he has been very different, how I have seen him in past, but his approach towards the game, his intensity, his energy has been very different."

Kishan clearly saw the

hunger in Shami, someone who desperately wanted to earn a recall to the India fold.

"You know it is hard when you are not regularly playing for the Indian team and to again have that same kind of motivation for your domestic games is tough. He has that hunger and that motivation right now like he wants to do that comeback. He wants to be part of Indian squad again and you can see it in him."

Shami's last appearance in India colours was in the Champions Trophy 2025 final against New Zealand in Dubai. But Kishan said the long absence from top-flight cricket has not dulled Shami's competitive spirit. "When he is trying to help me when I am leading the side...he is trying

to come to me, give me options of what you can do. I think these things you can pick from a player whether he is willing to win you this game or not." "That is something which all our boys are trying to do and we have been on the winning side," he added.

South Zone skipper Tilak Varma too showered praise on Shami, but said his side is ready to take on the wily pacer. "It will be a good competition for us playing against Shami bhai. We have seen in the last game how he set up batters and took that wicket. But we know that we are pretty confident for that challenge. That is why you love the sport. So, we prepared enough for that and we are ready to take him on," said Tilak.

Duleep Trophy final: Padikkal, Tilak, Sooryavanshi eye red-ball gain; Siraj searches rhythm

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Devdutt Padikkal and Tilak Varma will be eager to amplify their recent red ball gains while Mohammed Siraj will look to rediscover his rhythm ahead of some important assignments when East Zone face South Zone in the Duleep Trophy final here from Sunday.

Padikkal exploited his fortuitous entry into the Indian team, courtesy an injury to Sai Sudharsan, for the recent Test series against Sri Lanka to the hilt. The Karnataka batter returned home with two hundreds in as many Tests and a Player of the Series award to boot with.

Now, he will be hoping to replicate that performance for South Zone in the Duleep Trophy final. It will certainly help his side regain the title after 2023, but such an effort will further boost Padikkal's claim for a longer run at No. 3. Both Sooryavanshi and Tilak are not currently in the red ball scheme of things as far as the national team is concerned.

But Tilak, India's T20 vice-captain, made a strong case for himself to be considered in the traditional format scoring an unbeaten hundred and fifty in the semifinals against North Zone recently in Bengaluru. It also prompted the left-hander, who leads South Zone, to openly manifest his desire to don

India whites.

East Zone's Sooryavanshi made a 92 and 40 in the semifinal against Central Zone to state that his game has more contours to it than smashing sixes at will in white ball format. Now, if he can make a similar impact in the final then it will add more vigour to Sooryavanshi's journey to become a true all-format batter. However, seasoned pacer Siraj, who might replace injured pacer Vidwath Kaverappa, needs to slip into top gear before the upcoming tour to New Zealand. The South Zone pacer looked so off-colour against Sri Lanka in the two-match rubber.

He barely crossed 135 kmph in any of the four



innings he bowled, often operating well below his best. That lethargy prompted skipper Shubman Gill to underline the need for Siraj to regain his rhythm.

Ishan Kishan will lead East

Zone, and he will be looking forward for some valuable game time before joining the India squad for the T20I series against Afghanistan next week. KL Rahul too will be looking forward to another

round of red-ball game before intensifying his preparations for the tour to New Zealand next month. Rahul however was yet to link up with South Zone unit 24 hours before the game.

A capable East Zone attack comprising veteran India pacer Mohammad Shami, Mukesh Kumar and spinner Anukul Roy will test his skills on a pitch that often has something for the bowlers.

In that group, Shami will be a notable presence. The Bengal seamer will be appearing in his 100th first-class game, a whopping achievement for a fast bowler in this age of non-stop cricket.

But then Shami, who has 903 wickets across first-class, List A and T20 matches, is not

precisely on radar of national selectors. His last match for India was the Champions Trophy final in March 2025. But Shami, who was felicitated by the Cricket Association of Bengal, is far from disheartened. On most given occasions, the 36-year-old has produced some fiery spells to remind the powers that be that he might just have one more ride left in him.

Perhaps, an impact effort in the Duleep Trophy might just give him a sniff. However, it will be a fascinating sight over the next five days to watch some accomplished cricketers trying to channelise individual goals for teams' benefits.

Teams (from)

South Zone: Tilak Varma

(Capain), Ricky Bhui (Vice-captain & Wicketkeeper), SK Rasheed, K Sai Teja, T Vijay, Abhinav Tejran, K Himateja, T Thyagarajan, R Smaran, Karun Nair, Shreyas Gopal, Vidwath Kaverappa, MD Nidheesh, N Jagadeesan, Aman Khan, KL Rahul, Devdutt Padikkal, Mohammad Siraj.

East Zone: Ishan Kishan (Captain & Wicketkeeper), Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (Vice-Captain), Denish Das, Abhimanyu Easwaran, Sudip Kumar Gharani, Shahbaz Ahmed, Suraj Sindhu Jaiswal, Mohd. Shami, Mukesh Kumar, Kumar Kushagra, Shikhar Mohan, Anukul Roy, Virat Singh, Subhranshu Senapati, Abhijit Sarkar. Match starts at 9:30 am IST.

Boring is the new Cool

SAKSHI PRIYA

Once the ultimate insult, 'boring' has quietly become the highest compliment a life can earn proof that doing nothing loudly was always the real flex. Chat with people around the city and a rather amusing consensus emerges. Ask them point-blank, "Do you ever get bored just staying indoors to cook, sort the Sunday laundry, and drink coffee at home without stepping foot outside all weekend?" The answer usually comes with a quick laugh. "That is the coolest thing," they will tell you. For this crowd, keeping the noise away and letting the day stand perfectly still is brilliant. That supposedly dull, quiet routine? They find it completely wowing. Remember the students who preferred reading quietly over loud gatherings? Peers assumed they were missing out, but those exact habits have slowly become what adults envy most. Working fourteen hours straight and bragging about total exhaustion was once considered the peak of personal ambition. Today, the picture looks entirely inverted. Young professionals pack up the minute the clock shows five, heading straight back to

their rented rooms to build a personal sanctuary. Older generations might question the modern work ethic, but this choice feels deeply sensible. Setting a hard line at the end of the working day is a clear choice to have a life belonging to oneself rather than a company spreadsheet. Now people are growing deeply tired of treating their days like an open theatre. The joy lives entirely in doing things off-camera without needing a single person to clap for it. A standard nine to five routine was once treated as a trap, yet it has turned into a sturdy anchor giving people their evenings back. Outsiders might look at this domestic quiet and label it painfully dull. Going through a quiet, undomesticated, highly predictable day happens to be the rarest treat you can find in a busy city right now. Could it be that our endless chase for the extraordinary was always a bit of a mirage? It turns out being proudly 'boring' might actually be the new cool. Here is a closer look at what is driving this cultural shift, alongside the slow hobbies capturing a deeply exhausted generation.

JOURNALING DESK

Fountain pens and heavy ruled notebooks create a beautiful private ritual. Shambhavi, a video creator and architect from Delhi, anchors her evenings here. "I have been in journaling since very long," she explains. "I create a page of whatever I eat at, and a special self-love part in my journaling," keeping her reflections delightfully unseen.



BOOK COLLECTOR

Physical paper has dethroned the endless digital scroll. Rohan, a corporate worker, keeps his literary life completely private. "Recently in 2026, I have already read 40 books," he notes. "The plus point is doing it without uploading any success story on social media, because that is how I express myself."

A ghazal baithak that made paintings breathe



Nisschal Zaveri's Ghazal Baithak fused Amrita Sher-Gil's paintings with live Urdu poetry, proving masterpieces only wait for the right rhythm

TEAM VIVA

Visual art and live music rarely share the exact same emotional space, yet the Liszt Institute engineered a brilliant collision of both last week. The Hungarian Cultural Centre in Delhi was completely transformed into an immersive setting for *Echoes - A Ghazal Baithak* by Nisschal Zaveri,



SINGER NISSCHAL ZAVERI WRAPS HEAVY CLASSICAL VOCALS IN SHARP PIANO, BREATHING RAW LIFE INTO ANCIENT POETRY

where the profound visual legacy of painter Amrita Sher-Gil met the raw ache of live Urdu poetry. Singer and composer Nisschal Zaveri anchored the room by pouring his rigorous Patiala and Kirana gharana training straight into the verses of Mirza Ghalib and Faiz Ahmed Faiz. He effortlessly layered traditional thumri with sharp piano chords while illuminating projections of Sher-Gil's finest paintings watched over the crowd, sparking a beautiful conversation between completely different artistic lan-

guages. A glowing self-portrait of the painter seemed to absorb the exact mood of his voice, and projections featuring a melancholy resting woman alongside quiet, shadowed rural figures offered a stunning visual counterpoint to every heavy pause and deep breath the singer took on stage. It was a physical manifestation of his own artistic philosophy: "A ghazal is not just to be sung. It is to be lived-with every pause, every note, every breath."

Sher-Gil bridged European technique with the earthy reality of Indian subjects. Zaveri carries that exact dual nature forward today by wrapping ancient Urdu verses inside modern orchestral arrangements. Seeing her iconic brushstrokes seem to vibrate against live classical vocals proved a simple point. Masterpieces remain frozen under glass - they are simply waiting for the right rhythm to pull them back into the room.

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

SOURDOUGH RITUAL

Feeding a jar of flour and water on the kitchen counter requires serious, ongoing commitment. Waiting two full days for a loaf to bake transforms a quiet weekend task into the most sought-after domestic reward.



MAKER'S REVIVAL

Spending hours sorting through faded postage stamps or looping yarn into a colourful crochet pattern brings a wonderful sense of calm. Many young people would much rather sit and craft a garment stitch by stitch instead of buying something off a store rack. Doing this slow and repetitive work by hand offers a beautiful break from a very fast world.



DEDICATED COFFEE CORNER

Clearing a specific kitchen counter for brass kettles, ceramic filters, and manual bean grinders turns the early morning into personal theatre. Taking ten full minutes to brew one cup of coffee by hand proves that treating a daily chore like an art form is a highly refined choice.



PHOTOS ARE FOR REPRESENTATIVE PURPOSE ONLY

BOTANICAL NURSERY

Creating a dedicated corner in a modest apartment and filling it with deliberate routines elevates daily existence into a quiet art form. Filling rented windowsills with trailing ivy and terracotta pots takes serious dedication. Caring for leaves requiring months to grow provides a steady, grounded pace, making the cultivation of an indoor jungle incredibly chic right now.



The Flat-out edit



Styling Tip

Pair satin ballet flats with slouched knit socks and cropped trousers - an easy, Miu Miu-inspired combo that reads comfortable without giving up polish

SAKSHI PRIYA

Women are entirely done hauling backup sneakers in their tote bags. The towering stiletto has quietly bowed out, letting the ballet flat dominate city style. Today's shopper just wants footwear that survives the morning train commute and still looks incredibly sharp under a dinner table.

High fashion picked up on the mood fast. Miu Miu sparked a massive street-style obsession by sending models out in delicate satin slips shoved into thick, slouched knit socks. Chanel played to its strengths, keeping its iconic two-tone leather flats front and centre to prove heritage shapes never really leave. Meanwhile, edgy younger labels are tearing up the shoe's polite reputation altogether, trading dainty bows for blunt square toes and heavy metal hardware.

The 'balletcore' aesthetic now permeates film costumes, particularly in the Maddie Ziegler-led thriller 'Pretty Lethal', where rehearsal-room elegance bleeds into daily attire. It follows that certain styles are vanishing from shelves. The Suede Kiki Ballerina in dark plum suede channels the shadowy, screen-ready drama seen in contemporary film wardrobes, while the Gem Denim Sabrina Ballerina in indigo offers a bejewelled, easy-going choice for Saturday errands. In patent shine, sheer mesh, or buttery suede, the ballet flat has become the one shoe worth reaching for.

THE LINE UP

Black Patent with Buckles

Heavy silver hardware cuts through glossy black leather, giving a notoriously polite shoe a much-needed punk edge.



Indigo Denim with Stitching

Heavy blue denim finished with sharp contrast stitching. A durable, relaxed option that still maintains a clean, graceful shape.



Ivory Leather with Pearls

Structured cream leather finished with a line of small freshwater pearls across the toe. A sharp, vintage-inspired everyday choice.



Translucent Mesh and Crystals

Sheer black mesh covered in tiny, light-catching stones. It barely looks like a shoe, making it an excellent choice for late nights.



Deep Burgundy Crushed Velvet

Rich crimson fabric with a soft almond toe. It leans heavily into the dark, theatrical costume design dominating current cinema.



PHOTOS ARE FOR REPRESENTATIVE PURPOSE ONLY

Reanimating a lost tradition

Madhavi Festival: Swapnasundari's Vilasini Natyam and Agama Bharatham illuminate forgotten ritual traditions through Parijatham and Sarve Jana Sukhino Bhavanthu

TEAM VIVA

Centuries of temple history hold a peculiar silence where dancers once stood. Long ago, sacred Vaishnava rituals like *Baliharana* required priests to chant complex rhythms while performers physically mapped those beats across the stone floors. Eventually, the movement faded completely from the tradition, leaving modern priests to call out rhythmic syllables to a vacant room. The seventh Madhavi Festival at Stein Auditorium finally filled that long-standing void.

Padma Bhushan awardee Swapnasundari opened the evening with *Parijatham*, an original Vilasini Natyam solo

built on a 300-year-old libretto that has never been published. She wore hand-made wooden ornaments styled after old royal courts, and through them she brought Satyabhama to life - her pride, her longing for Krishna, her jealousy, her possessiveness, all carried through nuanced abhinaya and the vitality Swapnasundari is known for. She relied entirely on the unscripted spontaneity of traditional court dancers to build an connection with the



Natyalaya took the stage for *Sarve Jana Sukhino Bhavanthu*. Festival co-founder Rama Vaidyanathan invited Swapnasundari to conduct a rigorous ten-day workshop to help these young performers absorb Swapnasundari's decades of research. Swapnasundari actually spent years digging through old temple manu-

scripts to figure out the exact *Baliharana* footwork that priests used to watch. She calls this massive recovery project *Agama Bharatham*. Seeing young dancers physically hammer those forgotten beats back into the stage felt entirely different from a typical classical showcase. It played out as a loud, moving call for human peace, proving that ancient rituals only survive if artists actually put in the sweat to keep them moving.

SWAPNASUNDARI REVIVES SPONTANEOUS TEMPLE DANCE TO EXPLORE SATYABHAMA'S FIERCE LOVE



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

CINEMA



TEAM VIVA

Massive, mega-budget spectacles usually hog the Sunday headlines. Yet, one of the most surprising stories in Indian cinema today belongs to a tiny devotional film, *Hanuman Ansh*. Directed by Vishal Chaturvedi, a former MBBS doctor who left medicine to pursue filmmaking, the film, based on Neem Karoli Baba's spiritual journey, is proving to be an unlikely box-office success. The makers shot the whole project on a ridiculously tight budget of just ₹2 crore. When it first hit screens on August 7, opening day collections brought in a dismal ₹10 lakh.

The film initially appeared unlikely to recover its costs. But then word-of-mouth kicked in, and audiences began turning up in growing numbers, completely changing its fortunes Fast forward to today, and the film has crossed ₹70 crore in reported India net collections, with gross earnings approaching ₹90 crore. It even recently outperformed Yash's *Toxic* in daily collections. At the centre of this success is Shobhinaw Satyaa's portrayal of Neem Karoli Baba, resonating strongly with audiences. The remarkable run reportedly represents a return of several thousand per cent on its production budget. While not an audited profit, the numbers still make *Hanuman Ansh* one of the year's most striking underdog success stories.

HANUMAN ANSH OUTFRONS TOXIC AT THE BOX OFFICE

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The Pioneer AGENDA

We cannot stop natural disasters but we can arm ourselves with knowledge: so many lives wouldn't have to be lost if there was enough disaster preparedness .
- Petra Nemcova



The flash floods in Nepal are a grim reminder of the unforgiving power of nature. The recurring devastation raises a larger question: are natural disasters becoming more destructive, or are these disasters are our own making? In the fragile Himalayan landscape, rapid urbanisation, unplanned construction, and a changing climate converge, can quickly turn into a disaster. The Himalayas are sending a warning, but are we listening?

It is time for Global South-South Climate Action



VK BAHUGUNA

The catastrophic mountain collapses in early hours of 26th August 2026 in Tibet and deadly glacial outburst floods across Nepal are no longer isolated natural anomalies-they are like a last warning to humanity and people living in Hindu Kush region. When glacial lakes burst their banks and wash away entire Himalayan villages, Nepal serves as the world's primary indicator: the climate crisis is no longer a distant theoretical threat; it is an active ecological emergency and has now reached every household and this writer has been continuously writing about it and speaking in all forums and warning the political and administrative leadership.

As global average temperatures continuously hover beyond the 1-degree Celsius threshold above pre-industrial levels-with individual land temperature spikes already soaring past 1.5 degree Celsius, the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) CoPs have proven to be a monumental failure and at best a jamboree gossiping till mid nights and then coming up with face saving vacuous declaration by the host country. The developed nations, responsible for the vast majority of historical carbon emissions, continue to show a staggering lack of remorse. They offer empty pledges at annual summits while hoarding green technology and shirking their legal and financial damage commitments and blaming only India and China to recuse themselves from their historical responsibility.

If the Global South specially group of 77 and China continues to wait for Western goodwill, it will inherit a ruined planet with devastation like Nepal spread all over the humanity. The Cracks are already to see. We do not need to project into the future to witness the chaos of a warming planet, the indicators are already here. Already the IPCC projection of limiting temperature rise in the range of 1.5 degree Celsius in the beginning of 2100 Century threshold had already neared in the year 20230. The ominous sign of shrinking Glaciers & consequence Floods in the Himalayas due to breaking of glacial lakes in Uttarakhand, Himachal and

Nepal and the broader Hindu Kush region, temperature rises are occurring at double the global average, melting ice reserves that supply freshwater to over 1.3 billion people downstream affecting 200 crore people and their infrastructure. There are signs of extreme land warming as while ocean temperatures rise steadily, global land areas have already experienced sustained thermal spikes over above pre-industrial baselines (Earth had warmed 1.1to 1.4-degree Celsius since pre industrial era) during recent heatwaves, breaking records across Asia, Europe, and South America. Unprecedented Heat Stress is being witnessed over half of the global land surface now as prolonged stretches of extreme heat stress annually, are disrupting power grids, shutting down schools, and pushing human physiological limits.

Let us discuss about the scenario when the temperature rise will be 2 degrees Celsius. If the global temperatures cross the 2 degrees Celsius the localized tragedy of Nepal will become the daily reality for billions across the globe and therefore, we will witness a near-total ecosystem collapse. It is feared that over 99% of tropical coral reefs-the nurseries of marine life-will die off permanently, wiping out fisheries that sustain hundreds of millions of people. Further, roughly 37% of the human population will be exposed to severe, deadly heatwaves at least once every five years. Tropical and equatorial regions will experience "wet-bulb" days. The wet-bulb syndrome is a dangerous weather condition where high heat and high humidity combine so that the human body cannot cool itself through sweating. There is going to be a cascading food and water Insecurity which is going to severely compromise the agricultural yields for critical staples like maize, wheat, and rice sharply across tropical zones, while severe droughts double in frequency across Southern Africa, Asia, the Mediterranean, and South America.

There is therefore, an urgent need for a strategic shift as this writer has been advocating since past five to six years in his writings in national newspapers beseeching the mandarins in Ministry of External affairs, Prime Minister's office and the Environment Ministry to immediately organize a South-South Climate summit of group of 77 plus China which represent the 134 Countries now and thus 80% of the world population to counter the lackadaisical and selfish attitude of developed world. This is essential as the UNFCCC mechanism is paralyzed by Western double standards, the developing world must pivot to self-reliance.

CONTINUED ON >> PII

From Kedarnath to Nepal: Time to build a safer Himalaya



SATENDRA SINGH

Nepal's disaster on August 26, and India's own history at Kedarnath, point to the same lesson: an extreme event in the Himalaya may be unavoidable, but catastrophe is not. What decides the outcome is risk-informed planning, timely action, and treating the Himalaya as one connected system rather than separate states and borders. Nepal's floods made that brutally clear - villages erased, bridges gone, valleys cut off.

Nepal's task now is rescue and rebuilding. For India and the Himalaya, the harder question is what can be done beforehand so it doesn't become a full disaster. India has faced this before: Kedarnath in 2013, the Rishiganga-Dhauliganga flood in 2021, and Sikkim's South Lhonak glacial lake outburst in 2023 all show how these disasters cascade rather than stay contained.

The National Institute of Disaster Management studied Uttarakhand closely, recommending changes to land use, infrastructure, early warning, tourism and rebuilding. India has since improved scientific monitoring, GLOF preparedness and multi-hazard warning. A national review on September 3, led by Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan, stressed converting prediction into prevention and evacuation. Nepal shows the remaining gap: scientific capability must become operational capability.

When Hazard Triggers the Next

Nepal's floods were no ordinary flooding event. The Himalayan hazard environment is layered: rainfall, cloud-bursts, landslides, avalanches, glacier retreat, glacial lake outbursts, earthquakes and slope failure all interact. A landslide can dam a river into a makeshift reservoir; a rockfall into a lake can send a wave downstream; heavy rain can loosen an unstable slope. One hazard can trigger the next faster than any warning can travel.

This is why the Himalaya must be treated as a network of river basins, not administrative territories. Nepal's surge moved through the Bhote Koshi and Trishuli basins, destroying bridges and roads, and raised river levels in India's border districts. A village that looks stable on its hillside can still be at risk

from something happening kilometres upstream.

Capacity Exists - The Missing Piece Is Connecting It

India has not stood still since Kedarnath, advancing landslide forecasting, GLOF preparedness, flood modelling and multi-hazard early warning. The National Programme for Glacial Lake Outburst Flood Risk Mitigation now covers Arunachal Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, Sikkim and Uttarakhand, with satellite, geological and meteorological data increasingly combined.

Nepal exposes the next problem. A satellite flags a dangerous lake, a model predicts extreme rain, a sensor detects rising water - then what? Who gets that information, and who orders the evacuation? The task is building the machinery that turns warnings into evacuations and road closures - that should be the real focus of Himalayan disaster management.

From Warning to Action

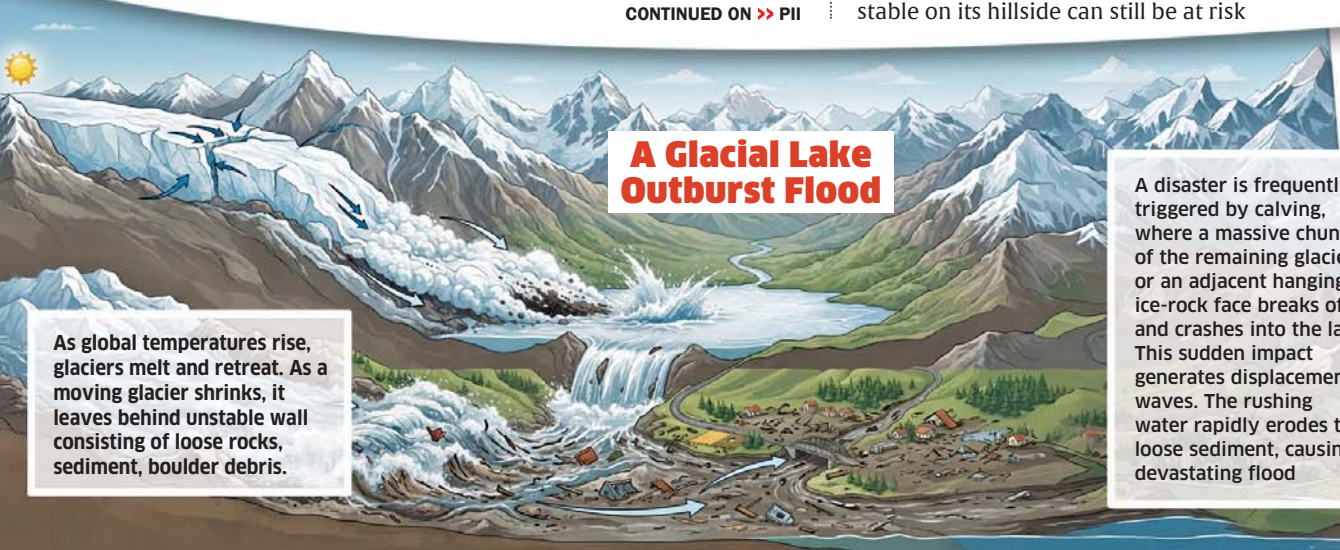
Surveys count roughly 7,500 glacial lakes across the Himalaya - a tenth in Sikkim, 25 rated very high risk - with nearly 4,700 in the Ganga basin alone, spanning a catchment of 2.5 lakh square kilometres. Many sit above hydropower projects, highways, border posts and populated valleys, demanding a risk hierarchy.

Every high-risk lake needs a mapped downstream footprint - villages, roads, bridges, power projects - paired with a working chain of detection, decision, warning, evacuation and verification, plus local authority to act and pre-identified shelters. Mapping vulnerable communities and rehearsing evacuation before the monsoon is a good start. Monitoring itself needs redundancy, since a hazard can destroy the instruments meant to detect it. The goal is moving from early warning to early action.

Build for the Mountains

India needs roads, tunnels, hydropower, transmission lines and tourist infrastructure in the Himalaya - mountain communities can't be isolated for conservation's sake. The question isn't whether to build, but how much, where, and to what standard. A plains-style road can't simply transfer to a mountainside: overcutting, blasting and poor drainage add to instability, and such roads often cause the landslides that block evacuation.

CONTINUED ON >> PII



A disaster is frequently triggered by calving, where a massive chunk of the remaining glacier or an adjacent hanging ice-rock face breaks off and crashes into the lake. This sudden impact generates displacement waves. The rushing water rapidly erodes the loose sediment, causing devastating flood



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

"I DO NOT FEEL OBLIGED TO BELIEVE THAT THE SAME GOD WHO HAS ENDOWED US WITH SENSE, REASON, AND INTELLECT HAS INTENDED US TO FORGO THEIR USE.— GALILEO ."

— GALILEO GALILEI

Bhagwat: Hindu cannot be exclusivist

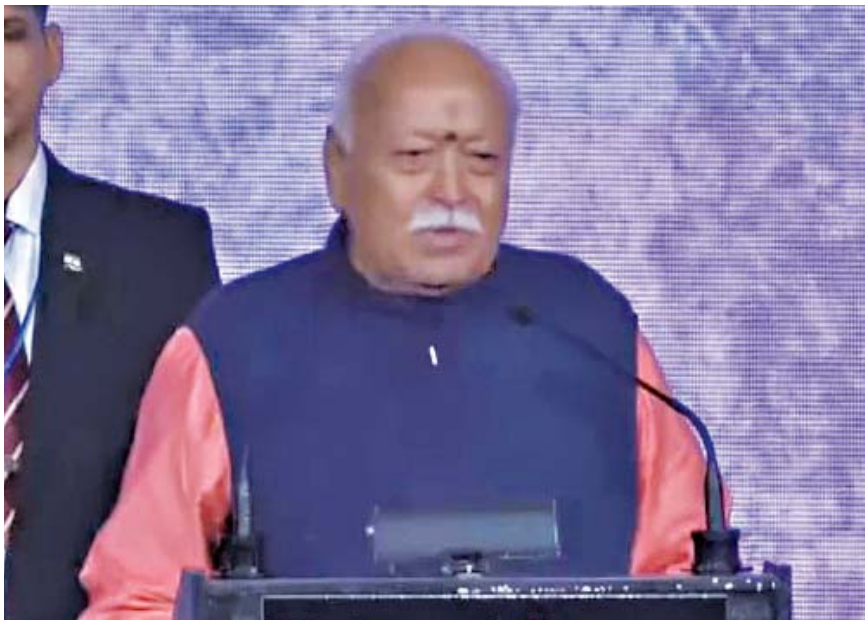


RATAN SHARDA

"The basis of this true belief, that my pain and pleasure lay in the pain and pleasure of the other is the reason for yearning for unity and its experience, harmony within humanity and feeling brotherhood. [...] This knowledge is safely stored with Hindus. No one else has it. It is the duty of one who has a treasure, to protect it and make it easily available to others. To shy away from this duty would not be the cause of our ruin alone but also of the world. This is the purpose for which we organize ourselves to create a strong society. Thus, our organization is for the good of the world. [...] People of the west are not aware of this science. Their senses are directed outwards and see outer world. They do not see inward, we see thus. Therefore, it is something worth doing for us, to awaken Hindu society to such levels that it can teach the world, that has the inclination to see outward to see inward, this knowledge with firm resolve and confidence." These words would sound familiar to many who heard Dr Mohan Bhagwat ji's speech in USA. However, they were spoken in 1954 in RSS meeting in Sindi by Shri Guruji. (M S Golwalkar: His Vision & Mission, Page 131) Dr Bhagwat presented this global vision of RSS to the world from New York.

The last stanzas of the 'Vishwa Prarthana' of Hindu Swayamsevak Sangh clearly state the global vision of Hindu thought: "Let our devotion to the cause be steadfast in organizing the people for the achievement of world peace and tranquility in the light of the universal Dharma; [...] In pursuit of the welfare of mankind which indeed is the holy cause and inspired by the noble virtues of service and sacrifice, let my being O' Lord, be offered at your feet.

Though Sangh works only within Bharat, it is recognized as a force that changed the social and political landscape of Bharat. Heavy agenda drive propaganda against RSS and Hindus hurts the Hindu commu-



nity globally. RSS is dragged in to paint targets on Hindu organisations as is apparent from the reactions and responses from various politicians, academics and media during Mohan ji's visit. Having completed it 100 years of growth, consolidation and evolution from an organisation to a movement - it was time for RSS to present itself to global audience.

It is worth noting that religious heads of 30 countries, from 16 religions and 180 scholars came together for this event. They had a heart to heart conversation with Dr Bhagwat before the public event. Looking at this big outreach with 200+ organisations across USA, one may dare say that it was the first time after Swami Vivekananda's epoch making speech in Chicago that a global vision about Hindu dharma and Bharat was presented before the world. USA was chosen as the stage, because whether we like it or not, narrative begins from USA and echoes around the world. Dr Bhagwat recalled Swami Vivekananda's words that every nation has a message, a mission and a destiny. Bharat's mission is the spread the word pluralism - see the divine unity in apparent diversity and celebrate diversity as an expression of unity in different forms, like nature. Hindu nation of Bharat stands as a living example of Spiritual Democracy where every faith, every religion has been respected and welcomed. In the same

spirit, persecuted people of different religions and races were given refuge in Bharat. Even in recent times, it has gone and supported refugees of war, people suffering from Covid etc.

The message of global relevance of Hinduness was in tune with what Shri Guruji had said decades back. It was about One atman/soul within all the human beings of whichever race, colour, religion they might be - Universal Oneness. The day chosen was Raksha Bandhan that celebrates the bond of brotherhood of the humanity, a pledge to protect each other. It is not just a festival of brother and sister, but of the society for the society sending out a message of social harmony. Prafulla Ketkar recalls that Hindus and Muslims tied rakhi to each other when they launched a successful agitation against 'Bang Bhang' division of Bengal on religious lines.

The RSS chief stressed the Hindu philosophy that material satisfaction cannot give lasting happiness. There is something else, the spiritual hunger which needs to be satiated. This can be through thought or action of helping other living beings. He talked about the difference between human beings and other living creatures who live just for consumption and pleasure. Animal does not think beyond present, human being thinks of life and afterlife. He explained that an animal

does not know the reason of its life, human being searches to know the purpose since eons. Only human beings have vivek - intellect - that really differentiate them from animal kingdom. And this awareness must be put to good use. He reminded the audience about the integral view of human beings and the nature of Hindus and importance of human beings living in harmony with the society and nature; not just as consumers but as a part of this vast universe.

In keeping with the inclusive nature of Hindu dharma, he clearly stated that Hindu cannot be exclusivist like many other ideologies, hence cannot think of throwing out minorities when it talks about Hindu Rashtra. We should be clear that Hindu idea of nationhood is not that of nation state but of cultural spirit of Bharat, which is Hindu culture. This is the culture that binds us together for eons. This thought has been expressed at various times, from Shri Guruji's interview of 1971 to Balasaheb Deoras to Sudarshan ji. He presented the two diametrically opposite ideas that can make or break the world - 'Live and Let Live' or 'Only the people who follow a certain idea have a right to live. If they agree with us, we will protect them, or they have no place in the society'. And he reiterated the Hindu philosophy of 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' as the only way for the world to survive, the thought that directs action of every conscious Hindu.

For the Indian diaspora, the message was what had been said much earlier by Shri Guruji to the swayamsevak who came to meet him from overseas. You may take inspiration from your Janmabhoomi, your punyabhoomi, but your primary loyalty should be to your karmabhoomi and see what you can contribute to the society you adopted. Thus, it was a positive messaging from RSS to dispel all the negative propaganda by the western Left intellectuals, academia and media that could spread positivity. This speech of his, along with his speech in Toronto, Canada, will echo for a long time globally. If taken in right spirit, as enunciated in the joint declaration of the religious heads and scholars signed about Universal Oneness for world peace, this could be the beginning of leading non-state actors led push for peace.

Ratan Sharda is a well known TV panelist and has authored several books. He has been a member of the RSS since his childhood days

FROM AGENDA COVER

It is time for Global...

As stated above the major emerging economies - specifically India, China, and Brazil - must spearhead a dedicated South-South Climate Technology Summit to directly transfer and scale green solutions across vulnerable nations without Western patent gate-keeping or predatory debt traps. In this regards the China's advanced solar manufacturing, India's ultra-low-cost green hydrogen and grid-scale renewables, and Brazil's agricultural bio-energy must be pooled to allow open-access vault for developing states.

From the point of view of Himalayan & equatorial early warning systems, India, China and Nepal need to establish joint satellite networks operated by ISRO, CNSA, and partner agencies must provide free, real-time glacial, atmospheric, and oceanographic monitoring data to frontline nations like Nepal, Bangladesh, and small island states.

Further countries having technology must provide Patent-Free Climate Resilient technologies for agriculture along with establishment of a collaborative research programmes for drought-tolerant seed varieties and share precision-irrigation models tailored to tropical climates. Another important thing needed is to evolve grassroots Climate Resilience for Every Household and for this the macro-level political shifts must be matched by a micro-level transition. Families can no longer rely on fragile centralized infrastructure; every household must adopt a climate-resilient lifestyle to weather the coming shocks. Water conservation is another area which the developing countries must act both at the village and city levels and promote rooftop water harvesting & greywater reuse by installing basic rainwater catchment systems and recycling household sink water reduces dependency on municipal supplies during climate-driven droughts and flood-induced contamination. To reduce the impact of heat waves painting house roofs with high-albedo reflective white coatings will lower indoor temperatures offering vital thermal protection without relying on power-hungry air conditioning. In this regards the Prime Ministers roof top solar systems and off-Grid micro small rooftop solar kits with battery backups ensure uninterrupted access to lighting, communications, and water pumping when national power grids fail during extreme weather events must be evolved through a scheme especially in rural areas in a big manner.

For food security the households should utilize micro-spaces like balconies, yards, rooftops etc to cultivate hardy, nutrient-dense native crops such as millets, sweet potatoes, and local greens - that thrive with minimal water and supplemented by decentralized seed banks, local composting networks, and emergency relief committees to act immediately when extreme weather strikes. Nepal's melting peaks are and occasion for Indian leadership to lead the global south. This tragedy also is an early warning signal for the rest of humanity. The Western-dominated climate negotiation framework has failed to deliver equity or safety. By forging a unified South-South technological alliance and fortifying our homes through grassroots resilience, the developing world can build its own defence against a warming world. The era of waiting for permission or help is over; survival demands immediate action.

The writer is former Director-general of Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education, Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change and is Chairman of Centre for Resource Management and Environment

From Kedarnath to Nepal...

The government has made progress with geotechnical, LiDAR, drone and InSAR surveys - these should become standard practice. Every major road, tunnel, bridge, hydropower project and township should pass a Disaster Impact Assessment, weighing environmental damage alongside disaster risk to and from the project. Former Union Minister Karan Singh's proposal for a Himalayan Authority - raised over concerns about infrastructure expansion, including highway four-laning - deserves fresh attention, combining geological, hydrological, ecological and disaster-management expertise with development planning, not another bureaucratic layer. Science can warn us; it cannot make an unsafe place safe - one of Uttarakhand's sharpest lessons. Hazard maps must shape land-use decisions: floodplains, unstable slopes and debris-flow channels shouldn't turn commercial just because the land is valuable. The question shifts from whether we can build somewhere to whether we should. Kedarnath's lesson isn't a ban on pilgrimage or tourism - it's managing visitors by real risk.

However advanced the national warning system, the first responder in a remote Himalayan village will be the community itself. Every vulnerable village needs trained responders, emergency communication, a marked evacuation path and a safe point, plus food, medicine, water, fuel and rescue equipment stocked before roads become impassable. Nepal's harder test begins once the crisis passes. Reconstruction defaults to restoring exactly what existed - the same home, road, bridge, tourist site - but without a fresh risk assessment, that simply recreates the next disaster. Where a settlement is unsafe, relocation must be on the table, and livelihoods need rebuilding too. The principle should be to build back better, not just what was lost.

Himalayan disaster management cannot stop at a border. India and Nepal need a real-time exchange of data on rainfall, river levels, glacial lakes and landslides - encouragingly, the Centre has asked agencies to share information as it happens, not after a disaster begins. Coordination must go beyond meetings: every major valley needs a shared risk map - hazard source, flow path, exposed population, warning status, evacuation routes, response capacity - the same logic scaled across the Himalaya, linking government, science and local communities. India's gap is not knowledge. Since Kedarnath, it has built early warning systems, GLOF mitigation, landslide prediction, satellite monitoring, community response programmes and more scientific infrastructure planning.

What's missing is the connective tissue: risk maps must shape construction; warnings must trigger decisions; sensors must prompt evacuation; roads must follow geology, not convenience; tourism must respect carrying capacity; and communities need training before disasters strike. Above all, the Himalaya needs a development philosophy of its own. The mountains don't oppose development - they oppose development that doesn't understand the mountains. We can't stop extreme rain, avalanches, landslides or glacial lake outbursts, but can limit who stands in their path, warn and evacuate faster. The real test of disaster management was never how well we rescue people from calamity, but how many never faced it. The truest tribute to those lost in Nepal, and at Kedarnath before them, is not another report after the next disaster - it is a safer Himalaya, built before it comes.

The writer is Former Executive Director, National Institute of Disaster Management and Director, SAARC Disaster Management Centre

The ghosts that are really memory

LAKSHMI PURI

"Ghosts are all around us. Seek them out and you shall discover them," Ruskin Bond once said — an apt threshold into a disarmingly entertaining book. As someone susceptible to such phenomena, I read it hoping for insight as much as validation that the unreal is real. Roy's hauntings are never confined to ghosts alone — apparitions, premonitions, eerie presences, even an apparent possession.

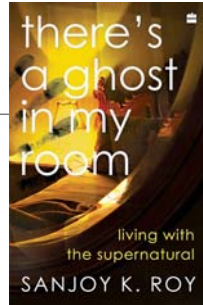
Calling it a ghost-story collection undersells it; this is closer to a supernatural memoir, part autobiography, part travelogue, part social history, where the unexplained becomes a portal into decades of lived experience. Roy begins with an advantage rare among writers of the paranormal: he isn't anxious to convince anyone. He owns experiences that challenged his rational understanding without claiming to be a mystic or seer; these, he suggests, are his reality. The reader decides.

That refusal to proselytise gives it credibility and charm; there is no grand theory, only an accumulation of experiences offered as: this happened, I cannot explain it, perhaps you can. The sixteen chapters move from Calcutta and Delhi to Khajuraho, Rishikesh and the Himalayas, then onward to Jerusalem and Valladolid. Geography is never decorative — Roy has an instinct for places where history seems to settle into the walls. That is the book's most compelling idea: places remember.

A Delhi neighbourhood conceals histories beneath modern construction; Khajuraho becomes a repository of centuries; in Valladolid, an apparition leads Roy toward the Inquisition and the persecuted Alumbrosos. His technique is effective: chapters often open cinematically — a child staring into darkness, Roy convulsing on a bus — before he wanders into a house's history or a memory, circling back to the inexplicable only later.

At its best, this gives the book the expansive quality of conversation. A second memoir sits quietly inside the first: the story of an India changing around its narrator.

Roy's childhood spans Cochin, Calcutta, Bombay, Delhi and



Author: Sanjoy K. Roy
Publisher: Harper Fictions
Pages: 100 pages
Price: ₹329

London; his father's naval career brings the 1971 war home; later come liberalisation, television's rise, and Teamwork's ferment through the 1990s, forming the world that produced the Jaipur Literature Festival. These are not interruptions; for Roy, the supernatural does not exist outside ordinary life — it walks straight through it. Puneeta is one of its key presences, often more instinctively receptive than her husband; children, siblings, friends and pets lend warmth, and the paranormal unfolds amid marriages, meals and domestic chaos.

Humour helps too — in Rishikesh, a feared tiger turns out to be light glinting off a packet of chips. The register darkens in "The Fire," where Roy's narrative meets the 1997 Uphaar cinema tragedy — an all-too-real horror of negligence and grief, a reminder its gravest terrors aren't always paranormal. Elsewhere the ghosts turn benign: the Nainital presence at Madam Durell's grows almost custodial, and the Valladolid apparition inspires curiosity rather than fear.

Perhaps the truest ghosts are history, memory and attachment — people leave, houses change hands, civilisations build over ruins, yet something remains. Roy never tells us what it proves, and that is exactly why the book works. Warm, atmospheric and richly anecdotal, "There's a Ghost in My Room" is less about fearing the dead than learning to live with the unexplained; believers will feel confirmed, sceptics may begin to wonder — and either way, you'll look differently at the rooms and memories we mistakenly think we inhabit alone.



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This Week's Zodiac Insights

Profession • Money • Family • Relationships • Health • Travel



Mesha | Aries

This week feels rewarding, especially after a period that may have tested your patience and resilience. At work, long-awaited recognition or even a promotion may finally come through, while friends can be especially helpful if you are racing against a deadline. Family life brings warmth and pride, but joint pain or physical discomfort could slow you down, so give yourself enough rest.

Lucky colour: Dark purple

Watch out for: Overexertion and ignoring recurring joint pain.



Vrishabha | Taurus

A little good luck seems to follow you this week, and people around you are likely to value your opinions more than usual. Business connected with transport, imports or exports can do well, while money matters may improve enough to ease an old debt or financial pressure. Relationships need more patience, especially with your partner or sibling, and stress may show up through headaches, fever or general tiredness.

Lucky colour: Rust brown

Watch out for: Family disagreements and neglecting your health.



Mithuna | Gemini

You are likely to handle pressure better than you expect this week, and staying calm will help you get more done. Work progresses smoothly, finances may bring a pleasant surprise and plans around shifting home or booking a new place could also move ahead. Relationships may need some compromise, while an elderly family member's health deserves attention if it has been put off for too long.

Lucky colour: White

Watch out for: Careless words with elders and overlooking family health matters.



Karka | Cancer

Some of the effort you have put in earlier may begin to come back to you this week, even if a few official matters continue to move slowly. Your communication is strong and business shows steady progress, but be particularly careful with banking, payments and important financial transactions. Personal relationships can become tense over differences of opinion, and those already dealing with blood pressure or stress should avoid situations that leave them worked up.

Lucky colour: Blood red

Watch out for: Financial mistakes, arguments and stress-related health issues.



Simha | Leo

The week may start with a few frustrations, but things become easier once you stop seeing every setback as a defeat. Business owners may think about expansion or bringing new people into a venture, while fresh professional contacts can turn out to be useful, although money owed to you may be delayed. Misunderstandings at home need a calmer response, and neck or shoulder strain is possible if your posture or routine has been poor.

Lucky colour: Rust brown

Watch out for: Delayed payments, heated arguments and physical strain.



Kanya | Virgo

This is a week when things finally begin to move after a period of feeling stuck. People are more willing to trust your judgement, long-term plans can make real progress and your finances look steady enough to start building a stronger safety cushion. Keep love matters simple and avoid turning small differences into bigger discussions, while time with friends or outdoors can do wonders for your mood.

Lucky colour: Green

Watch out for: Unnecessary relationship debates and spending without setting something aside.



Tula | Libra

Patience will help you more than speed this week, especially when deadlines, paperwork or last-minute changes begin to test you. Extra effort can still bring additional income and better savings, but rushing through work may only create more pressure. Relationships can become touchy over differing viewpoints, a planned trip may change because of family needs and physical strain should be avoided if you are already feeling uncomfortable.

Lucky colour: Pale red

Watch out for: Arguments, deadline stress and pushing yourself physically.



Vrishchika | Scorpio

You may have a lot on your plate this week, but that pressure can actually bring out your most focused side. Career and business look strong, especially if you are planning something of your own, while finances and vehicle-related plans may also move in a favourable direction. Your partner is likely to be supportive, though different opinions at home could create some tension and old friends may unexpectedly come back into your life.

Lucky colour: Metallic gold

Watch out for: Family disagreements and taking on more responsibility than you need.



Dhanu | Sagittarius

This can be a strong week for anyone whose work depends on ideas, writing, speaking or being seen by the right people. A fresh professional idea may win support from seniors, but property or land-related matters should be checked carefully before you sign or commit to anything. Family concerns, particularly around an elderly relative, may need your attention, while a short trip can help you reset mentally.

Lucky colour: Turmeric yellow

Watch out for: Legal paperwork, family concerns and ignoring unusual health symptoms.



Makara | Capricorn

Progress may be slow this week, but the good news is that things that have been pending can finally start getting finished. Career matters need careful judgement and major investments, especially in property or construction, are better handled only after checking every detail. Relationships feel lighter, travel can bring good family time and a calm, measured way of speaking will help you handle people more easily.

Lucky colour: White

Watch out for: Risky investments, work pressure and minor injuries while moving around.



Kumbha | Aquarius

You may feel more drawn to home and family this week, even if work is still bringing you some good results. Career-related gains are possible and money that was lent out earlier may return, giving your finances a welcome boost. Relationships may not feel as dependable as you would like, so lean on trusted friends where needed and pay attention to any recurring nervous-system or physical discomfort.

Lucky colour: Blood red

Watch out for: Expecting too much from others and brushing aside health concerns.



Meena | Pisces

This is a week to slow down before saying yes, no or making any decision you cannot easily reverse. You may feel eager to get moving at work and an unexpected financial development connected with family assets could come up, but acting in a hurry may not give you the result you want. Relationships and family conversations need a softer approach, and it is better to take your time before trusting new people or ignoring a health issue that keeps returning.

Lucky colour: Pale red

Watch out for: Hasty decisions, unnecessary arguments and delaying health care.



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GENUINE HAPPINESS”
— AUGUSTE ESCOFFIER

Paryushan : A cuisine shaped by mindfulness



ANIL
RAJPUT

Some festivals announce themselves through abundance. Paryushan enters the home by asking what can be relinquished. The kitchen grows quieter, ingredients disappear from the shelf and appetite itself becomes a subject of reflection. Yet this deliberate simplicity does not diminish food culture. It reveals another kind of richness, shaped by ahimsa, discipline, seasonality and care.

Indian festivals are not simply occasions marked on a calendar. They are among the most enduring carriers of India's cultural memory. Through rituals, stories, prayers, family customs and food, values pass almost imperceptibly from one generation to the next. Every traditional dish forms part of this inheritance: its ingredients speak of geography and season, its preparation preserves household knowledge, and its place within a festival recalls why and when it was made. Recording such traditions therefore preserves not merely recipes, but the cultural meaning that gives them life. In 2026, Shvetambara Paryushan begins on Tuesday, 8 September and continues for eight days until Samvatsari on Tuesday, 15 September. Across those sacred days, many Jains fast completely, while others eat within carefully chosen limits. For those who cook, every decision, from selecting a pulse to boiling drinking water, can become an expression of reverence for life.

Paryushan is among the most important annual observances in the Shvetambara Jain tradition. Its name carries the idea of drawing closer to the self, quietening passions and shedding karma through austerity. It falls during the monsoon Chaturmas, when Jain monks and nuns remain in one place. The rains bring forth insects and minute forms of life, making travel more likely to cause unintended harm. Staying put therefore reflects ahimsa as a discipline practised in response to the living world.

Over eight days, devotees deepen prayer, meditation, scriptural study and self-examination. The Kalpa Sutra, which includes accounts of the Tirthankaras and Lord Mahavira's birth, is read in Shvetambara congregations. Pratikraman encourages reflection upon faults in thought, speech and action. The observance culminates in Samvatsari, when forgiveness is sought with the words “Micchami Dukkadam”, acknowledging hurt caused knowingly or unknowingly. Digambara Jains mark the related but distinct ten-day Das Lakshan Parva, devoted to ten virtues. The distinction preserves Paryushan's particular religious setting while recognising a shared Jain commitment to purification.

Food participates in this inner work because Jain philosophy asks the eater to consider the life affected by every meal. Underground vegetables such as potatoes, onions, garlic, carrots and radishes are avoided because uprooting them destroys the plant and disturbs organisms in the soil. During Paryushan, many households adopt further restrictions, including fresh greens, certain fruits and ingredients whose use can involve greater harm during the monsoon. Meals are prepared and consumed before sunset, although exact practices differ among families and sanghs. Taken together, these choices give Paryushan a distinctive philosophy of food. What is eaten, when it is eaten, how it is prepared and even what is consciously left uneaten become expressions of ahimsa, restraint and responsibility towards other forms of life. Its cuisine is therefore not simply religious food, but an ethical system practised in the



kitchen.

There is no single Paryushan menu because the observance includes different forms of tapasya. Some undertake upvas and consume no food, often taking only boiled water within prescribed hours. Ekasana permits one sitting for a meal, while Biyasana permits two. Ayambil is stricter, centring on one plain meal without rich flavouring, oil, ghee, milk products or sweets. The dishes described here belong to the wider food culture surrounding Paryushan, especially among Gujarati and Rajasthani Jain families eating restricted meals. They are not suitable for every fast or expected of every devotee.

Within those limits, western Indian Jain kitchens have developed an extraordinary pantry intelligence. Dried vegetables, gram flour, pulses, grains, dairy where permitted and preserved foods can carry an entire meal without underground produce. Gujarati Gathiya nu Shaak captures this resourcefulness. Thick chickpea-flour gathiya are simmered in a spiced gravy, often based on curd, buttermilk or dry masala adapted to family rules. They soften at the edges while retaining some bite and are eaten with rotli or another permitted flatbread.

A related pantry dish, Papad nu Shaak, turns roasted lentil papad into pieces that soften in a curd-based or spiced gravy. Its salty, toasted character gives body to a meal when fresh vegetables have been set aside. Moong Vadi nu Shaak follows the same logic. Sun-dried nuggets made from moong paste are cooked until tender in a restrained gravy, providing texture without fresh produce. Ingredients dried before the monsoon thus become especially valuable during sacred days.

The Gujarati repertoire continues with Chana Dhokli nu Shaak, in which pieces of firm gram-flour dough are simmered with chickpeas and dry spices until they absorb the surrounding flavours. The dish is substantial without relying on root vegetables and is served with rotli as part of a daytime meal. For a different balance of sweet and savoury, Pakka Kela nu Shaak uses ripe banana rather

than raw plantain. Slices are gently cooked with cumin, chilli, turmeric and a souring element allowed by the household, creating a soft shaak in which the natural sweetness of the fruit is checked by spice. Bananas also appear in Kelawada, small fritters made by combining mashed ripe banana with flour and seasonings before frying spoonfuls until golden. Where frying is permitted, they are enjoyed warm as a compact snack rather than an unrestricted indulgence.

Another ingenious preparation is Banana Chivda, made from thin banana slices fried until crisp and tossed with salt, pepper or selected dry spices. It keeps well, requires no green garnish and is eaten in modest portions during permitted hours. Alongside it, Sing Daliya ni Chutney combines crushed roasted peanuts, dry coconut, sesame or permitted spices. Ground without fresh herbs or garlic, this dry, nutty accompaniment enlivens rotli and gram-flour dishes. Both show how flavour can be created without weakening the observance's restraint.

Across Rajasthan, an arid landscape had already taught cooks to make exceptional use of gram flour, dried berries and little water. Gatte ki Sabzi is therefore naturally at home in many Paryushan kitchens. Besan is kneaded with spices into firm cylinders, boiled, sliced and simmered in a curd gravy. The dumplings absorb the tangy sauce and are eaten with rotis, turning shelf-stable ingredients into a complete dish.



The

desert's
most distinctive

contribution is Panchkuta, traditionally built from dried ingredients such as ker berries, sangri beans, kumatiya seeds, gunda and dried mango. The components are soaked, cleaned, boiled and cooked with oil and dry spices. Each contributes a different sensation, from the sharpness of ker to the fibrous bite of sangri, while dried mango supplies acidity when fresh lemon is avoided. This is not a generic festival vegetable, but an expression of a regional ecology in which scarcity, preservation and respect for resources have long shaped taste.

Curd and gram flour also meet in Pakodawali Kadhi, a Rajasthani preparation in which small besan fritters are immersed in a gently simmered yoghurt gravy. The tempering is adjusted to Paryushan rules, relying on asafoetida, cumin, mustard seeds and dried chilli rather than fresh aromatics. The soft pakodas make the kadhi more substantial and it may be paired with rice during a permitted meal. Each of these savoury dishes is adaptable, but adaptation must remain honest. A recipe becomes appropriate only when every ingredient, preparation method and eating time agrees with the discipline observed in that particular home.

Sweet preparations require the same qualification. They are not part of Ayambil and have no place during a complete fast, but some families prepare them for those who are eating, for children, for communal hospitality within permitted rules or for the parna meal after a period of fasting has formally ended. Gujarat's Mohanthal is among the most prized. Coarse besan is rubbed with ghee and milk to form a grainy texture, roasted slowly until nutty, then set with sugar syrup, cardamom and sometimes saffron.

Cut into dense squares, it rewards patient roasting and is served in small pieces.

Wheat takes a more rustic form in Churma Laddoo. Coarse-flour dough portions are fried or baked, crushed into crumbs and mixed with melted ghee, jaggery or sugar and cardamom before being shaped into balls. Barfi Churma begins with a similar crumb but is pressed into a tray and cut into squares or diamonds,

giving the familiar flavours of churma a firmer, sliceable form. Both preparations preserve an older household knowledge of judging texture by touch, knowing when the flour is roasted enough and adding just sufficient ghee for the mixture to hold.

In Sukhdi, also called Gol Papdi, wheat flour is roasted in ghee until aromatic, removed from intense heat and mixed with jaggery so that it melts without turning hard or bitter. The mixture is spread quickly and cut while still warm. Its short ingredient list makes precision essential. Lapsi develops sweetness more slowly. Broken wheat is roasted in ghee, cooked until the grains swell and then sweetened with jaggery or sugar, often with cardamom and nuts. Served warm, it retains a pleasantly separate grain and carries the comfort of a sweet made from the everyday grain cupboard rather than elaborate decoration.

Gram flour returns in Magaj, but with a texture distinct from Mohanthal. Fine besan is gently roasted in ghee and combined with powdered sugar and cardamom to create a soft, rich sweet that may be shaped or set. Moong Dal Halwa, associated especially with Rajasthan, demands still more patience. Soaked moong dal is ground and roasted slowly in ghee until its raw aroma disappears, then cooked with milk or water and sugar until glossy. Kalakand completes the sweeter spread where dairy is allowed. Milk is reduced or gently curdled and cooked with sugar until moist granules form, then set and cut. None of these sweets defines Paryushan by itself, but together they show how regional Jain households accommodate different ages and levels of observance without confusing nourishment with spiritual licence.

Even beverages are governed by attention. Boiled water holds the central place for many devotees because water is filtered and boiled to reduce harm to minute life, then consumed only within the time and storage limits prescribed by one's tradition or sangh. Those not undertaking a strict fast may drink plain milk, lightly flavoured Masala Milk prepared with cardamom, saffron or permitted dry spices, ordinary tea, a mild dry-ginger infusion or water sweetened with mishri. Such drinks are neither universal nor interchangeable. Milk, sugar and spices are excluded from stricter practices such as Ayambil, while someone observing upvas may take only boiled water. The beverage chosen is therefore another declaration of the vow being followed.

This is what makes Paryushan cuisine remarkable. Its depth lies not in a celebratory thali but in the moral reasoning that precedes the meal. A papad becomes a vegetable, dried desert produce replaces a market basket and ripe banana supplies both shaak and snack, while the empty plate of a fasting devotee remains just as meaningful as another's carefully restricted meal. Both express the effort to loosen appetite's hold and turn attention inward.

The Paryushan kitchen has also served as an informal classroom of culture. Recipes were rarely transmitted in isolation. Along with a method came an explanation: why one ingredient was avoided, why another was preserved, why food was prepared before a particular hour and why a dish belonged to a season or sacred occasion. Younger generations should therefore be invited to roast besan for Mohanthal, clean ker and sangri, shape gatta and grind a dry chutney while learning the values behind each act. Cuisine can carry knowledge without calling itself education. Preserving Paryushan's food traditions means passing on both recipe and reasoning, so the observance remains not only marked on a calendar but understood through choices made at the stove, at the table and, sometimes, through the profound choice not to eat at all.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

Nutrition Week 2026 The value of eating right, and how India can get there

TEAM AGENDA

New government survey data show India winning some old nutrition battles even as a newer one — obesity — gathers pace. Since 1982, India has observed September 1 to 7 as National Nutrition Week, built around a simple idea: food is not just fuel; it is vital to health, learning and productivity. This year's observance overlaps with Rashtriya Poshan Maah, whose 2026 push uses the theme “Poshan Bhi Padhai Bhi” — nutrition and education together for children.

The numbers tell a mixed story. In the 2025 Global Hunger Index, India ranked 102nd of 123 countries, with a score of 25.8, an improvement on 105th the year before. Undernourishment, stunting and child mortality have improved, but child wasting has barely shifted.

The National Family Health Survey-6, covering 2023-24, shows child stunting falling from 35.5 per cent to 29.3 per cent and severe

wasting nearly halving, from 7.7 per cent to 5.2 per cent. But the underweight rate among children barely moved. Overweight and obesity among women have climbed from 13 per cent in the mid-2000s to nearly 31 per cent now. ICMR's National Institute of Nutrition estimates that more than 17 million Indian children and adolescents are living with obesity, with the figure expected to cross 27 million by 2030. This is a double burden: stunting, micronutrient deficiency and obesity.

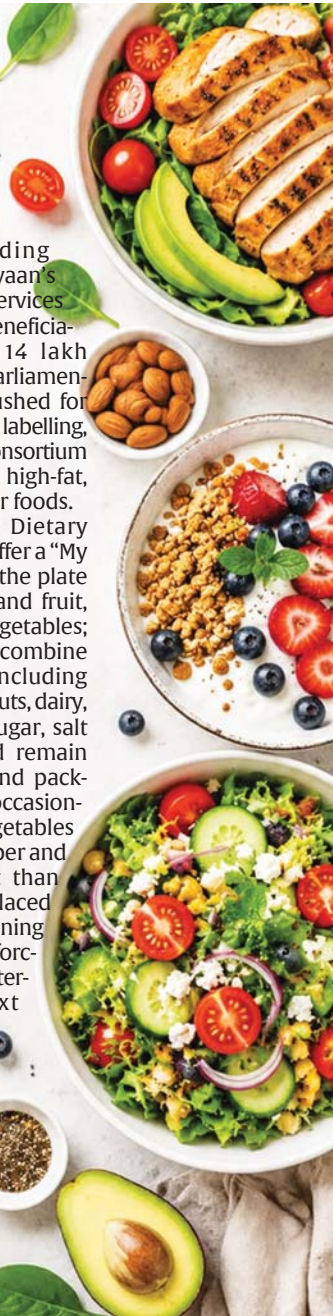
It happens when diets change faster than public health systems can adjust: processed food, sedentary work and a food environment where unhealthy options are the

A RECENT UNICEF REPORT FOUND THAT CHILDHOOD OBESITY HAS OVERTAKEN UNDERWEIGHT AS THE WORLD'S MOST COMMON FORM OF MALNUTRITION AMONG SCHOOL-AGE CHILDREN FOR THE FIRST TIME - AND INDIA, AGAIN, IS SQUARELY PART OF THAT SHIFT

cheapest and closest.

Policy is responding unevenly. Poshan Abhiyaan's tracking app monitors services for close to nine crore beneficiaries across roughly 14 lakh Anganwadi centres. A parliamentary committee has pushed for mandatory front-of-pack labelling, while an ICMR-NIN-led consortium has proposed a tax on high-fat, high-salt and high-sugar foods.

ICMR-NIN's revised Dietary Guidelines for Indians offer a “My Plate for the Day”: half the plate should be vegetables and fruit, including green leafy vegetables; the other half should combine grains and protein, including cereals, millets, pulses, nuts, dairy, eggs or meat. Added sugar, salt and refined oil should remain minimal, while fried and packaged snacks should be occasional. Millets, seasonal vegetables and pulses can be cheaper and more climate-resilient than much of what has replaced them in urban diets. Training Anganwadi staff and enforcing food labelling will determine whether next September's numbers look different.



The India beyond the familiar plate



GYANESHWAR DAYAL

Indian cuisine is a vast map of flavours, ingredients and cooking traditions, with each region offering dishes shaped by its own history and communities. MaatriBhoomi seeks to bring that diversity to the table, offering diners an opportunity to explore regional Indian food through recipes, indigenous ingredients and traditional cooking techniques.

That premise comes from research, not romance. The team behind the restaurant covered over 14,000 km across the country, tracking down regional recipes, indigenous ingredients and cooking techniques that rarely make it past the communities that keep them alive. The result is a menu built on discovery rather than the usual butter chicken-and-naan

shorthand for “Indian food” — think Dilli Wali Chowmein, Palak Anjeer Kebab, Dadar Vada Pav and Gujarati Dhokla Chaat sharing table space, each dish carrying its region's fingerprint rather than a generic makeover.

The menu also explores the textures, spices and flavours that give each regional dish its identity. From familiar street-food favourites to lesser-known recipes, the food aims to offer diners a sense of place with every plate. The emphasis is on ingredients, traditional techniques and flavours that remain rooted in their original culinary traditions.

What sets the



concept apart is the ambition to hold two things together that Indian restaurants rarely attempt at once: regional authenticity and premium hospitality. Too often, one comes at the cost of the other - food dressed down for fine dining, or fine dining

A FLAVOURFUL JOURNEY ACROSS INDIA, SERVING REGIONAL RECIPES, INDIGENOUS INGREDIENTS AND CULINARY TRADITIONS

dropped to keep the food honest. The team is betting diners want both, with context built in: every dish carries the story of the region and community it came from, turning a meal into something closer to a guided tour of India's culinary map.

“MaatriBhoomi comes from a deep desire to celebrate the incredible diversity of Indian cuisine,” says founder Priyank Gautam. “Our journey of over 14,000 km across the country gave us the opportunity to experience food at its source, meet communities that have preserved these traditions, and discover recipes that deserve to be celebrated.” Whether execution matches ambition will only be clear once the doors open. But as a concept, it's a rare bet on complexity over convenience — one Noida's dining scene could use more of.



Shri Krishna's Living Presence of Love

AMMA (SRI MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI DEVI)

Behind the perishable faces of this world stands the one imperishable Reality, the Supreme Self, beyond all space and time. Janmashtami is the holy day that this eternal power took form in Gokula to uplift the world during dark times.

The birth and deeds of Shri Krishna, who lies beyond word and beyond thought, cannot truly be told. By releasing a Ganga-flood of loving devotion in countless hearts, by sweeping away the dust of ages, by re-establishing dharma and giving us the essence of the scriptures through the Bhagavad Gita, the Lord brought about a new dawn for humankind.

Such an avatar is the never-ending source of the universe folding itself, of its own will, into the small vessel of a human form, and walking among us as an "ordinary" person.

It is a rare grace to be able to see the Divine in this form with our very own eyes, hear it with our ears, speak to it with our lips, touch it with our hands, and feel it with our hearts.

More words cannot give the sweetness of honey, but let a single drop fall on the tongue, and we know it at once. This is what the presence of an enlightened being imparts to the world. Their company is itself a path to the experience of the Self. As the very light of the world, they live on forever in the hearts of the people they reach.

This was the experience Shri Krishna offered to everyone who saw him. From the moment of his birth, life was thick with obstacles and opposition, yet he went forward unshaken.

He protected those in need of protection and corrected those in need of correction. He consoled the grieving, gave courage to the faint-hearted, and showed the way to those who had



With children around, Amma watches the breaking of pots for Janmashtami celebrations in Amritapuri

lost it. In hearts that were pure, he awakened selfless love.

According to their level of understanding, Shri Krishna gave each one the fruits of their lives — teachings, understanding, prosperity, righteousness, fulfilment, and liberation. In every way, the lives of all those who came to the Lord were blessed.

For the sake of dharma Krishna was ever at work, and he honoured every kind of labour alike, counting none too lowly. As Arjuna's charioteer, he tended the horses. At Yudhishtira's great sacrifice, he washed the feet of the guests. When Draupadi's garment was pulled away in insult before the court, he made the cloth endless so her honour was saved.

Shri Krishna lived on Earth both as the protector of devotees and as their servant, attached to nothing, flowing

along with time. By his life, his work, his teachings, and just his presence, he made every particle of the Earth he stepped upon sacred again.

When an actor enters the stage, he plays his role as though it were life itself; so too did Krishna live in the world as a divine play. A theatre performance is meant to give joy to those who watch, and to carry within it a teaching of values.

In just this way, the Lord both delighted the people around him and taught them the lessons of dharma. The many acts of this sacred story, from scenes of sorrow to scenes of joy, led to the redemption of countless souls.

Krishna manifested many wonders, yet the greatest wonder was the loving devotion he awakened in human hearts, above all in the gopis of Vrindavan. Those simple, unlettered village women rose to a height that even the sages could not reach.

Even if we have everything else in life, we become truly blessed only when there is sincere love for God, and we surrender everything to Him. That is the message of Shri Krishna's life.

(Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, known simply as Amma, is a spiritual master and humanitarian who has given her darshan in the form of a motherly embrace to more than 4 crore people. Listening to the cries of the suffering, Amma leads the Mata Amritanandamayi Math, an NGO that reaches across more than 50 countries, working in the areas of healthcare, disaster relief, education, gender equality, and environmental restoration)



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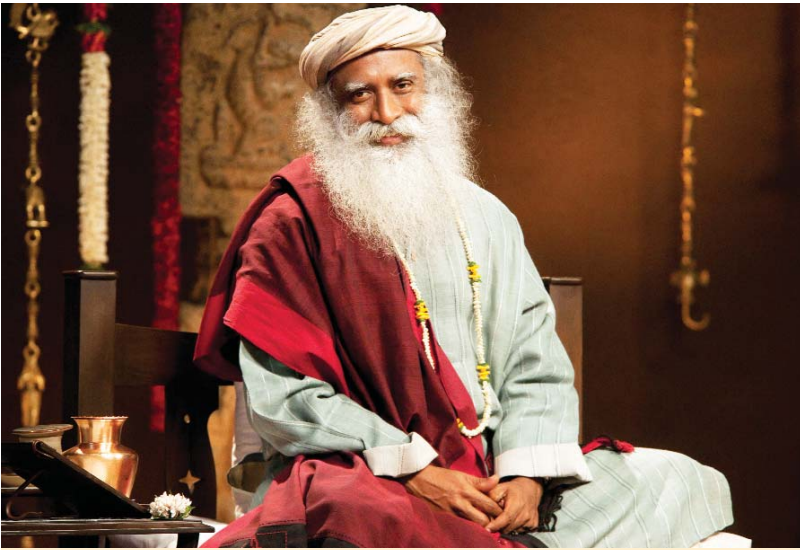
Inner management is essential

SADHGURU

Commerce is something that we believe will decide the quality of human life in many ways. It is a 50 per cent truth because when a human being is in poverty, you cannot tell him anything other than food. When you are hungry, your whole consciousness will be food. If you go and ask a beggar how much is 2+2, he may say four chappatis. The whole thing will be about food when there is no food.

It will not be possible to talk to a human being about anything higher in his life when his fundamental needs are not taken care of. But we need to understand that this journey from poverty to affluence is a hard journey. Whether it is for an individual person or for a society or nation or large populations in the world, it is a hard journey. It does not happen easily, it comes with an enormous price attached to it. But most of the time when people get there, they cannot enjoy their affluence.

Most societies suffer their affluence. For example, in the United States, which is among the richest country in the planet, average citizens have so much comfort and convenience that even royalty could not have afforded a hundred years ago. In spite of that, a significant percentage of the population in United States is on some kind of anti-depressants. If you just take away a particular medicine from the market, half the nation will go crazy. That is not wellbeing. It does not matter where you live, how you live, what you eat, what you



WE AS AN INDIVIDUAL, AS A SOCIETY, AS A NATION, AS A WORLD, WE HAVE NOT INVESTED ANYTHING TOWARDS INNER WELLBEING. IT IS TIME WE INVEST IN OUR INNER WELLBEING

wear, what you drive, if you are not happy, you cannot call it wellbeing.

If you do not know how to manage yourself, your happiness will be accidental. Outside situations are not always going to be in your control because the outside situation involves a million different ingredients. Most of them do not even know what they are actually. Only some you understand and those you try to control. Rest you do not even understand, so there is no question of controlling. You are just hoping it will all fall into place. But when it comes to inner situa-

tion, there is only you, just you. This inner situation at least must happen your way. If this one does not happen your way, you are a lost case. So if you want to be happy, you have to manage yourself properly. Management means creating situations the way you want it. Just as you manage your family, finance, industry, business, it is important to manage your mind, your emotion, your energy, your body. And your ability to manage the outside situations will come to you only when the inside is well managed. Unfortunately we as an individual, as a society, as a nation, as a world, we have not invested anything towards inner wellbeing. It is time we invest in our inner wellbeing.

(Ranked amongst the fifty most influential people in India, Sadhguru is a Yogi, mystic, visionary and a New York Times bestselling author. Sadhguru has been conferred the Padma Vibhushan by the Government of India in 2017, the highest annual civilian award, accorded for exceptional and distinguished service. He is also the founder of the world's largest people's movement, Conscious Planet- Save Soil, which has touched over 4 billion people)

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Does God dwell in the temple?

The mandir does not bring God closer to us; rather, it brings our wandering hearts closer to God. When our hearts are filled with devotion, the silent murti begins to speak, and the heart understands it all

DR SWAMI GYANANANDDAS

How did this magnificent universe come into existence? Was it the result of an accident, or did it unfold according to an intelligent order? Is there a Creator behind this vast cosmos? And if God truly exists, is He merely an abstract, formless reality, or can He assume a personal and manifest form?

These questions have accompanied humanity for centuries. Philosophers have debated them, scientists have explored the mysteries of the universe, and rishtis have sought their answers through direct spiritual experience. Yet for millions of devotees, the answer is not confined to philosophical arguments. It is experienced in a far more intimate way, in prayer, in devotion, and before the sacred murti of God in a temple(mandir).

The history of Indian spirituality is filled with such experiences. Mirabai, the great saint-poet of Rajasthan, possessed an unshakable conviction that God was not just a distant philosophical concept but a living, loving presence. Her devotion to Shri Krishna was so intense that, according to devotional tradition, she experienced the ultimate divine bliss of Him. To those who dismissed her faith as imagination or superstition, her life itself became her answer. For Mirabai, the murti was not an object of stone or metal; it was a sacred medium through which the Divine became present to the heart of the devotee.

This is the essential idea behind the Hindu tradition of murti worship. A mandir is not merely an architectural structure, nor is a consecrated murti simply a work of art. Through the sacred rite of consecration and, more importantly, through the faith and devotion of generations, the mandir becomes a spiritual space where the human heart learns to encounter the Divine.

Even in the modern age, incidents have occasionally drawn public attention to this question of divine presence. On 21 September 1995, reports spread rapidly from India to many parts of the world that devotees were observing murtis of Lord



Ganesha appearing to accept milk offered with a spoon. The phenomenon created extraordinary public interest, and people gathered at mandirs across India and abroad to witness it. Whatever explanations one may offer for such events, the episode demonstrated something undeniable: for millions, the sacred murti of God is not a lifeless symbol but the focal point of a living faith.

The Hindu scriptures have expressed this principle for centuries. In the Vachanamrut, Bhagwan Swaminarayan cites a verse from the Shrimad Bhagavatam to explain the divine presence in the consecrated murti of God and in the God-realized sant. He states, "God eternally resides in His various forms of consecrated murtis and in His spiritually enlightened devotee." The purpose of the murti, therefore, is not to limit the infinite God within a material form. Rather, it is to make the human encounter with the infinite more personal, accessible and loving.

After all, the human mind often needs a point of focus. We cannot easily love an abstraction. We may intellectually accept that God is everywhere, but the restless mind struggles to experience that omnipresence continuously. A murti provides a center for the wandering mind and a direction for the searching heart.

This is also why mandirs continue to hold relevance even in the twenty-first century. In a world filled with noise, distraction and constant digital stimulation, a mandir offers something increasingly rare: silence. The ringing of a bell, the fragrance of incense, the rhythmic

sound of prayers and the peaceful darshan of the murti gradually draw the mind away from worldly anxieties. A mandir gives the individual an opportunity to pause and ask questions that technology cannot answer: Who am I? What is the purpose of my life? How should I live?

Pramukh Swami Maharaj often affirmed this simple yet profound truth: Bhagwan is eternally present and lovingly accepts the devotion of His devotees. His own life was a living expression of such faith. To stand before the murti, for him, was not to stand before an image; it was to stand in the presence of Bhagwan.

Perhaps this is the deepest purpose of a mandir. It teaches us to see beyond what the physical eyes can perceive. To one person, a murti may appear to be stone or metal. To another, it becomes the most beloved presence in life. The difference lies not merely in the object being viewed, but in the vision with which it is viewed. Mahant Swami Maharaj reminds, "When we enter a mandir, we should not merely look at the beauty of the architecture or admire the artistry of the murti. We should pause, quiet the mind and allow the heart to speak. With faith, humility and devotion, the mandir can become more than a place we visit; it can become a place where we rediscover ourselves."

Therefore, visit the mandir every day and make a personal relationship with God.

(Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

What makes a good teacher?

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

There is a unique concept associated with the teacher-student or Guru-Shishya tradition in India. The Guru or teacher always wishes for the student to succeed, and the student wishes for the teacher's victory. The student wishes for the victory of the big mind or the Guru. It is healthy because if the student feels that he knows more than the teacher, that would mean the learning has stopped, and that his arrogance has killed the wisdom. The student knows even if his/her small mind wins, it is going to be miserable, but if the teacher wins, it is the victory of knowledge, which will only bring good and joy to everyone.

A great teacher understands where the student is coming from and how to guide them step by step. For example, Lord Krishna was such an amazing teacher! He took Arjuna step by step to attain life's final goal. Arjuna was initially very confused. When a student starts evolving, they become confused because they see their concepts breaking apart.

As a student, first, you learn that the sun rises from the east. Later, you are taught about the planets and their movements around the sun. So your concepts break at each step as you grow. Great teachers know this. They do not let the student hold on to a particular concept because each concept is a step towards the ultimate goal. And the concepts have to break to reach the next steps. A good teacher helps students overcome their confusion. And, sometimes, they also create more confusion when needed.

Teaching is a great responsibility. A teacher can be a living example to students because children watch them very carefully. They learn values not only from their parents but also from their teachers. Children observe much more than adults do. They notice when you are calm and composed, and when you are tense or unhappy. And they imitate what they see. This is what makes teaching a more responsible job than it may first appear. Parents may have to deal with one or two children, but a teacher has many children in the classroom, and the situation can be much more challenging and stressful. Aspiring teachers should have a deep trust that everything is being taken care of, and that you have been given a responsibility that you can handle. If you think the task is too big for you, then you may find yourself unable to handle it. Instead, you should have the confidence that the task given to you is appropriate for you, and that you will do your best to fulfil it. To handle it, you need to centre



yourself a few times every day. Just before lunch, you should sit and calm yourself, or just be with nature for a short time. You can start meditation regularly to increase your energy. A few deep breaths will also help to stay centred. Before a teacher can help children become steady, confident and joyful, the teacher has to cultivate that steadiness within. Once that steadiness is in place, the deeper work can begin. A child is born with basic human values, and teachers just need to uncover them. The human values are compassion, co-operation, friendliness, smile, laughter, lightness, helping nature, belongingness, caring for each other, etc. These need to be nourished and brought out. Often teachers need to de-program some of the behaviour children would have learnt at home. Any negativity you find in a child is only on the periphery. It is not their nature. With patience, loving attention and care, you can bring out the positive human values in them.

I remember in my childhood, we had a social science teacher who was very sweet and everybody loved to be in her class, but students would get very less marks in her exams. In contrast, we had a very strict physics teacher, and students were terrified of him, but everyone scored very well in the exam. Great teachers know how to strike the right balance between being loving and being strict. Some children are rebellious. They need more physical contact, encouragement, and pats on the back. They need to feel that they are loved and cared for, and that they belong. On the other hand, sometimes, the teacher can act with a little firmness when dealing with timid children. The aim is to help them stand up and speak out.

Often, the opposite is done. Teachers are strict with rebellious children and liberal with shy ones. Then those behavior patterns continue to remain. The teacher needs to be tough and sweet both; otherwise, they will not be able to guide the student to where they want to take them. Even seemingly small classroom practices can influence the values a child develops. Usually,

children sit in the same place in the classroom every day. This is not a good idea because they become attached to that particular seat. When another child comes and sits there, they quarrel. They begin to feel, "This is my place," and become possessive about it. Instead, children can be encouraged to sit in different places and next to different children at regular intervals. Making them sit in the same place may be more convenient for the teacher, but it deprives children of a sense of belongingness with everyone in the class. It may make things a little more challenging for the teacher, but it is better for the child's growth.

The same principle can be extended to the way children are grouped according to academic performance. Usually, children who rank higher sit together and those who rank lower sit separately. This is not healthy for the classroom atmosphere. Instead, a child who ranks high can be made to sit with a child who needs more help and be encouraged to support them. When children begin relating to one another in this way, they develop a greater sense of belongingness, love and caring for each other.

In Canada, some schools give an award to the friendliest child in the classroom. I think this is a wonderful practice and can be adopted by schools everywhere. It encourages children to be friendly and inclusive with everyone.

Ultimately, the purpose of education is not to fill minds with information. It is to enable the total development of the body and mind. Children also need to be taught values like sharing, caring, non-violence, and developing a sense of belongingness. These values should not just be read about but be made part of their daily lives. Teachers always have a very big role to play in shaping the country's future. They must work together to bring peace and progress to our country. It is the teachers who brought about a wave of change at the time of the country's struggle for independence. They took the responsibility of inspiring the entire nation. Today, too, teachers must inspire children.

Children are like empty transparent vessels; whatever knowledge you fill them with, they will reflect the same and behave in that way. If you fill them with fear and wrong ideas, then they behave as such. But when you give them good ideals and noble virtues, then they grow up to become ideal and responsible citizens. We can pass on ideals to someone else only if we ourselves have imbibed and demonstrated those ideals and virtues. It is thus very important for teachers to walk the talk in their daily lives.